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# The Signs of Not Belonging

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*The balance between belonging and authenticity*

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

TO MY CHILDREN.

*So that you may know, sooner than I knew, that  
belonging was never meant to be paid for with  
your own disappearance.*

*May you love your tables without making  
yourselves smaller at them, and move house on  
the inside without believing that this betrays  
the ones who stayed.*

*It was thinking of you that I learned to remain.*

# Opening note

I wrote this book from the inside, not from above.

I am not writing to you from the height of someone who has solved her life and comes down to teach you. I write to you from the middle of the road, from the same ground where you are standing now, because what you are about to read I recognised first in myself. The feelings this book names I did not go looking for in manuals. I came to know them at the table, in rooms full of people I love, in silences I could not explain. It was from having lived through them, not from having studied them, that the courage came to give them words.

This book lives beside another, *The Seven Veils*. They are siblings, and they cross paths in their vocabulary, but each has its own house. That one speaks of the veils we place between ourselves and life. This one speaks of something quieter and harder to confess: the moment when we stop fitting a place that was good, without anything in that place having changed, and without anyone having done anything wrong.

I want you to know three things before you go in.

The first is that I am not going to try to fix you. There is nothing wrong with you here waiting to be corrected. The not-fitting you

may feel is not a defect, it is a warning, and warnings do not fall silent, they are listened to.

The second is that this is not a book about learning to fit in. If you are looking for a technique to squeeze back into a place where you no longer fit, you will leave here empty-handed, and that is just as well. What I offer you is something else, slower and truer.

The third is that you can come in wherever you like. The seven signs are not steps you climb in order. They coexist. It is natural to recognise yourself in several at once, or to begin with the one that touches you most and only later go back to the start. The book waits for you on any page.

I do not promise you a place of arrival. I promise you honest company along the way, and the one thing I have found that is truly worth it: that you can belong without ceasing to be whole. That there is a way to remain.

I see you. There is more for you than what they taught you to shrink into.

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INTRODUCTION

Why this is not a book  
about learning to fit in



**Y**ou are at the table. It is an ordinary dinner, one of those that repeat year after year without anyone marking them as important. The tablecloth has an old stain that no one notices anymore. There is the usual smell coming from the kitchen, the dish that one particular person has made since you were small, the chairs in their usual places. The voices you know by heart rise and fall around you, and you know, before each sentence ends, who is going to say what. You know each person's laugh. You know where the conversations will land, you know the joke that is coming, you know the silence that follows and who will break it. You are surrounded by people you love. You are present, your whole body there, breaking the bread, passing the salt. And at the same time there is something you cannot name that moves through you slowly: you are no longer the person they are talking to.

Let me stay in that room a moment longer, because it is in the small details that this is recognised. There is a yellow light above the table, the kind that warms everything and never reaches the corners. Someone gets up halfway through to fetch more water, and as they pass they rest a hand on your shoulder, a gesture of always, without thinking, a gesture that for years told you you are home and that tonight reaches your skin in another way, as though it came from very far off. The plates clink, the cutlery scrapes, there are two conversations at once and you follow them both because you always knew how to follow them.

Someone tells a story you have heard thirty times, and at the exact spot where everyone laughs, you laugh too, because your body learned the laugh before you thought of it. It is precisely there, in the middle of the warmth, with someone's hand still warm on your shoulder and the laugh still in your mouth, that the distance arrives. It does not arrive in the cold. It arrives in the warmth. It arrives at the very moment when everything is fine, and it is because it arrives there that it is so hard to understand, because nothing in the room gives you a reason to feel it.

It is not that they say anything wrong. It is not that they treat you badly, or less, or coldly. It is the opposite of that. They treat you exactly as they always have, and that is precisely where it hurts. They speak to you out of who you were, and you answer out of a place that is no longer quite that place, and for an instant you look around the table, from face to face, and you understand something very calm and very difficult at the same time: no one did anything. There was no betrayal, no argument, not a single word said that you could point to and say it broke here. The world goes on exactly the same. The table is the same table. The people are the same people, and they are good, and they love you. What changed is not in the room. It is in you. And you still have no language to explain it, not to them and not to yourself.

Do not think this belongs only to family, to the house you grew up in, to the table of blood. It happens at any table that knew you from



before. Picture the group of lifelong friends, the ones with whom you shared your whole youth, the first heartbreaks, the nights that would not end. They are all sitting in a café that has been yours for fifteen years, and the conversation falls into its usual grooves, the same teasing, the same nicknames, the role each one learned to play within the group.

There is a place kept for you, your place of always, your way of being inside that circle, and for a moment you realise that this place has become tight on you without anyone having shrunk it. Or picture a work lunch, or the wedding of someone dear, a round table with people who saw you in another phase of your life, all asking after things you no longer are, all toasting a version of you that left the room without warning. It is the same movement. The setting changes, who serves and who laughs changes, but the instant is the same: you are in the middle of the warmth of belonging, and the distance arrives all the same, quiet, on the inside.

There is a word that may come to mind at these times, and I want to disarm it straightaway, because it is a word that does a great deal of harm. The word is ungrateful. You think, in the middle of all this: I have people who love me, I have a full table, I have more than so many people dream of having, and even so I feel out of place, so I can only be ungrateful. That word shuts your mouth, because whoever thinks herself ungrateful has no right to complain. But listen well: to feel the not-fitting is not to undervalue what you have.

It is the exact opposite. Only someone who truly loves the place feels this ache, someone who wants to keep it, who is not willing to throw it away. If you did not care, it would not hurt. The ache is the proof of the love, not its absence. Take the word ungrateful out of your mouth. It does not serve you, and it is not true.

This is it. This is the moment the whole book is about. The moment when you stop fitting without yet knowing where you belong. It is not a dramatic scene. It almost never is. It is discreet, almost domestic, it happens between the second course and the dessert, at a dinner that for everyone else was a normal dinner and from which only you come away different. You came away feeling something you have no name for, and the fact that you have no name for it is part of the weight. Because what has no name looks, from the inside, like a defect. It looks like ingratitude. It looks as though something is wrong with you, since everyone else is fine and only you feel out of place at your own table, among your own people.

And you notice that you hide it. Because saying it out loud, there, in that moment, would be to spoil a good thing for a reason you cannot even explain. So you smile, and you carry on, and you take home a weight with no shape, and in the car, on the way back, in the dark, you try to give it a name and find none that does not accuse you. You think you are turning arrogant. You think you believe yourself better. You think you have grown too much, or too little, or in the wrong direction. Every name you try is a way of blaming yourself,

and so you would rather name nothing and pretend it was nothing, and that is how the not-fitting gains its greatest strength, living hidden, without a word, passing itself off as a fault of yours.

I want to tell you straightaway, before anything else, that there is nothing wrong with you. What you feel has a name, and a shape, and even a certain harsh beauty once you learn to look at it. To that misalignment, to that sense of being inside a place and no longer belonging to the place within, I give the name not-fitting. And the ways it appears, its faces, its disguises, the corners of life where it hides, are what I call signs. There are seven. We are going to cross them one by one. But before we go in, there is something you need to know about this book, because it will save you a great deal of time and some disappointment: this is not a book about learning to fit in.

I say it plainly, because that is precisely what almost everything will push you toward. When you begin to feel the not-fitting, the first thing the world offers you, and that you offer yourself, are two answers. They look opposite. They look like the only two possible ways out. And both fail, each in its own way, and this book exists in part to spare you the years that are lost in trying them.

The first answer is to go back to fitting. To retreat. To look at the old version of you, the one everyone knew how to talk to, the one who laughed at the right moments and agreed in the right places and fit without effort, and to try to put her on again. To shrink the shoulders that grew. To swallow the new sentences before you say

them. To feign interest where there is none, to feign agreement where there is already doubt, to lower your voice, to lower yourself. And it works, for a while.

. . .

You buy your place at the table back, and the table gives you the old warmth in return, and for a few months you feel relief, because the relief of belonging is real and should not be dismissed. The problem is not that it does not work. The problem is the price. To go back to fitting, you had to become smaller, and there is a part of you that knows how to count, and it does the sum every day. Each time you make yourself smaller to fit, the crack does not vanish. It only goes inward. And what goes inward does not fall silent, it ferments.

Look closely at the one who chooses this. You surely know someone like that, or you have been that person in a phase. She goes to the same dinners, says the same things, laughs in the same places, and from the outside no one notices anything, everything is in its place, everything is at peace. But there is a fine tiredness building up, the tiredness of someone who plays, every day, a part that has grown small on her. It is an effort no one sees, because the work of shrinking yourself is done on the inside, in silence, before each sentence. You swallow the new opinion.

You hush what you have learned. You agree with your head while inside you disagree, and as you leave you feel vaguely soiled, without quite knowing why, with the sense of having lied without having told a single lie. Because that is what going back to fitting is, deep down: a slow lie, told with tenderness, spoken with good intentions, and costing you a little of yourself each time. So little each time that it does not even hurt in the moment. Only after years do you realise how much you have already given away, and that the person who went back to fitting at the table is barely you anymore.

The second answer is the exact mirror of the first, and that is why it deceives so many who think themselves brave in choosing it. It is to leave the table. To decide that, if you do not fit whole, then you do not fit at all. To cut. To get up, in the literal or the figurative sense, and walk away from the people you love in the name of your own authenticity, with a word on your lips that sounds noble: freedom, truth, faithfulness to yourself. And this too brings relief, at first, the clean relief of someone who has stopped pretending.

But it is a relief that cools quickly, because you discover something no one warned you of: the authenticity bought with solitude is not whole authenticity. It is only half. To be true alone is easy. The hard thing, the thing actually being asked of you, is to be true in the midst of the people who knew you from before. Whoever cuts has not resolved the not-fitting. She has moved it. She has traded the ache

of being out of place at the table for the ache of having no table at all, and that one, in time, tends to weigh more.

Look closely at this one too, because it is prettier on the outside and therefore more treacherous. Whoever cuts leaves with her head held high, with the sense of having done the hard thing, of having been faithful to herself where the others were cowards. And in the first while there is a real euphoria, the wider air of someone who has stopped shrinking, the lightness of no longer having to pretend anything to anyone. But there comes an ordinary Sunday, one of those late winter afternoons when the light goes early, and the house is silent, and there is no table to go to, no voices known by heart, no one's hand resting on a shoulder without thinking.

You realise that the freedom you won has the taste of an empty room. That being whole is worth little if there is no one from before to whom that wholeness matters. The solitude of pure authenticity is a strange solitude, because it is chosen, and being chosen it does not even grant you the right to weep over it out loud. You have to pretend you are fine with it, and that too is a form of pretending, identical to the one you thought you had left behind.

Notice what the two have in common, because that is where the trap is. Both start from the same secret premise: that you cannot have both things. That either you belong, and then you pay with pieces of yourself, or you are wholly you, and then you pay with solitude. The two false answers disagree on everything except the essential, both

believe that belonging and authenticity are enemies, that one lives only by the death of the other, and that adult life is to choose which of them kills you more slowly.

It is a cruel choice, when you see it laid bare like this, because either side takes from you something you love. On one side, you lose yourself. On the other, you lose your people. And what makes the trap so effective is that it disguises itself as maturity. They tell you that to grow up is to accept losing, that adult life is made of renunciations, that no one can have it all. There is a part of that which is true, of course there is. But the premise that belonging and being whole do not fit in the same life is not maturity at all. It is an old mistake, repeated so many times that it passed for wisdom. It is that mistake we are going to undo.

Look hard at the symmetry of the two, because it is perfect, and it is in that perfection that the deception lies. One says stay and disappear. The other says appear and leave. One buys the table with your absence from yourself. The other buys your presence with the absence of the table. They are the same bargain made backwards, and in both there is always one thing missing at the end: either you are missing, or they are. That is why going from one to the other resolves nothing. There are people who spend their lives swinging between the two, years of shrinking, then a furious cut, then the longing and the shrunken return, and so on, like a pendulum that never finds the middle. And it never finds it, because the middle is

not in either of the two ends. It is somewhere else, in a place neither of them can see, because both begin by accepting that the place does not exist.

This book refuses that premise. And it refuses it not with a pretty theory, but with a third verb, which is the verb of everything that follows. Not to go back to fitting. Not to leave the table. To remain. To stay at the table without shrinking. To go on among the people you love, the very same ones, and to be there whole, in your version of now, without asking permission and without fleeing. To remain is the hardest of the three, because it does not have the quick relief of either of the others. It does not give you back the immediate warmth of the one who retreated, nor the solitary cleanness of the one who cut. To remain asks you to bear the tension of being different in the midst of what is the same, for as long as that takes, without resolving the tension quickly through one of the easy exits. It is slow. It is uncomfortable. And it is the only one of the three that costs you neither a piece of yourself nor a person you love.

Notice that it is a verb, and not a place. I do not say to you arrive at the place where you remain, I say remain, in the present, every day, like someone breathing. Because to remain is not something you win once and it is done. It is something you do and redo, dinner after dinner, conversation after conversation. It is to choose to stay at the table when the easier part of you would rather retreat into the old warmth or get up and slam the door. It is to let your version of now



be seen without justifying it, without apologising for it, and without demanding that the others change to accommodate it. It is a balance that never fixes itself for good, and this whole book exists to show it to you from the inside, sign by sign, calmly, without spending it here at the door. For now it is enough to know that it exists, that it is possible, and that it has this simple name: to remain.

. . .

Because this is what, in the end, I want to tell you, and I am going to say it only once, with all the weight it can carry, so that it marks the rest of the pages: the opposite of not-fitting is not fitting in. It is belonging without needing to make yourself smaller.

Read it again, slowly, if you must. It does not say there that you have to choose. It does not say there that belonging is the problem. It says there that a form of belonging exists that costs you nothing of yourself, and that this form is the aim. Not the return to who you were. Not the flight far from everyone. Whole permanence.

And it is because of this that you need to understand what this book is going to ask of you, and what it is going to ask, above all, of your way of looking at the people you love. Because the temptation, when one feels the not-fitting, is to look for someone to blame. It is to say they changed, or they became small, or they never truly saw me. It gives you a clean anger, and anger is comfortable, because it turns

the sadness, which is vague, into a target, which is sharp. But the truth of the not-fitting is harder, and tenderer, and more difficult to carry than any blame: no one failed. The table was good. It is still good for those who are in it.

And it stopped being yours without anything in it changing. The people you love did not betray you by going on being the same. You did not betray them by ceasing to be the same beside them. The two things are true at once, and it is because they are true at once that this is not a story of victims and villains. It is a mourning. The mourning of a place that was good. And what makes this mourning so strange, so shapeless, is that you grieve a place without being able to blame anyone for taking it, because no one took it, it simply stopped serving you, like a childhood house that is still standing and lived in and where your grown body no longer fits.

It is a mourning without rituals, notice, and perhaps that is why it costs so much to recognise it as mourning. When someone dies, there is a wake, there are arms to hold you, there is a date, there are flowers, there is a socially approved way to grieve. When you say goodbye to a version of yourself at the table of the people you love, there is none of that. No one offers you condolences for a loss that cannot even be seen. You go on going to the dinners, you go on embracing the same people, and from the outside nothing has died. On the inside, you said goodbye to a whole place, and you have to grieve it in secret, without witnesses, without anyone to tell you I

know, it must hurt. So let me be the one to tell you, here, before anything else: I know. It must hurt. And you are not exaggerating, nor inventing an ache that does not exist. It exists. It simply had no one, until now, to call it by its name.

You will learn, over these pages, to do something that sounds impossible the first time you hear it: to love the same people and to have stopped being the same person beside them. The two at once, without one cancelling the other. You will learn to say goodbye to a version of yourself without having to say goodbye to a single person. Because that is what this is about. No one died. There is no one to cut off. What has to be let go is not your people, it is an old way of being with your people, and to make that mourning without turning it into a war is the whole learning of this book.

Now, about how you are going to read it. There are seven signs before you, and I am going to ask you not to treat them as steps. They are not a staircase you climb from bottom to top, from the first to the seventh, with the promise that on reaching the end you will be healed. They do not work like that, because life does not work like that. The signs coexist. They are all there at once, overlapping, and you may recognise yourself in several on the same day, in the same hour, at the same table. If I arranged them in this order, and I did arrange them for a reason, it was not by chronology. It was by visibility. They begin with the most socially invisible, the one no one around you notices and that you yourself hide well because it seems

small, and they move, page after page, toward the most solitary, the one lived far from others, in the dark, when no one is watching. From the disguisable to the undisguisable. Not from first to last in time.

What this means, in practical terms, is that you have full permission to come in wherever you like. You can begin with the sign that called you by name when you read the contents. You can jump to the one that tightened your chest without your knowing why. You will lose nothing, because there is no thread that breaks if you read it out of order. Each sign is whole in itself, and at the same time they all speak to one another, and it is likely, almost certain, that in recognising yourself in one you will discover that you were already, without knowing it, inside two others. That is not confusion on your part. It is the way the not-fitting is actually lived, all at once, and not in tidy chapters.

And if you recognise yourself in all of them, do not be frightened, and do not think you are worse off than others. To recognise yourself in many signs at once is not gravity, it is lucidity. It is only that you are seeing more clearly what was always there, all together, without order. The signs are not boxes you have to file yourself whole into one of. They are lenses. You pick one up, and you see a part of the same not-fitting; you set it down and pick up another, and you see another part of the same thing. They do not compete. There is no one that is right for you and six that are wrong. There

are seven ways of looking at the same feeling that moved through you at that table, and you are free to use them all, in whatever order you like, as many times as you need. This book is yours to be read as it serves you, not as I arranged it.

One last thing I owe you, and I want to say it honestly, because honesty is the least I owe you before we go in. This book is not going to give you a place of arrival. There is no destination waiting for you at the end of these pages, no place where everything settles and the not-fitting ends and you never again feel what you felt at that table. I will not promise you that, because it would be a lie, and you deserve better than a comforting lie at the front door. What I can promise you is something else, and it is less than a destination, but perhaps more useful: a way of being inside this without losing yourself. A language for what had no name. And the company of someone who was at that table, who felt exactly what you felt, and who came away not with a solution, but with a way to stay.

One last image, before you turn the page, to take with you. Go back to that table from the beginning, to the yellow light, to the usual smell, to the voices you know by heart. Now imagine that you are there, in your version of now, whole, without shrinking and without getting up. The people are still the same. The dish is the same. The laugh still arrives at the usual spot. And you are present in another way, not pretending an old place, not grieving a lost place, but occupying a new place in the midst of the same warmth. I cannot

yet tell you how one comes to be like that at that table. I can tell you that it is possible, that it costs neither a piece of yourself nor a person you love, and that each of the seven signs ahead is a step toward bringing you nearer to it. Keep this image. It is where we are going.

I see you. I see what you feel at that table, and I see that you have carried it alone, without a name, thinking it was a fault of yours. It is not. And there is far more for you than going back to fitting or walking away. Turn the page. We will begin with the sign that almost no one sees.

S I G N 1



You are present but you  
do not feel that you  
belong

*I am here but I am not home.*



**Y**ou are at the table. The people you love are around you, the conversation flows, someone laughs, someone serves you more without asking, and you answer at the right moment, you say what is expected of you, and nothing in this scene would justify what you feel. That is the problem. What you feel has nothing to hold on to. It is not loneliness, because you are surrounded. It is not sadness, because nothing bad has happened. It is a fine distance, almost translucent, between you and the moment you are living. You are present. You are not home.

Notice the gesture of the one who serves you more without asking. It is a small gesture, and it is perhaps because it is so small that it says everything. That hand that brings the plate toward you and fills it again, without waiting for an answer, knows you. It knows what you like, it knows the amount, it knows that you say yes. It has done this for years, perhaps since you were a child and your place at the table was decided before you could walk. You thank them, and you eat, and everything is right. Except there is a part of you that notices that gesture the way one looks at an old photograph of oneself: you recognise the person, you know it is you, and at the same time you no longer find yourself entirely there. You were loved exactly like this your whole life. Today that same love, which is still exact, arrives at a place that moved without warning.

Think of one particular dinner. Not just any dinner, one in particular, the kind that repeats with small variations over too



many years to count. The tablecloth is the same, or it is the same colour. There is the one who always sits in the same place and the one who always arrives late and the one who always tells the same story, laughing as though it were the first time. There is a moment, halfway through, when everyone is talking at once and the noise is warm and familiar, and it is exactly at that moment, when the warmth of the family is at its height, that the distance arrives deepest. It does not arrive when you are alone. It arrives in the middle of the noise of love.

Think, too, of a reunion after a long time apart. The kind prepared weeks in advance, with phone calls to arrange who brings what, with cousins you have not seen since who knows when, with someone who came from far away and whom everyone wants to embrace first. You arrive, and there is that instant at the door when they press you against a chest you know by heart, when they say your name with a joy that cannot be faked, when they look you up and down and say you are just the same, that you have not changed at all. It smells of food that is only made on these days. There is a tablecloth laid with care, glasses brought from another house, chairs borrowed to fit everyone in.

You enter that wave of people who love you, and for a while you let yourself go, because there is real joy there, you are not inventing it. Except halfway through, when the reunion reaches its fullest point, when everyone is talking over everyone and someone gets up to

take a group photograph and pulls you into the middle, you feel that fine distance settle in again, sharper now for all the love around. They all gather for you, with you, around you, and you are there, at the centre of the embrace, feeling outside it. Not because they want you outside. Because a part of you has already left, and no reunion, however full, calls it back.

You remember a photograph. Perhaps it is in a frame in the living room of whoever raised you, perhaps it is kept in a box that opens now and then at the end of an afternoon of tidying. It is a family photograph, the kind where everyone poses leaning against one another, and there you are, younger, with a smile you do not have to feign. When you look at it, you feel two things at once, and they do not contradict each other, though they seem to. You feel tenderness for that scene, because it was real, because that joy was not staged.

You feel a strange longing, a longing for yourself, for the person who was so deep inside that embrace that she did not even need to think about it. You look at that girl and you see that she fit. She fit whole, without effort, without distance. You see, in the same instant, that you are no longer quite her, and that no one in that photograph noticed, because change does not show in a portrait. On the outside you are still the one smiling there. On the inside you moved house, and the photograph kept the old address.

There was a time when someone, leafing through those same photographs with you, said, do you remember how you were? You

said, I remember. That person said, you are just the same. You smiled and said nothing, because what you wanted to say did not fit there. You wanted to say no, that you were not just the same, that something deep had shifted, but that to say it would spoil that tender moment of two people looking at the past. So you swallowed the sentence and kept it, the way one keeps so many, and the silence that fell inside you was not a lie and was not weakness. It was care. It was the way you found to protect a joy without betraying yourself. But it had a price, and the price was one more layer of distance between what you show and what you are.

It is hard to explain to anyone who has never felt it, and harder still to explain to the one sitting beside you. How do you tell someone you love that being with them no longer brings you home, without it sounding like an accusation? There are no words that say it without wounding. So most of us fall silent, smile, comply, and leave that room with a tiredness that matches nothing of what happened there. The very particular tiredness of someone who was present without having been there.

There is an exact instant, in the middle of the gathering, when this becomes almost physical. You are listening to someone tell a story, you nod, you ask the right question at the right spot, and for a second, just one, you hear your own voice as if it came from far off, as if it were not quite you speaking but someone who knows your part very well speaking for you. It is only a second, and it passes, and

no one notices, because on the outside everything is in place. But you noticed. You noticed that there was a moment when you were performing yourself instead of being there. That moment, repeated countless times over a night, over years of nights, is that invisible thing at work. It is not that you do not like those people. You do. It is that between you and them a small interpreter has installed itself, a version of you that answers for you while the real one stays a step behind, watching. To watch your own life, even a life surrounded by love, is a very particular kind of weariness.

You know that tiredness better than you know its name. It is the tiredness of coming home after a Sunday lunch, closing the door behind you, and sitting in the dark for an instant before turning on the light, not understanding why a day in which you made no effort at all left you so empty. You carried no weights. You argued with no one. You even laughed. Yet you come home like someone who worked a whole shift at something invisible. The invisible thing has a name, and we will get to it. For now it is enough to know that it exists, and that you are not inventing it, and that this exhaustion with no apparent cause is itself one of the first forms in which this sign speaks to you.

There was a time, and there will surely be many, when someone at the table looked at you and said, with all the tenderness in the world, you are always so well. Or said, it is so good that you never change. Or said, with you everything is so easy. You smiled, and you thanked

them, because it was a compliment, it was meant as a compliment, it came wrapped in real love. Except that sentence, said to please you, fell inside you like a sentence handed down. It is so good that you never change. There is a part of you, the part no one at the table sees, that trembles in silence, because it knows that you changed, that you are changing, that you cannot not change, and that the place it occupies there was built on the promise that it would always stay the same. The tenderest compliment became, without anyone meaning it to, the exact description of the cage.

The first thing the mind does, faced with this, is look for someone to blame, because a discomfort without a cause is harder to bear than a discomfort with an address. There are only two possible addresses. Either there is something wrong with me, or there is something wrong with them. We spend years swinging between the two. One day we are the ungrateful ones, the difficult ones, the ones who are never satisfied. The next, it was they who became small, who stopped, who no longer keep up with us. But the truth of the not-fitting is harder than either of these, and that is why we flee it. The truth is that no one failed. The table was good. It is still good for those who are in it. It stopped being yours without a single thing in it having changed. The not-fitting gives us no villain. It takes even that consolation, and makes us suffer with no one to point to.

See how the mind works to give you someone to blame, because the alternative seems unbearable to it. If there is someone to blame,

there is a solution: if the fault is yours, you correct yourself; if the fault is theirs, you withdraw with reason on your side. In either case there is a path, there is a possible action, there is an end to the discomfort. What the mind cannot bear is the possibility that there is nothing to correct and no one to blame, because that leaves it without work, without a lever, with nothing to do but feel.

To feel, without being able to fix, is the thing that costs us most. So we prefer blame, even our own, to mourning. Blame gives us the illusion of control. Mourning asks only that we accept a loss no one caused. A loss without anyone to blame is the hardest to grieve, because there is nowhere to set down the complaint, no one to forgive, no possible scene of reconciliation. There is only a place that was good and stopped being yours, and the slow, quiet work of letting it go without turning it into someone's crime.

Look closely at that swinging, because it is where most of life's time is lost. In the morning you wake convinced that the problem is you, that you have become demanding, cold, complicated, that you have lost the simple capacity to be content with what you have. You feel ashamed. You promise yourself to try harder, to go back to being the one who was content. In the afternoon, after another lukewarm gathering, the scale tips the other way, and suddenly it is them, their lack of depth, the way they got stuck in the same conversations and the same certainties, and you feel an irritation that immediately afterward shames you as much as the earlier shame did.

So, morning and afternoon, day after day, you go from accused to accuser and from accuser to accused, and what never occurs to you, because it is the hardest possibility of all, is that perhaps there is no crime at all. That no one needs to be wrong for you to no longer fit there. The mind refuses this for a long time, because someone to blame, even if it is you, is easier to inhabit than a mourning with no one responsible.

It is precisely because you love that it costs so much. If you did not love, you would leave and that would be that, without this tightening, without this secret, without this division that wears you out. The not-fitting between strangers is solved with a goodbye that does not hurt. It is the not-fitting within love that has no easy way out, because any move looks like a betrayal: to stay pretending betrays you, to truly leave seems to betray the people you love. You stay caught in the middle, and the middle is a tiring place to inhabit, and the only way to breathe there, for as long as you have to be there, is to stop demanding of yourself an answer you do not yet have. You do not have to resolve today the knot between your love for them and the truth about yourself. You only have to stop pretending the knot does not exist. To recognise it is already to rest a little, because half the weight came from your denying it.

So this is not what we so often call it. It is not arrogance, though you catch yourself wondering whether you are setting yourself above the others. It is not a lack of love, and that is the cruellest confusion

of all, because you love those people, and it is precisely because you love them that it hurts not to feel whole beside them. The hardest not-fitting to carry does not happen between strangers. It happens inside what is dearest to you, and that is why it is almost always lived in secret. There is no one to tell it to without seeming to undo what everyone around you still believes to be whole.

Think of a Christmas. There are few places where this secret tightens more than at Christmas, because Christmas is the table raised to its highest power, the table with lights, the table with the memory of all the other tables. There is the tree in the same corner. There are the dishes that only leave the cupboard once a year. There is the absence of someone who has gone, felt in the place no one fills.

. . .

There is you, in the middle of all this, opening a gift chosen with care by someone who loves you, saying thank you, it is lovely, this is exactly what I wanted, and feeling at the same time, beneath the real gratitude, that fine distance tightening. Because the gift was thought up for the person they still think you are. It is a gift for the earlier version. There is no way to say this. There is no way to return so genuine an affection with the news that it is no longer addressed to whoever is here. So you keep the gift, and you keep the truth, and the secret grows one more year inside you, among the lights.



There is the Sunday phone call, or the midweek one, the one that always follows the same route. They ask if everything is well, and you say yes, everything is well. They ask about work, and you answer what one answers. There is a short silence, and then someone says, so when are you coming to see us? You promise that you will, soon, one of these days. You hang up, and you stay with the phone in your hand for an instant, with a feeling you cannot name, because the conversation was tender, it was truly tender, no one hurt you.

Yet there is something in that so when are you coming, that stirs a deep place, because you know that going there no longer gives you back what it used to give you. You go out of love, and it is right to go. But you no longer go home. You go to visit a house where you once lived, and that still keeps you, and that you still love, and that stopped being, through no one's fault, the place where you set yourself down whole. The call always ends the same tender way. It is what comes after it, inside you, that changed.

There was a Christmas, or a birthday, or a lunch with no occasion at all, when someone said a sentence that stayed with you. Perhaps it was your mother, or an aunt, or whoever plays that part in your family, looking around the table and saying, with shining eyes, it is so good that we are all together, it is so good that this never changes. There was a silence inside you, a silence no one heard, because a part of you wanted to say, quietly, but I changed. You did not say it.

You smiled, you raised your glass, you joined the toast. That is your loyalty in its purest state: to toast a permanence that no longer contains you, so as not to spoil the joy of those who still live in it whole. There is nothing false in that toast. There is too much love to spoil it with the truth.

When you really look beneath this feeling, calmly, without the haste to correct it, you rarely find rejection. You find misalignment, and they are very different things. Rejection is someone closing the door on you. Misalignment is you going on entering through a door that no longer leads to your house. The place you occupy at that table belonged to an earlier version of you, and you are no longer entirely that version, though you do not yet know who you are in her place. You did not lose your house. You moved house on the inside, and you have not yet had time to tell anyone, not even yourself.

It is worth lingering on this distinction, because almost everything that follows is decided in it. Rejection hurts in a way we know: it hurts because someone wanted us out, because a door closed against us, because we were weighed on someone else's scale and found wanting. Rejection has an agent. Someone did it. So even in the pain there is a certain clarity in it, there is a place to set the hurt. Misalignment has none of this. No one closed the door on you. The door is still open, wide open, and that is exactly why it costs so much. You go in when you like, you are warmly received, there is always a place waiting with your name on it.

Even so, once through the door, you are no longer home. You were not cast out. You changed address on the inside, and the old house, faithful, goes on keeping your room exactly as you left it, waiting for a version of you that no longer returns. To confuse one thing with the other is the source of half the suffering of this sign. You think you were rejected, and what happened was that you grew in a direction the house did not follow. They are different aches. The first asks you to forgive someone. The second asks only that you recognise that no one did anything.

Take a small example, so that the difference stops being an idea and takes on a body. Imagine you walk into a room and someone, on seeing you, changes the subject, lowers their voice, slowly turns their back. That is rejection, and you would know it in your skin, without needing an explanation: there is an agent, there is an intention, there is a clear place where it hurts. Now imagine the exact opposite. You walk into the same room, and everyone lights up, they make space for you, they call you by your usual pet name, they kept your place with your name on it, someone says right away sit here next to me. You are received with everything a person could wish to be received with.

It is precisely in the middle of that warm reception that you feel the distance. There is nothing to forgive, because no one did anything to you, they did everything good. Rejection slams the door in your face and at least gives you the clarity of pain. Misalignment opens the

door wide, sits you in the best place, fills your plate, and leaves you feeling, in the midst of all that welcome, that the place where they welcome you with so much love is no longer the place where you live. On the outside they are opposite situations. On the inside, the second costs more, because in rejection there is someone to hate and in misalignment there is only an exact love arriving at an address that changed.

That is why you so often misread what you feel. On some ordinary night, around the table, someone makes a joke at your expense, one of the old ones, repeated since you were small, about some habit of yours or some flaw of yours that the family kept and cherishes. Everyone laughs, fondly, without malice. You laugh too, on the outside, but inside there is a disproportionate tightening, a sudden urge to get up and leave, and right after it an equally sudden shame at feeling something so large in the face of something so small. What wounds you there is not the joke. The joke is old and you always put up with it.

What wounds you is that the joke is addressed to a person you no longer are, and each laugh around the table confirms, without meaning to, that they still see that person when they look at you. They are not rejecting you. They are loving, with all tenderness, a version of you that left. You, who do not yet know how to name this, read the tightening as hurt, when the tightening is in truth mourning. It is the difference between someone not liking who you

are and someone going on liking very much who you no longer are. The second hurts in a way that has no possible complaint, because there is no one to make it to.

There is a reason we go on sitting in places that no longer serve us, and that reason has an old name. Loyalty. We stay there out of loyalty to the family that taught us where we should sit, to the role of the one who cares and endures and is always available, to the version of us that was strong and capable and that everyone learned to expect. Loyalty, in the end, to the whole system that told us, long before we had a voice to disagree, who we should be in order to be loved there. These loyalties are not defects. They are bonds, and it was they that gave you a place when you did not yet know how to build one alone. That is why they tighten without being seen, and that is why you feel ungrateful just for noticing the tightening. But to notice is not to betray. To notice is only an honesty that had long been overdue.

Look closely at each of these loyalties, because they live in concrete gestures and not in ideas. There is loyalty to the role of the one who cares. You are the one who calls to find out if everything is well. You are the one who senses, from the tone of voice on the phone, that someone is not well before they say so. You are the one who stays to the end tidying the kitchen while the others are already in the living room, the one who says do not worry, I will handle this, go and rest.

You have done this for so long that no one asks anymore whether you want to, because no one imagines you might not want to. Care has become your address at the table. What no one sees, not even you at times, is that this care, which is real and is born of real love, is also the seat that holds you. As long as you are the one who handles everything, you have a guaranteed place, indispensable, unquestionable. To let go of even one end of that role seems, deep down, to risk the whole place.

Look at a scene of that loyalty. The lunch is over, the plates are still to be cleared, and there is that moment when everyone slowly gets up and drifts toward the living room, the coffee, the sofa, and you, without anyone deciding it out loud, stay. You stay stacking plates, scrubbing pots, putting the leftovers in boxes. Someone appears at the kitchen door and says, leave that, come to the living room, and you answer, I am coming, just a minute, and you do not come, because there is always one more minute. The truth is that a part of you chose to stay there. Not only out of duty. Out of refuge.

Because in the kitchen, with your hands busy, you have a clear place, a function, a reason to be that no one questions, and that is easier than going to the living room and sitting in the middle of the conversation feeling that fine distance with nothing to do with your hands. Care became, without your noticing, a place where you hide from the distance. To serve is your way of belonging without having to expose how much you no longer belong. That is why letting go of

the dish towel costs far more than it seems. To let it go would be to sit in the living room unarmed, without a role, and to risk the distance being seen.

There is loyalty to the strong version. The one who never weighs anything down, who never needs anything, who is always well, with you everything is so easy. You built that version of yourself over years, and it served, it suited everyone, you included. You learned early that being easy was a way to be loved without being a burden, and that being a burden was a risk better not taken. So you solved alone what cost you. You smiled on days when you had no wish to. You always brought the light part of the conversation and kept the heavy part for your own darkness. Now, when a part of you needed precisely to set the weight down at the table, to say I am not well, to be difficult for an instant, you discover there is no place for it, because your place was tailored to fit someone who never needs. The strong version is loyal, and its loyalty is a soft chain. No one asked you to put it on every day. You put it on, out of love, and now it wears you.

You remember a time when that strong version spoke for you without asking your permission. You were going through a hard patch, the kind that does not fit into a sentence on the phone, and someone from home called just to check. How are you?, they asked, and you, in an instant, before you even thought, answered, I am great, everything is going well. There was a silence on the other end,

and then the person said, that is good, you are a rock, and you said, yes, I am, and you laughed a little, and changed the subject.

You hung up and stayed looking at the phone, with the whole truth left unsaid, rotting inside your chest, realising you had lied out of love, so as not to weigh anyone down, so as not to spoil the calm of someone who called full of good intention. It was in that instant that you saw the soft chain at work. No one silenced you. You silenced yourself, and called it being strong, and the person who loves you hung up at ease, believing you well. The strong version had played its part once more: you had spared everyone, except yourself.

There is also loyalty to the role of being the person no one worries about. Notice the small portraits in which it lives. You are the one of whom it is said, with pride, that one gives us no trouble at all. You are the one who always sorts herself out, who finds a house, a job, solutions, without ever asking for anything, the one who calls to solve other people's problems and never to unload her own. In a family where there is always someone who needs attention, you built your place by being the one who does not need, and it worked, and no one ever had to look very hard at you again, because it was settled, without anyone settling it, that you were taken care of.

The cost of this loyalty only shows late, on the day you need to be seen and discover there is no place for it at the table, because your place was tailored to fit someone who can do without being seen. To ask now would be to contradict years of serene competence, would



be to frighten those who never saw you fragile. So you go on not needing, and needing in secret, and the loyalty to the role charges itself in solitude, which is the quietest form weariness has of arriving.

. . .

There is, beneath them all, the deepest loyalty of all, the loyalty to the family itself as it is, to its way of seeing, to its way of measuring a good life. It was there that you learned what counts. You learned what it is to be trustworthy, what it is to value family, what it is not to do foolish things, what a serious person is. Those measures entered you so early, so long before you had words to discuss them, that for a long time they did not seem like the measures of a family. They seemed the truth. They seemed the ground itself. To notice that perhaps there were other ways to live, other measures, other grounds, is one of the most solitary things there is, because it is to begin to leave a mother tongue without yet having another to speak.

There is a concrete moment when this is felt. It is when you tell of a choice of yours, a choice that did you good, and you see on the face of whoever raised you not disapproval, which you would know how to face, but a tender incomprehension, an and are you happy with that?, said without any malice, that even so makes you feel, for a second, a foreigner at your own table. They did not tell you that you

were wrong. They told you only, without meaning to, that you no longer speak exactly the language of home. You, out of loyalty, lower your voice, and round off the choice, and make it fit better into what they understand, to spare them and to spare yourself. It is one more small act of fidelity to the old ground. It is one more millimetre of distance.

Notice how none of these loyalties is a mistake. There is no moment here when someone imprisoned you on purpose. There was, rather, a child who needed to belong, and who learned, with the tender intelligence of one who is small and loves her own, exactly what she had to be for the table to open her a place. That child got it right. She belonged. She was loved. The price reveals itself only much later, when the person she became no longer fits the mould that made her belong, and discovers that the mould, meanwhile, has turned into skin. This is not undone with anger. There is no one to scold. There is only an old bond asking, with the greatest gentleness, to be reconsidered.

Perhaps this is the most exact image of what happens in this first sign. The soul has already got up and left the room, and the body goes on sitting at the table out of respect for the past. Not out of hypocrisy. Out of respect. There is a part of you that has gone, that needs something else it cannot yet name, and there is another part, loyal and tender, clinging to the memory of what that table once was, that refuses to wound those who stayed. You go on sitting out of

love for a time that truly existed, that you are not inventing. To be divided like this, present in the body and absent at the centre, is what wears you out without your having done anything visible.

It is here, at last, that the tiredness is explained. That exhaustion without cause, the one of coming home in the dark, the one of the invisible shift, is born precisely of this division. You are not tired of the table. You are tired of holding yourself in two places at once, with the body filling one place and the centre already elsewhere. Imagine the effort, repeated at each gathering, of putting the soul back in a chair it has already risen from, and of holding it there, by force, for hours, so that no one notices it left. That is the invisible work. That is the shift. You come away from each dinner like someone who spent the night holding a door that wants to open, and no one around you sees the door, and no one sees the effort, and so no one understands your exhaustion, and you, who do not understand it well either, end up calling it a defect of yours. It is not a defect. It is the cost, in the body, of a loyalty that no longer has anywhere to rest whole.

Here is where most books would tell you to do something. Get up from the table, or sit back down for real. But not every truth asks for immediate movement. Some ask only for enough company not to be mistaken again for a defect. This is one of them. What this sign asks of you is not a decision. It is a change of fidelity, so silent that no one at the table would notice it.

I am not going to ask you to get up. I am not going to promise you that on the other side of this page there is a new place waiting for you, all tidy, with your name right this time. That would be a lie, and a lie of the worst kind, the kind that trades the comfort of a hard truth for the haste of a solution. I do not know where you are going, and you do not know yet either, and it is right that it should be so for now. There is a wisdom in not running out of a place before we have grieved it well and truly. To get up halfway, in haste, is a way of fleeing the mourning, and whoever flees the mourning carries it everywhere afterward, to the next table, to the next house, to the next version of yourself. So there is no hurry. What there is, and it is a great deal, is a different way of sitting.

Notice that this change of fidelity takes nothing from anyone. It is not a choice between you and them, as though fidelity were a fixed quantity that, given to one part, would be missing from the other. It is exactly the opposite. As long as you are at war with the part of you that noticed, you spend on that war the energy you should be giving to the people you love, and so you arrive at each gathering already tired, already divided, already half. To be faithful to the part that noticed is, in the end, to stop wasting your strength on an endless inner fight, and it is that stopping that gives you back, paradoxically, more presence, not less. The person who has stopped fighting with herself is the person who can finally look at those at the table with whole eyes. You do not become colder by being faithful to yourself.

You become more capable of tenderness, because the tenderness that was busy hiding a truth is suddenly free to love.

Because perhaps the first fidelity is not to the table, nor to the place you occupy at it, nor to the version of you that fit there. Perhaps the first fidelity is to the part of you that noticed it is no longer home. It was that part that endured in silence while you called it ingratitude. It was that part that went on warning you, without words, dinner after dinner, that something essential had changed. To be faithful to it does not mean leaving the table. It means only to stop calling it wrong. It means letting it exist without apologising to it.

Think of what changes when you stop calling it wrong. On the outside, nothing. You go on arriving at the dinners, you go on serving, you go on laughing at the same stories told for the hundredth time, you go on saying thank you for the gifts tailored to who you no longer are. No one at the table notices the slightest difference. Yet, on the inside, the greatest change of all has happened. You have stopped being at war with yourself. You have stopped spending half your energy trying to convince the part that noticed that it is mistaken.

Before, at every distance you felt, the punishment came right behind it, the shame, the effort to erase it. Now, when the distance arrives, you let it arrive. You do not correct it. You do not punish yourself for it. You simply know, quietly, beneath the conversation, it is true, I am no longer entirely home, and it is all right that it should be so. That

sentence, said only inwardly, without accusing anyone, is the change of fidelity. It costs nothing to those at the table. It costs everything, and gives back everything, to the one who makes it.

When you stop calling it wrong, you finally see where all the suffering was born. It was not born of the not-fitting. The not-fitting, in itself, is almost silent. The suffering was born of the effort, repeated at each gathering, to convince the soul that it is still sitting where it no longer is. It was that effort that wore you out, not the table. It was the performance, not the distance.

There is a Sunday lunch that serves to understand this, and it is likely you have already lived it without giving it this name. You arrive with the intention, decided in the car, to be well, to be present, not to let the distance win this time. You sit down. You smile. Shall I serve you more?, someone asks, and before you answer your plate is already full, because the question was only a courtesy, the answer is known by heart. You eat. You follow the conversation. Halfway through, without warning, you catch yourself doing something you have done for so long that you no longer notice it: watching yourself.

Measuring whether you are smiling enough, whether your interest looks genuine, whether anyone will notice that a part of you is far away. You are at the table and you are, at the same time, on the outside watching yourself at the table, making sure the performance has no flaws. It is exhausting work, and it is all invisible, and it is all

yours. No one asked you to do it. You do it out of love, so that no one is hurt by your inner absence. You come away from there, once again, with that tiredness without cause, which after all had a cause the whole time: you spent the lunch performing a person to protect the people you love from the truth that you are no longer quite her.

Say this slowly, because it is the key to almost everything. It is not the distance that hurts. It is the fight against the distance. It is not the fact that you no longer fit that weighs. It is the work of pretending that you still fit. The pain you have been carrying, and that you took for the pain of not belonging, is in truth the pain of an endless performance, of an actress who refuses to leave the stage long after the play has changed. On the day you let go of the performance, and not the table, the table, notice, you discover that you can stay sitting exactly where you were, with the same people, in the same chair, and breathe. Because you are no longer sustaining a lie. You are only inhabiting, with honesty and with tenderness, a place you know has changed. That is a kind of peace no flight would give you.

You do not have to know, today, where the part of you that got up has gone. You do not have to put anything in order at the end of this chapter. You can stay sitting, if you like, and there are good reasons to want to, because you love those who are there. But you stay in another way. No longer pretending that you still fit, and not yet preparing to leave. You go on doing the hardest and tenderest thing

this first sign allows: saying goodbye to a version of yourself without saying goodbye to a single person. What ended was a place. None of the loves ended. There is a way of remaining at the table knowing this that is neither pretence nor flight. It is only the tenderness of one who honours an old house without forcing herself to live in it forever.

Perhaps you need time to believe that this is not coldness. There is an old, loyal voice that will call this peace selfishness, that will say that putting your truth before their comfort is a way of abandoning them. Listen to that voice with tenderness, because it comes from the same love that taught you to stay. But do not grant it. To be faithful to the part of you that noticed is not to turn your back on anyone.

It is the only way not to live, from here on, pretending, and pretending is not a gift, pretending is a debt that is charged later, in bitterness, in absence, in abrupt and ill-explained departures that wound far more than a serene honesty. The people who go on pretending in their places are the ones who one day get up suddenly, with accumulated hurt, and break the door on their way out. The one who allows herself the truth on the inside, without accusing anyone, is the one who can stay with lightness, or leave with care, when and if the hour comes. Inner honesty is not the opposite of loyalty. It is its grown-up form.



Notice, finally, those who stay there. They did nothing wrong. The table they gave you was good, it was truly good, it gave you root and name and a place in the world when you did not yet know how to walk. The hands that served you more without asking served real love. The sentence that felt like a verdict, it is so good that you never change, was said out of real love by someone who thought they knew you whole. There is no villain in this story, and that is its greatest difficulty and its greatest beauty.

The mourning of this first sign is the mourning of a place that was good. You are not leaving behind people who failed you. You are leaving behind a version of yourself that fit there with joy, and learning, slowly, to love exactly the same people having stopped being, beside them, exactly the same person. It is possible. It is the tenderest thing there is. Stay sitting for as long as you need. On the inside, in silence, without wounding anyone, begin to be faithful to the part of you that has already noticed it was time to move house.

S I G N 2



You begin to shrink  
yourself to fit

*Maybe I am exaggerating.*



**Y**ou notice it first in something small. You were about to say something, you had the sentence almost on your lips, and you swallowed it. It was not an important sentence. It was only a different opinion about a film, or a tiredness you felt like confessing, or a no to an invitation that meant nothing to you. You swallowed it, you smiled, you agreed, and the conversation went on without even noticing your absence inside it. No one told you to be quiet. There was no threat, no punishment, not even a look. You were the one who decided, in a calculation so quick you did not even feel it happen, that the sentence would cost more than it was worth. You kept it. The way you have kept so many others for so long that you no longer know where you put them.

To grasp the scale of this, count a day. Any day, with nothing special about it. Count the times you sweetened an answer before giving it, the times you laughed at a joke that did not amuse you, the times you said yes with your head while inside you shook it no. Count the times they asked how you were and you answered well, thank you by reflex, without even checking whether it was true. If you count honestly, you will be frightened by the number. Not because there is a single grave gesture there, there is not, but because they are so many, and so automatic, that you realise it is no longer something you do. It is something you are. You shave yourself down before you have even fully woken, and you go on shaving yourself down until you fall asleep, and not even in dreams do you fully let yourself be.

That is how it begins, and that is why it takes us so long to notice. It does not begin with a great renunciation. No one gives up the soul all at once, with ceremony, before witnesses. It begins with a small edit. You cut an adjective here, you soften a disagreement there, you turn a no into a maybe and a maybe into all right. You shave the edges off your way of being until it fits without noise into the space they leave you. Each cut, on its own, is so tiny, so reasonable, so easy to justify, that it would be ridiculous to make a drama of it. Who is going to get angry over a comment let slip? Who respects herself and makes a scene over an invitation she said yes to without meaning it?

Think of a work meeting, the kind where you are sitting at the table with eight other people and there is some matter on the table. You see something no one else seems to be seeing. You have the idea formed, you know it is good, you even feel its warmth rising, that clean certainty of someone who understood something before the others. You open your mouth, and you close it. You wait for the right moment, which never comes. You tell yourself you will let someone more senior lead, that perhaps it is not your turn, that maybe someone has already thought of this and dismissed it.

The meeting ends, the decision is made without your idea in it, and two days later someone else says exactly what you had thought and everyone finds it brilliant. You smile, and you agree that it is brilliant, and inside there is a dull sinking that has no name. It is not

envy. It is the recognition that you were present without being there, that you took up the chair but not the place, that once again you left your most alive part at the door so as not to disturb the room.

So you say to yourself the sentence that gives this sign its title. Maybe I am exaggerating. You say this to yourself when the discomfort rises, when there is some tightening in your chest at the end of an afternoon in which you were impeccable and pleasant and available and did not say a single thing that was truly yours. Maybe I am exaggerating. It is a sentence that looks like humility and is, in truth, the mechanism that keeps you shrinking. Because as long as you think you are exaggerating, you do not have to look at what you are actually doing. What you are doing is no exaggeration at all. It is a real shrinking, slow, daily, of everything that takes up space inside you.

Notice how the sentence works. Maybe I am exaggerating is a sentence that always turns against you, never in your favour. It gives you no slack, it gives you guilt. It does not ask you what you feel, it orders you to silence what you feel in the name of a measure that comes from outside. When you say you are exaggerating, what you are in fact doing is comparing your pain to a ruler that is not yours, the ruler of someone who never felt what you feel and therefore discounts it. The sentence asks you to doubt your own thermometer. A person who no longer trusts her own thermometer goes through the world frozen, thinking she is well, or burning with

fever, thinking she is only a little warm, because she has unlearned how to read herself. Exaggeration, notice, is an accusation that needs a witness. The only witness you call is yourself, against yourself, always on the side of whoever wants you smaller.

There is something else this sentence does, more cunning still. It robs you of the company of your own pain. When you say maybe I am exaggerating, you shut the door on telling anyone what is going on, because you have already decided beforehand that it is not worth it, that you would be making a storm in a teacup, that the other person would think, rightly, that you are dramatising. So you fall silent. And in falling silent, you stay alone with something that, said out loud to someone who would truly listen, might turn out to be far less mad than it seems from the inside.

The things we keep with shame grow in the dark. The ones we say wilt a little in the light, or at least are shared. But the sentence maybe I am exaggerating keeps everything in the dark, always, because it convinces you, before you even open your mouth, that there is nothing there worth hearing. So you go on rotting inside with something that might be resolved by a conversation, only because you refuse to admit that it exists, in the name of a humility that has nothing of humility about it.

It is worth saying now, before going on, what it is that gets betrayed here, because there is a misunderstanding that makes people feel worse than they need to. When you shrink yourself to fit, you did not

betray right away your deep identity, your values, what you believe in the depths of the depths. That tends to last longer, hidden, intact, waiting. What gets betrayed first is subtler and rawer. It is the impulse. The urge to speak before you have examined and approved it. The urge to disagree when you disagree.

The urge to rest when the body asks for rest and not when the schedule allows. The urge to ask, to want out loud, to take up your natural size in a room without asking permission to do so. It is the impulse that falls silent first. The impulse is precisely the part of you that has not yet passed through the filter of pleasing. It is your reaction before you have made it presentable. That is why it is so grave to lose it without noticing: it is as though you had switched off the most honest signal you have, the one that appears before any calculation.

The impulse is not the opinion. It is worth not confusing them, because the confusion makes you afraid of it without reason. The opinion is a construction, thought out, weighed, articulated, and that one you can keep for another time without losing anything. The impulse comes before that. It is your body leaning a millimetre forward when someone says something that touches you. It is the slight opening of the mouth when the urge to speak arrives. It is the heat that rises to your face when you feel an injustice before you even have words for it.

The impulse is life manifesting in you in real time, without revision. When you silence it too many times, you are not only losing a sentence here and there. You are teaching your own body not to lean, your own mouth not to open, your own face not to flush. You are domesticating the part of you that was wild and honest, and domestication, contrary to how it looks, is not peace. It is a caged animal that has learned to stop jumping at the fence, and that therefore no longer even knows there is a far side.

There is a difference between keeping something by choice and keeping it by reflex, and it is in that difference that this whole sign lives. To keep by choice is maturity. It is to look at the impulse, recognise it, and decide, with clarity, that this is not the place or the moment for it to come out, and to stay whole in the decision. To keep by reflex is another thing. It is the sentence not even reaching the mouth. It is the filter dropping so fast, so far ahead of you, that you do not even get to have the sentence to decide about it. Choice presumes there was someone choosing.

The reflex spared you the process. That is why so many women who shrink themselves think themselves, on top of it all, balanced and sensible, because they confuse the reflex with the choice, and take for maturity what is only well-trained fear. The question that dismantles the confusion is simple and hard: if you wanted to, you could say it. If there were only your will and no other calculation, it would come out. If the honest answer is no, that you no longer even



know whether you could, then you are not choosing to keep it. You are being kept by a mechanism that no longer asks your permission.

Think of some ordinary scene, the kind with nothing special about it. A Sunday lunch, let us say. Someone says something you do not agree with, a generalisation about people you know well and that this person does not know at all. You feel the impulse rise, the clear urge to say it is not quite like that. In that half-second, faster than this is read, everything happens. You assess the cost. You weigh the Sunday, the peace of the table, the face of the one who spoke, the chance of it turning into an argument, the reputation for being difficult that you already have or fear having.

You decide it is not worth it. You agree with your head, or you stay quiet, which comes to almost the same, and the impulse withdraws, hurt, and learns something it should not have to learn: that here it is not safe to appear whole. At the table where they love you, notice carefully, at the table where they love you, the impulse learned to hide. No one there was at fault. No one told you to hide. You were the one who calculated that it was cheaper.

Or think of another scene, the kind that looks friendly from the outside. You are with your friends, and a plan is taking shape. A weekend away, perhaps, or a dinner somewhere far off, on a day when you are wrecked. They are all enthusiastic, and you feel, beneath their enthusiasm, your body drawing back. You felt like saying no, or yes but another day, or yes but somewhere nearer. You

felt like saying the simple truth that you are tired and that this, that week, would cost you more than it gave. Instead you hear yourself say you love the idea.



You hear yourself enter the plan with a joy you do not have, even offering to handle part of the logistics, as though your body, realising you would give in anyway, had decided to give in with applause so that no one would suspect the effort. You go. You even have fun, because you also know how to have fun inside what costs you, which is another of your old skills. But you come back empty, with that particular hangover of someone who spent a whole weekend being a version of herself who says yes to everything. Your friends love you. None of them meant to drag you into anything. You were the one who decided that saying no would cost you more in relation to them than saying yes would cost you in relation to yourself, and you did the sum always with you losing.

Here is what makes this sign so hard to see and so easy to defend. Almost always, in the moment, shrinking yourself is reasonable. It is polite. It is generous, even. Not making a scene over a sentence is maturity. Giving way at the restaurant so that everyone eats happily is love. Swallowing the tiredness so as not to spoil the birthday party is care. Each isolated act of shrinking can be presented, and is

presented, as a virtue. The problem is never in one cut. The problem is in the sum. It is in waking one day and realising that you no longer know what you like when there is no one to please, that you no longer know what you think before you know what is expected of you to think, that you lost access to your own yes and your own no because you handed them over, cent by cent, in a thousand transactions so small that none of them looked like a payment.

Notice the restaurant, which is the place where this is seen in slow motion. They are choosing where to sit, and there is that good table, the one in the corner, the one by the window, the one you fancied. Without saying anything you let them sit at the other. They are ordering, and you wanted the dish of the day, but your best friend says she will have a salad so as not to feel heavy, and you, in a reflex of company, order a salad too, and you stay looking at her plate wanting yours and hers at the same time. They order wine, and you did not want wine, but since everyone is drinking you say yes to half a glass so as not to be the spoilsport.

It is cold on the side where they sat you, there is a draught from the door, and you do not ask to swap places because everyone is already settled and you would be making trouble. At the end of the dinner, which was lovely, everyone says it was lovely, you come away hungry, cold, and with the tiredness of someone who spent the whole meal negotiating with herself. No one noticed. How would they notice, when you do this with the perfection of someone who

has trained at it her whole life. You gave way in everything, in silence, with a smile, and the only one who came out the loser, at the table where they wish you well, was once again you.

Do not think this is cured with willpower, with a morning of good intentions in front of the mirror. The shrinking is deeper than the will, because the will is of the mind and the shrinking has already passed into the body. You can wake up determined to appear more, to say what you think, to take up your place, and at the first table you sit down at the old mechanism fires before your morning decision has even had time to arrive. It is like trying to change the way you breathe with the head alone.

It works for a minute, while you pay attention, and then the attention goes elsewhere and the body resumes its old habit. That is why this sign is not won in a battle. It is won in a repetition, patient, small, of gestures that little by little teach the body a new way of being. It is not a decision. It is a re-education. Re-educations are slow, and full of relapses, and there is nothing in them to post, and it is precisely for that reason that they work, unlike the grand decisions made at night and betrayed at breakfast.

There is a woman I always remember when I think of this. The name does not matter. She was one of the most pleasant people you could meet, the kind everyone says is a darling, who is always in good spirits, who never gives any trouble. One day, in the middle of a banal conversation about nothing, they asked her a simple thing.

Where did she like to go to dinner. She stood still. She really stood still, with the question in front of her like a closed door, because she did not know. She was not feigning modesty, she was not being difficult.

She had spent so many years asking others where they wanted to go, moulding herself to other people's appetites, saying it is all the same to me with the lightness of one who offers, that the needle of her own taste had stopped pointing. It is all the same to me, said a thousand times, had become true. It really was all the same to her now. She, who had given that answer the way one gives a gift, realised in that instant, with the question about dinner hanging in the air, that she had given away her own palate.

It is not only the taste of food. Notice how the thing spreads. You lose the taste of what you eat and you lose, next, the taste of everything else. You no longer know what music you would put on if the house were only yours, what film you would watch if no one saw you choose, how you would spend a whole Sunday with no one for whom it had to be pleasant. They ask you where you want to go on holiday and you say wherever, it is always good. They ask what you want as a gift and you say I do not need anything, you have so much to do.

They ask whether you prefer this one or that one, and you, who no longer have a trained preference, choose whatever tires least the one who asks. It is not sainthood, however much it looks like it. It is a

polite disappearance. It is a whole person making herself of little importance so many times over that she ends up being, in fact, and even to herself, of little importance. The saddest part is that no one asked for this. You offered it. You wrapped your own taste in pretty paper and gave it away, piece by piece, to people who did not even know they were receiving it.

This is why the body is the first witness, and the most reliable, long before the mind admits what is going on. The mind is loyal to the project of fitting. The mind always finds a good reason, an it was only this once, a they needed it more than I did, a tomorrow I will see to myself. The body does not negotiate. The body only records. It records in an order worth knowing, because it repeats in all of us with an almost indecent precision.

First the air disappears. You notice that you breathe less deeply in certain company, that the chest does not fill all the way, that there is an invisible ceiling a little above the diaphragm where the breath hits and turns back. It is not dramatic breathlessness. It is a breathing on the surface, of one who does not allow herself to take up even her own lungs. Notice how this makes sense, with a cruel logic. Someone who is making herself small cannot breathe deeply, because to breathe deeply is to take up space, it is the chest expanding and pushing the world back a little, it is declaring with the body itself that one is there, whole. You are rehearsing the opposite. You are rehearsing fitting, and fitting asks that one

breathe little, take up little, make of the body a discreet thing pressed against the wall. So, without noticing, you hold your breath at the halves. It is not that you lack air. It is that you do not grant yourself permission for it.

Then comes the tension in the chest, that dull, continuous tightening that does not hurt enough to frighten you but is always there, like a hand closed inside the ribs that forgot to open. There are days when you rest your own hand there, in the middle of the breastbone, almost without thinking, like someone trying to calm a small animal. You do not quite know what is tightened there, but you know that it is. It is the place where you keep everything you did not say. Each swallowed sentence does not disappear, it stays, and it stays there, in the chest, taking up volume. The tension is not an illness, it is an archive. It is your body keeping, in a tight safe between the ribs, all the times you chose to keep quiet instead of taking up your place. The safe, over the years, grows heavy.

Then comes the tiredness, and this is the most treacherous of all, because it is a disproportionate tiredness, a tiredness that does not match the day. You did nothing much. You sat, you talked, you smiled, you were pleasant. You come home emptied as though you had carried stones. There is a kind of tiredness that comes from living and another that comes from performing living, and this second is far worse, because the first at least gave you something in return, and the second only took. You lie down exhausted without

the comfort of knowing why. You look at the day and it seems light, it seems nothing, and you are wrecked, and that difference between the weight of the day and your own weight is itself one more thing that tires you, because it makes you believe there is something wrong with you, when what is wrong is only the invisible work that no one counted, beginning with you.

Then, later, comes the irritability for no reason, the kind that frightens you because you do not recognise yourself in it, those days when everything grazes your skin, when an innocent question from someone you love makes you want to scream, and you do not understand where so much anger comes from over so little. It comes from far off. It comes from all the times you did not say what you felt and the sentence stayed rotting inside you, and now it comes out where it can, displaced, unfair, against whoever happens to be there. Anger is not a flaw of character, notice, it is a late letter.

Everything you did not say at the right moment, to whoever needed to hear it, stays in the inner mail waiting to go out, and since the main door is locked, a lock you yourself put there, the letter goes out through the window, broken, in tatters, against the first person who appears, who is usually the one who least deserves it, because she is the nearest and the one to whom you grant yourself permission to show yourself ugly. That is why you are frightened. It is not the anger that does not recognise you. It is you who do not recognise



everything it carries inside and that should have come out long ago, slowly, in time.

Finally, at the end of this whole sequence, comes the question. The question that gives the symptom a name and that so many people put to the doctor, to the friend, to the mirror, without ever finding an answer that serves. Why am I so tired when I did not even do that much. The question has the answer inside it, but it is an answer that is hard to accept because it dismantles the idea we have of rest. You are tired not despite having done nothing visible, but precisely because of what you did and no one saw. You spent the whole time performing. Performing is a full-time job, the most exhausting of all, because it has no hours, no lunch break, no weekend.

You are on duty whenever there is someone to fit yourself to. Watching what you say, measuring what you show, anticipating what they expect, adjusting your face to the temperature of the room, calculating in real time the price of each sentence before you let it out. This consumes more than any work of the arms. Since it shows up nowhere, since no one sees the effort, you are left with all the tiredness and no permission to feel it. That is why she did not know where she wanted to go to dinner. She was working full-time at a job no one paid her for and from which no one had told her to take a holiday.

It is worth staying a moment longer with this idea, because it is the heart of the sign. Performing is a full-time job, and like all full-time

jobs, it deforms the one who does it. There is the morning shift, in which you wake and are already calculating the face you will appear with in the kitchen, the mood it is wise to show, the right tone of the good morning so that no one worries about you. There is the day shift, with its thousand adjustments, the sweeter voice on the phone, the opinion filed down in the meeting, the rehearsed patience with whoever costs you.

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There is the night shift, the worst, in which lying down you go back over the whole day auditing your own performance, seeing where you could have been kinder, where perhaps you overdid a no you let slip after all, where someone may have come away with an impression of you that you need to correct tomorrow. There is no break. There is no moment when you set down the uniform and are only yourself, in house clothes, with your legitimate bad mood and your guiltless silence. A job with no break, however light each task may seem, always, always ends up consuming the whole person. That is why you are tired. You did not do that much, it is true. You only did not stop doing, not for a minute, the most tiring thing there is, which is being someone else to fit where you already had a place.

When one looks beneath all this, with the calm this book has a right to, one sees that the shrinking is not weakness of character. It is old

intelligence working badly in the present. There was a time, far back, very far back, when fitting really was a matter of survival. When one is small and depends entirely on those around one, reading the room and adjusting to it is not vanity, it is instinct. The child who learns early that her excess joy is a bother, or that her sadness has no space, or that her wanting is too much, does the only sensible thing she can do: she shrinks to the measure that lets her remain loved.

It is not a defect. It is a talent for adaptation sharpened at a moment when everything depended on it. The problem is that this talent does not know the time has passed. It goes on thinking that your whole existence is too much, that your true size is a risk, that the sentence left unsaid costs more than it is worth. It goes on protecting you from a danger that no longer exists, and it charges you for that protection the highest price there is, which is not letting you appear where it was already safe to appear.

Perhaps you remember a small scene from when you were a girl, the kind that seems to have no importance and stays for that very reason. You were excited about something, telling a story in a rush, with your hands in the air and your voice loud, full of yourself, and someone, without malice, told you to calm down, or that you talked too much, or that you were getting worked up, or simply turned their eyes to something else while you were still telling it. It was not a great moment. There was no drama, no visible pain. But you, who

were small and attentive as children are, registered it. You registered that that amount of you was too much.

That your joy, at the exact point where it filled, overflowed into a place where it no longer fit. You learned, without words, to regulate it. To lower your voice before they raised it for you. To measure your enthusiasm. To offer a version of you a little smaller than the true one, because that one seemed to fit better. It was no one's fault. Whoever told you to calm down loved you, was tired, had their own tightening in the chest that came from some other table even older. But you, on that day, installed in yourself a tuner, and the tuner never switched off again, and it goes on today, at the table of grown people who would be heartbroken if they knew, turning your volume down for a danger that no longer exists anywhere except inside you.

This is why shrinking yourself hurts in such a particular way within love. Because you do not shrink with strangers, or you shrink less, since with strangers there is not so much at stake. You shrink where you most want to stay. You shrink at the good table, with the right people, in that place that was and still is, in part, your ground. Here is again the mourning that runs through this whole book, now inside this sign. The table did not ask you to shrink. The people you love do not want you smaller. They would probably be sad if they knew what you have done to yourself to fit there. There is no one to blame. There is no one pushing you down. There is only a version of you, loyal and frightened, that goes on making you small at the door

of a house where you already fit whole, and that is so afraid of losing the place that it would rather occupy it shrunken than risk occupying it true. What is lost is not the house. What is lost is you inside it.

There is a phone call that repeats this sign better than any scene at the table. The call to your mother, or to whoever stands in for her, the one you call because you love her and because you should and because there is a thread there that does not break. She asks how you are. You, who perhaps that day are hanging by a thread, who perhaps cried in the morning without quite knowing why, who perhaps carry a tiredness that already frightens you, say everything is fine. You say everything is fine, Mum, and you, are you well. You say that work is going, that the children are great, that yes, you have been sleeping. You are not lying out of malice or even only out of habit. You are protecting her.

You think, and perhaps you are not at all wrong, that she has her own aches, that she would not sleep easy if she knew, that there is nothing she can do and that you would only be passing her the weight with no relief at all. So you shrink the truth until it fits into an everything is fine, and you hang up, and you stay with your whole pain on your side, now even more alone than before the call, because you have just hidden it from the person who learned earliest to read you. There is no villain in this scene. There are only two women protecting each other at the same time, each pretending

herself smaller in her pain so as not to weigh on the other, and the love passing between the two real and blind, without ever touching what hurts.

Most books, arriving here, would tell you to set limits. They would say to start saying no, to assert yourself, to defend your space with the firmness of someone who has learned the rule. It is not wrong, in the long run. But you know yourself well and you know what would happen if I told you, today, at the Sunday table, to say all the noes you have been swallowing for years. Either you could not, and you would be left feeling even more of a failure, now also for not knowing how to assert yourself. Or you could by force, with your heart pounding, and it would tip into a disproportionate scene where everything would come out at once, years of kept sentences coming out against someone who only wanted to know about the dinner, and you would confirm to yourself the old lesson that to appear is dangerous. The turn of this sign is not that. It is not the great no, the great assertion, the great scene of reconquest. It is far smaller, and it is because it is small that it holds.

The turn is to leave one thing unshaved. One only, next time. Not all of them. Not the biggest. Not the riskiest. A small sentence, a taste of yours of little weight, a disagreement with no consequences, and instead of shaving it off by habit, to let it pass through the door whole, the size it was born. I am not saying to say everything you feel to everyone, because that is no truth at all, it is only another way

of losing yourself, now through excess. I am saying to recognise the impulse at the exact instant it appears, before the filter drops, and now and then, in a situation that can bear it, to let it exist.

Where did you like to go to dinner. Instead of it is all the same to me, to pause half a second, to listen for whether there is some preference underneath, however small, and to say I feel like fish. Just this. I feel like fish. It looks like nothing and it is a whole revolution, because it is the needle starting to point again, it is the impulse learning that it can appear after all, it is your existence taking up again, for an instant at least, its legitimate size at a table where they love you.

Choose well the situation that can bear it, because that makes all the difference. Do not begin with the table where there is most tension, nor with the person who costs you most, nor with the subject that has burned inside you for years. Begin with the easy one. Begin with a safe person, on a calm day, with something that changes no one's life. The place where you feel like sitting. The music you feel like putting on in the car. The fact that today, honestly, you feel like staying home.

They are small things, without weight, without danger, and it is because they are like this that they serve, because what you are training is not the courage of a great battle, it is the simple gesture of letting yourself appear. Each time the impulse comes out whole and the world does not collapse, and the person you love goes on loving you, and the table stays laid, you teach the old tuner something it

needed to learn long ago: that the time has passed, that there is no longer any danger, that you can after all be here at your own size and go on fitting.

It will hurt a little, it is worth warning, because the truth is that the impulse, the first time you let it come out whole after years locked up, comes out clumsy. It does not come out gracefully, it does not come out round, it does not come out as it came when you were small and had not yet domesticated it. It comes out a little rough, a little too much or a little too little, with the voice trembling or too loud or too soft, because it is relearning how to walk. Do not use that clumsiness as proof that you should not have spoken.

The clumsiness is only the rust of a door that was shut a long time. It opens with a creak the first time, and the second time it creaks less, and by the tenth it opens in silence. What matters is not that it came out perfect. It is that it came out. Each time it comes out, however crooked it goes, the hinge loosens a little, and the next time is easier, until one day you hear yourself saying what you feel with the naturalness of someone who never silenced it, and you no longer even remember the effort the first one was.

Notice that this turn does not take you from the table. It does not require you to be angry with anyone, to make speeches, to claim years of shrinking as a debt to be collected. You stay exactly where you are, with exactly the same people, and you love them exactly the same way. What changes is that you stop paying for staying with



your disappearance. You begin, in a gesture so small that no one else notices, to be present there without having to absent yourself from yourself to do it. This, contrary to what fear tells you, does not make you harder to love. It makes you more possible to love, because at last there is someone there to love, and not a pleasant, tired form performing the part of you.

You will have relapses, and I want you to know this beforehand so that you do not use them as proof that you are not capable. There will be days when you shave everything off again, when you go back to swallowing, when you catch yourself saying it is all the same to me with the old lightness and only notice afterward, in the car, the old tightening rising. It does not matter. To notice afterward also counts. To notice afterward is the impulse coming back late, but coming back. The path of this sign is not to stop shrinking yourself overnight, because that happens to no one. It is to reduce, slowly, the distance between the moment you shrink and the moment you notice it, until one day, without ceremony, you notice it before, in the very instant, and still in time to choose something else.

I am not asking you, in closing this chapter, to recover today everything you handed over. Nor to know already, all at once, what you like, what you think, what you want, after so many years of not asking yourself. Those answers come back slowly, as you stop silencing them. I ask you only one thing, and it is the hardest of all for its smallness: that the next time you hear yourself say maybe I

am exaggerating, you distrust the sentence. That you see that it is not humility, it is anaesthesia. That, beneath it, instead of silencing yourself one more time, you ask yourself with all the tenderness you are capable of, and what if I am not. What if, instead of exaggerating, I am, for the first time in a long while, feeling the exact size of what it costs me to fit like this.

SIGN 3



You feel longing for  
something you never  
lived

*There is something I am missing but I do not  
know what.*



**I**t happens to you in quiet hours. It is not on the hard days, notice carefully, it is on the good days that this visits you. You are in a late Sunday afternoon, the light going down slowly through the kitchen window, the house in order, the people you love near, and everything you asked of life for years is, at this exact instant, inside the walls where you are sitting. Even so, without warning, a lack moves through you. A lack so old and so precise that it seems like memory, and so without a body that you cannot say what it is of. You lack nothing of what you see. You lack something you never had, and the strange thing, the almost unbearable thing, is that you recognise it. You feel longing for something you never lived.

It is not desire, because desire points outward, to something that is bought or won, and this has no object. It is not sadness, because sadness has a cause, and you, if you are honest, cannot name what you lost. It is not dissatisfaction, though that is what you tell yourself to silence yourself, because dissatisfaction is loud and this is mute. This is a longing in reverse. Ordinary longing remembers a place where one has been. This one remembers a place where one never set foot. The memory of something you never lived should not be possible, and yet it is here, inside you, clearer than much of what actually happened to you.

Perhaps you have already given it a name under your breath, one of those names that serve to close the matter and that close nothing. Perhaps you thought, I am ungrateful. I have everything and it still

is not enough. Or perhaps, crueller, I am a romantic, I go about imagining a life that does not exist while the real one passes me by. Or else, and this is the oldest verdict of all, the one everyone always told you, you are never satisfied. There is someone there in your head, a voice that is not exactly yours, confirming the diagnosis with the patience of one who has repeated it many times. You always wanted more. What you had was never enough for you. You fall silent, because part of you believes it. Part of you is ashamed of this lack, as though it were a factory defect, a fault in the capacity to be happy with what one has.

Notice how it chooses its hours. It does not visit you when life is hard, when there is a bill to pay or a fever to watch over at dawn, because in those hours you are too deep inside life to feel the lack of another. It waits. It waits for everything to be in order, for the children to sleep, for the dishes to be washed, for the silence to settle with that quality particular to nights when nothing is missing. It is then, at the exact moment when you ought to be at peace, that it sits down beside you. That is why it costs so much. Because it comes at the wrong hour for a lack, at the hour when no one would grant you a reason to have it. Who complains when everything is well? You do not complain. You swallow it. What you swallow stays, and the following night it returns, a little clearer, a little more yours.

I want to tell you something before we go deeper, and I want to say it slowly so that it does not pass you by. That longing is not a defect. It

is not ingratitude, it is not a whim, it is not proof that you do not know how to love your life. It is a compass. It is the most intelligent thing in you pointing toward a direction your mind cannot yet read. The work of this chapter is not to make you silence the compass so that you may have peace. It is to teach you to look where it points without being afraid of what you will see.

There is something you need to know about this sign before anything else, and it is its position. If the first not-fitting is felt at the table, surrounded by people, present without being home, this one is deeper and quieter. In the first, at least, there is a scene. There are people, there is a room, there is a moment you can point to and say, it was there, it was at that dinner, it was when everyone laughed and I could not. Here there is no room.

Here you are alone, or you seem to be, even when there is someone sleeping beside you. This sign is not seen from the outside. No one notices that you carry it. There is no gesture that gives you away, no silence that another person notices, nothing in your face that says what is going on. It is the most inward not-fitting, the most mute, the one you can carry for thirty years without a single person around you suspecting that you carry it. Perhaps that is why it weighs most. A pain no one sees is a pain no one helps you carry.

Let us begin with what it is not, because the quickest way not to understand a thing is to confuse it with its imitation. The longing for what you never lived is not nostalgia. Nostalgia has a photo album.

You sit down to remember your grandparents' house, the smell of bread, a particular summer with a year stuck to it, and what hurts is that it passed and does not return. Nostalgia is a form of love for what has already been. But this that you feel has no photograph at all. There is no summer, there is no house, there is no year. There is a recognition without memory, and it is precisely because it has no memory that it frightens. How does one feel longing for something one has never seen? How can an absence be so familiar?

Nor is it regret, though from a distance it resembles it. Regret knows what it did wrong. It has a day, a decision, a door that closed and that one would have liked to have crossed. Regret could have been avoided, and that is its torture, it could have been otherwise and was not, through my fault. But this that you feel accuses you of no choice. There is no decision here that you made badly. On the contrary, you went on deciding well, all through life, and even so the lack came. It is not the weight of what you did wrong. It is the weight of what never came to be, and that was no one's fault. There is an innocence in this longing that regret never has. It does not judge you. It only reminds you.

I am going to risk an answer, and I ask you to receive it as a hypothesis and not as a verdict, because in these territories humility is the only path that does not lie. Perhaps what you call longing is your soul recognising a possibility of life more aligned than the one you are living. Notice the word recognise. Not imagine, not invent,

not desire. Recognise. As when you enter for the first time a city where you have never been and there is a street that seems yours, and you stop, and you say inwardly, I know this, and you do not, and yet you do. There is in you a form of life that belongs to you and that you have not yet inhabited. It is not a fantasy you built. It is a truth you have not yet fulfilled. The lack you feel is the distance between who you are and who you already are in potential. The longing is not looking backward. It is looking at a part of you that is still ahead of you.

Perhaps it has happened to you without warning, in an unlikely place. You are in a café in a city where you had never been, or driving past a country road you did not know, and suddenly a tenderness tightens your chest for it, as though you had already lived there, as though that table, that light, that smell of wet earth belonged to you from a time that never was. Or you hear a song in a language you do not speak and your eyes fill with water without a single word telling you why. Or you see, in a film, a woman doing something simple, mending a fishing net, kneading bread at dawn, writing by candlelight, and something inside you says, slowly, I am that, I should be doing that. Right after, the mind hurries to deny it, what nonsense, you do not even know how to knead bread. But it was not the bread. It was never the bread. It was the whole life that scene promised, and that you recognised before you thought it.



Let me bring this down to earth, because said like this it hovers, and what hovers does not serve you. I know a woman, let us call her Inês, who for sixteen years was exactly what life asked her to be. A good daughter, a good mother, a good professional, a good neighbour, one of those people no one has anything to reproach, and she herself had nothing to reproach. Her life worked. One ordinary afternoon, with nothing to justify it, she was folding laundry on the bed, a banal thing, her son's clothes still warm from the line, and she burst into tears. Not a weeping of pain.

A weeping without a name, the kind that comes from so deep that the person herself does not know to whom it belongs. What she told me afterward, ashamed, quietly, like someone confessing, was this: I felt longing for a woman I could have been. Right after, correcting herself, putting herself in order, but what nonsense, I love my life, I have no reason to complain. Do you notice the movement? The lack came first, real, with tears and all. Right behind it came the guard, the shame, the what nonsense, dismantling the lack before it could say what it had to say. She spent years folding that weeping in with the laundry and putting it away in the drawer.

Look closely at what she said. Longing for a woman I could have been. Not for a man she did not meet, not for a journey she did not take, not for another life in another place with other people. For a version of herself. For an Inês who existed in potential and who, at each fork in life, was left behind for good reasons, always for good

reasons, never for any bad reason. It is here that we need to stop, because it is here that the heart of this sign lies and its difference from every other book you have read about lack and desire. That woman who was left behind was not left behind because someone stopped you.

There is no villain in this story. There is no father who clipped your wings, no husband who diminished you, no unjust circumstance that robbed you. There was a good table. There was a life you chose and that went on being good, choice after choice, all of them loving, all of them right at the moment they were made. The other, the one not made, stayed alive inside you, waiting. The longing for what you never lived is the mourning of a life that was not taken from you. It is the mourning of a life you said no to, again and again, out of love for this one, and that never quite left you.

There is a confusion here that needs to be undone with care, because it is from it that the greatest mistakes come. When you feel this lack, the mind hurries to translate it into a plan. I am missing something, therefore I must change my life. I must leave this, set off for that, start over, do the great irreversible thing that will finally bring me what I am missing. Here is the trap, because the longing for what you never lived is almost never a request for flight. It is a request for presence. The life it points to is rarely on another continent. It is, most of the time, inside your own, a gesture away, shrunk for lack of courage and not for lack of space. Inês did not need to leave the

house, the son, the work. She needed to let in the woman who folded laundry weeping, instead of putting her away in the drawer. They are very different things, and to confuse them costs dearly. There are those who destroy a whole life fleeing a lack that only wanted to be looked at.

So where does it come from, this lack? I am going to tell you what I have understood, and I am going to tell it in layers, from the simplest to the deepest, because each is true and none alone is enough.

The simplest layer, and the most likely, is the future calling. There is in you a life in potential, a more whole version of you, more yours, and that version is not a fantasy, it is a possible destiny, and the longing you feel is the longing one has for what one has not yet been but could be. It is strange to feel longing for the future, but that is exactly what it is. There are parts of you that already know the way before you know it. The courage you have not yet had, the voice you have not yet used, the work you have not yet done, the tenderness you have not yet let yourself feel. All of that is already in you, in seed, and the seed feels longing for the tree. It is not madness. It is the most natural thing in the world. What is unborn pulls to be born, and that pull, when it has no name, we feel as lack.



I want you to notice something, because it is strange and it is true. There are longings that are born before the experience. A girl of fifteen, who has never loved anyone, already knows how to feel longing for a love she has not yet had. It is not anticipation, it is not planning the future, it is a real lack, with real weight, for something that has not yet come. We find this natural in youth and strange in adult life, but it is the same phenomenon. The life in you runs ahead of you. It knows things you do not yet know. When a part of it, more whole, more brave, more yours, is already formed in there waiting to exist, you feel its presence the way one feels the presence of someone in a darkened house. You do not see her. You know she is there. The longing is the way the body tells you, there are more people here than the ones you switched on a light for.

There is a second layer, and this one is more delicate, and because it is delicate I am going to tread on it with bare feet. Sometimes the lack you feel did not begin in you. Sometimes it comes from further off, from before you existed, from a line of people to whom you owe your name and your blood. Think of the women before you. The one who wanted to study and was not allowed. The one who had a gift and died without having used it a single time. The one who loved someone and had to marry another.

The one whose life was interrupted by a war, by an illness, by a poverty she did not choose, by a time that made no room for what she was. Interrupted lives. Desires left unlived. Parts of a lineage left unlived. There are those who say, and I say it as one who offers a hypothesis and not as one who closes a door, that those desires do not die with the one who had them. That they go on looking for continuation. That they come down the line of the blood waiting for someone with room to fulfil them. That, sometimes, that someone is you.

There is a photograph in almost every family, one of the black-and-white ones, of a woman whose name almost no one remembers anymore. You look at her and say, she was your great-grandmother's sister, she died young, she was the one who played the piano, or the one who wanted to be I do not know what and never was. There is always one like that. The one who had something and life closed on her before she could open it. There are whole families where, generation after generation, there is a woman who feels, without knowing why, a wanting that tightens her in the exact direction of what that other one, in the photograph, never could. As though her desire had not died with her. As though it had come down, quiet, the line of those who came after, looking for one with enough room to fulfil it. I do not tell you that it is so. I tell you that perhaps it is, and that it is worth looking at the photograph with other eyes.

I am not asking you to believe this as a fact. I am asking you to try it as a question. When you feel that nameless lack, ask yourself with delicacy, is this all mine? Or is there a longing here that was not born with me? There are women who discover, on asking this question, that what they always took for a whim of their own was an old fidelity. That the gift they never dared to use was the gift of a grandmother who never could use it.

That the life that seemed too romantic to be theirs was simply the life that someone before them did not get to have. When a woman sees this, something in her softens. Because the lack stops being a defect of hers and becomes an inheritance. An inheritance is not cured. It is honoured. But I tell you this quietly, without certainties, because there is many a charlatan here selling maps of what cannot be seen, and I do not want to give you any map. I want only to open to you the possibility that your lack is larger than you, and that this, instead of frightening you, might console you.

There is a way of honouring an inheritance like this that requires no certainty at all about whether it exists. You do not need to know whether that wanting comes from a grandmother or only from you. It is enough to treat it with respect, instead of treating it with shame. Because even if it is all yours, it deserves the same care it would deserve if it were another's. And if it is another's, then to fulfil it is a form of love that crosses time, it is to do for her life what life would not let her do, and there is in that a dignity that changes the way

you feel yourself wanting. You stop thinking yourself greedy. You start thinking yourself faithful. It is a very different word, faithful, and it fits you better than ungrateful ever fit.

There is a third layer, perhaps the soberest of all, and the one that most often gets it right. Perhaps it is nothing so grand. Perhaps it is only you, in the present, living a life smaller than the life you are capable of. Not worse. Smaller. There is an enormous difference between a bad life and a tight life, and the second is much harder to detect, because on the outside everything is well, everything is more than well, and it is precisely because everything is well that no one grants you the right to the lack. Who would hear you? You have a life many people would want. How do you complain about a good life? Yet the lack does not ask whether you have the right. It only knows that there is more of you than what you are living, and as long as that more is not called into being, it will go on knocking at your door on Sunday afternoons, in the hour when the light goes down and there are no more chores to distract you.

I know another woman, and her story says this better than any explanation. Let us call her Teresa. She had everything one could want of a comfortable life, and she said so, in the voice of someone defending herself against an accusation no one had made. I have a good life, I cannot complain. She repeated I cannot complain a great deal, and whoever repeats that she cannot complain is because she has a complaint she does not allow herself to have. Her lack always

appeared the same way, at the end of the day, when she sat down on the sofa with her life tidied, and it was a kind of hunger that did not pass however much she ate. She spent years thinking it was anxiety. She went to the doctor. She took pills.

The pills muffled the lack the way one muffles a sound with a pillow, but the sound went on underneath, waiting for the pillow to tire. One day, without a pill, the lack came back whole, and she, instead of muffling it, asked it the question she had never asked. She sat down with it and asked, what do you want? The answer came simple and old, as though it had been waiting thirty years only for someone to ask. I want to heal people. That was all. As a girl she had wanted to be a doctor, and life, without malice, for a thousand good reasons, had taken her another way, and she had buried it so deep that she no longer even knew it was there. The hunger the pills muffled was that. It was a whole life calling from under the pillow.

I want to stop now at the false diagnosis, because it is where most of your suffering lives, and it is not where the truth lives. The false diagnosis is everything you tell yourself to turn this lack into a defect of yours and so not have to look at it. You are ungrateful. You are a romantic. You are never satisfied. Did you notice that they all have the same function? To return the lack to you as guilt, so that the lack stops pointing outward, at your life, and starts pointing inward, at your character. It is easier to be a woman with a defect than a woman with a life left to live. The defect explains everything



and demands nothing. You put the problem in yourself, in you who are never enough, and your life stays over on the far side, untouched, perfect, and you bent under the weight of not knowing how to be happy in it. It is a convenient trade, and it costs you everything.

Think of the word ungrateful for a moment, because it does dirty work and almost no one sees it. Ingratitude presumes that you received something and do not give thanks for it. But you do give thanks. You love your life, you love the people in it, and the lack you feel takes nothing from that, it is not instead of the love, it is alongside it. What the word ungrateful does is force you to choose. As though gratitude and longing could not live in the same woman at the same time. As though to want more were to despise what you have. It is not. A mother can love deeply the child she has and feel the lack of the painter she stopped being to have him. The two things are true, and neither cancels the other. Whoever wanted to make you believe that one cancelled the other was asking you, without knowing it, to kill half of yourself to prove that you loved the other half. Do not accept the bargain. There is no gratitude that proves itself by sacrificing the truth.

I am going to dismantle for you the cruellest of these three, the you are never satisfied, because it is the one most women heard and the one that sank deepest. Whoever told you this, and whoever it was, almost always said it out of love or out of fear, rarely out of malice.

They said it to protect you from the restlessness they saw in you and did not know how to take in. They said it because your lack frightened them, because if you wanted more, then perhaps their life, which was the same as yours, was also not enough, and that was too much to bear. You are never satisfied was not an observation about you. It was a request that you stop wanting, so that they could go on not wanting in peace.

You obeyed. You swallowed the sentence, you made it yours, and for years each time the lack visited you, you heard inside the same verdict, there you go, never satisfied, and you silenced the compass so as not to be a bother. Satisfaction, notice, was never the opposite of this lack. One can be deeply satisfied with the life one has and even so feel longing for the life one can still have. The two fit. Satisfaction is for what you received. Longing is for what you have not yet given. They do not compete. Whoever told you they competed wanted you to choose one and give up the other, and the one they wanted you to give up was always the same.

There is a cruel thing these diagnoses have in common, besides returning the guilt to you. It is that all of them were, at some moment, said out of love. No one called you ungrateful to hurt you. They said it, or you said it to yourself, to spare you the restlessness of wanting something that seemed larger than what life allowed. It is a crooked form of fondness, this, the one of convincing ourselves that we do not deserve what we desire so that we may stop desiring it and

so stop suffering. We learn to do it early, and we learn it watching the adults around us do it with their own lacks. We saw our mother shrug a desire off her shoulders and say, oh, that is not for me. We saw our father set a wanting aside with a never mind that, and sit silent looking at the television. They did not teach us to silence the lack out of malice. They taught it the way one teaches survival. We learned it too well.

There is a silent cost in living like this, and few people name it. When a woman spends years treating her lack as a defect, she does not only become sad. She becomes smaller. She shrinks her life so that it fits the size she thinks she deserves. She does not ask for the raise, she does not write the book, she does not say the true sentence, she does not change rooms, she does not switch on the light she has inside, because each of those things would be to grant the lack its point, and to grant the lack its point would be to admit that she was not satisfied, and not to be satisfied would be to prove that she is, after all, the ungrateful one she always feared being.

Do you see the knot? The lack, by being treated as shame, makes life tighten further, and the more life tightens, the more the lack grows, and the more the lack grows, the more shame is felt. It is a wheel that turns on its own, and there are women who grow old inside it without ever having suspected that the wheel was not life, it was only a way of living it.

. . .

I want to return to Inês, because her story has a turn, and the turn is what you need to hear. For months after that weeping on the laundry, she went about thinking she had to do something great. She thought of leaving her job. She thought of things I will not say here because they frightened her herself. She had decided that the lack demanded a demolition, that the woman she could have been would only fit if she tore down the woman she was. One day, in conversation, she saw a simple thing that changed everything.

That woman she could have been had a name, and the name was to write. That was all. Since she was a girl she had written, and since she was a girl someone, with the best of intentions, had told her that it was a pastime, not the kind of thing that gives anyone a living, and she put the notebooks away in the same drawer where, years later, she would put away the weeping. The life she was missing was

not another life. It was hers, with the notebooks open. She did not need to demolish anything. She needed to open a drawer again.

Linger on this part, because it is where almost everyone trips. Your mind does a sum that seems logical and is wrong. If I am missing a life, it says, then the life I have is the wrong one, and I have to trade it. But the longing never said that this life is the wrong one. It said that this life is incomplete, which is a different thing. A wrong life asks to be left. An incomplete life asks to be filled. It is tragic to see how many women tear down a good life because they read it as wrong, when it only needed to receive within it the part that was missing. Inês was not in the wrong life. She was in the right life with a closed drawer. It was not the house that was wrong. It was the drawer that was unopened. No one opens a drawer by tearing the house down.

This brings me to the gesture I want to leave you, because we have reached the part where it is not enough to understand, it is necessary to do, and what one does here is far smaller than everything your mind has been proposing to you. Your mind, faced with this lack, wants a plan. It wants you to change your life, to set off, to do the irreversible thing. I am going to ask you the opposite. I am going to ask you for a gesture so small that it will seem ridiculous to anyone expecting revolutions, and that is, nonetheless, the only thing that truly makes a difference.

The gesture is this: to let the lack exist without explaining it.

The next time it visits you, and it will visit you, probably in a good hour, do not rush to call it names. Do not say, there I go, ungrateful. Do not say, it is romanticism, away with it. Do not put it away in the drawer with the rest of what you put away. Stay with it. Sit beside it the way you would sit beside a friend who arrived without warning and whom you were not expecting but in fact wanted to see. Ask it a single question, without haste for an answer, without needing to resolve it today. The question is, what do you long for? Not to act now. Not to change anything tomorrow. Only to listen. Because a lack that is listened to begins to speak, and a lack that is silenced only knows how to shout louder.

Notice what I am and what I am not asking of you. I am not asking you to change your life. Whoever changes her life fleeing a lack carries the lack with her, because the lack was not in the life, it was in not having listened to it. Nor am I asking you to resign yourself, to accept that this is how it is, to bury the compass and smile. That would be self-abandonment, it would be to do exactly what they have been asking of you, to stop wanting so as not to be a bother. The gesture I ask of you is neither flight nor resignation. It is fidelity. It is to be faithful to the part of you that knows there is more, without your yet having to know what. It is to let that part breathe inside your life as it is, instead of expelling it to have peace or demolishing the whole house to lodge it.

When you listen to it, do not expect a whole answer right at the first try. Old lacks speak slowly, in half words, like someone who lost the habit of being heard. Perhaps only a loose image will appear to you, a colour, a gesture, a word with no context. Do not despise it for being small. A lack that was silent for decades does not hand you the whole life in one afternoon. It hands you the end of a thread. Your work is not to pull the thread hard until you know everything. It is to hold it, and come back tomorrow, and hold it again.

The truest things about a person are not discovered, they are recovered, and to recover is slow. Teresa did not become a doctor. She was fifty-something, she was not going to go to medical school now. But she began to volunteer in a care home, to be near those who suffered, to tend, and the hunger of thirty years began, slowly, to know itself fed. The life she was missing did not come in the exact form the girl of fifteen had imagined. It came in a smaller and possible form, and it was enough, because what was missing had never been the diploma. It was the gesture of caring, and that one still fit in the life she had.

Notice that this is sibling to something you already know. It is of the family of remaining. You do not remain in the lack to punish yourself with it, nor do you make of the lack a house where you go to live in suffering. You remain in it the time it takes to listen to it. You stay, the way one stays beside someone who weeps without knowing why, without demanding that she explain, without telling her that is

enough. There is a form of presence that does not resolve and that heals more than resolving. It is that one I ask of you with your own lack.

Do not send it away. Do not feed it. Keep it company. And go and see what it shows you, slowly, with no promise of any arrival, because I am not going to promise you that you will discover which life you are missing and run to it and be finally whole. I do not know whether that happens. I know something else, more modest and truer. I know that a lack that is listened to stops hurting as shame and begins to hurt as direction, and that a pain with direction is a pain one can live with, because it is no longer a defect to correct, it is a path to open.

I am going to tell you something that may cost you and that you need to hear, because it is the heart of this book and I do not want to leave you without it. Feeling longing for something you never lived does not mean your life is wrong. It does not mean you chose badly, that you should have gone another way, that you wasted what you had to give. The life you chose was good. It was the right one. The people you love go on deserving your love and go on having it. None of this is in question.

What this lack tells you is not leave this life. It is make this life larger. It is there is more of you waiting to exist, and that part did not come to take from you what you have, it came to join what you have. The woman who folded laundry weeping did not want to stop being a



mother. She wanted to be a mother and to be the one who wrote. Both. They were always both. It was someone, long ago, who convinced her that she had to choose, and she believed it, and she spent years living half of herself convinced that the other half was a defect.

There is a farewell within this sign, and I want to name it before I leave you, because without it you would be left thinking this was only about gaining. To let the woman you have not yet inhabited exist, you are going to have to say goodbye to a version of yourself. The version that was content. The version that learned not to want so as not to be a bother, that folded the weeping in with the laundry, that called herself ungrateful to spare herself the courage. That version protected you for years. It kept the peace, kept the table, kept the loves around without alarms. Do not despise it in the farewell. Thank it.

It was that version that brought you here whole. But you are going to have to say goodbye to it, and the hardest part is that no one around you will notice that you said goodbye, because on the outside nothing will change. The same people, the same house, the same laundry to fold. What changes is inside. You go on loving exactly whom you loved, and you stop being exactly who you were beside them. You say goodbye to a version without saying goodbye to a single person. No one will be able to console you for that farewell,

because no one will even know it happened. It will be yours, quiet, and it is the most real of all.

Do not be frightened if, as you begin to let it exist, it seems to grow rather than shrink. That is what usually happens. A lack that was silent for years, when you finally let it speak, speaks loudly, because it has much accumulated to say. There will be days when you will think you were better off when you muffled it. You were not. You were only deafer. The lack did not grow, it is you who are hearing it for the first time, and what we hear for the first time always seems larger than what we always knew without wanting to know.

Bear those days. They pass, and on the other side of them is not the lack resolved, it is the lack tamed, which is something one can live with. It stops assaulting you and begins to accompany you. It stops being a stranger who comes in without knocking and becomes a voice of yours, low, that now and then reminds you which way you are facing. That is not a cure. It is company. For a lack like this one, company is more than the cure would ever be.

So, when it comes back, the lack, on the next afternoon of low light when everything is well and even so that bodiless longing moves through you, do not flee and do not resign yourself. Just do the small gesture. Stay. Ask it, quietly, what do I long for. Listen. Not to change your life tomorrow. To begin to let in, today, slowly, without fanfare and with no destination marked, the part of you that always knew there was more. I do not promise you where that leads. I promise you

only that it stops being shame. And a lack that has stopped being shame is itself already a way of beginning to come home, even without yet knowing where home is.

S I G N 4



# You swing between over- adapting and isolation

*Either I belong or I am myself.*



There are weeks when you are everywhere. You say yes before the question ends, you anticipate what is missing from the table before anyone asks, you know by heart the joke that makes that group laugh and the exact tone that calms your mother on the phone. You are good at this. You are so good that no one notices the effort, and that is part of the talent. You adapt to the temperature of each room the way water takes the shape of the glass, and for a while it even looks like generosity, it looks like love.

Then, without warning, the other week comes. The week when you do not answer the messages, when you put off the dinner with the excuse of tiredness, when the phone rings and you look at the name and let it ring. It is not anger. There was no argument. It is only that you ran out of rope. You gave so much of yourself in so many directions that you no longer know where yours ended up. The silence of isolation, for a few days, tastes of relief. Like a house where finally no one asks anything of you.

This is the pendulum. To one side, you are everything to everyone. To the other, you disappear. Between the two swings you go on judging yourself, because in the head this has no pretty name. It has ugly names. Unstable. Inconsistent. Too intense and then too cold. You look back and see a woman who gives herself with her whole body and right after a woman who locks herself away, and you cannot make the two fit into the same person, and you conclude that the fault is you. That there is something broken in you, a

factory defect, a wrong way of being with others. Anyone who saw you from the outside one week and the next would swear they were two. You, on the inside, think the same. That you cannot be trusted, not even by yourself.

I want you to stop here, before we go on, and to hear this with care, because it is the first thread we are going to pull. The pendulum is not a defect of character. It is an intelligent answer to a badly posed question. You are not swinging because you are unstable. You are swinging because you believe, deep down, in a place you have not even put into words, that there are only two ways to survive near people: either you become what they need, or you absent yourself. Either you dissolve into them, or you protect yourself from them. To adapt or to disappear. When those are the only two options on the table, to swing stops being madness and becomes the most logical thing in the world. You are doing what any creature does with two exit doors and no third: it uses one until it is spent, then runs to the other. The problem was never the pendulum. The problem is the map where only two points exist.

I am going to describe the over-adapting side first, because it is the one the world praises and therefore the hardest to see. Imagine a child in a house where the weather changes quickly. Perhaps it was not a bad house. It is almost never a bad house, and that is why it costs so much to tell. It was only a house where the air changed without warning, where someone's mood came through the door

before the body, and where you, small, learned to read that air with a precision that would frighten an adult. You learned that if you smiled at the right times the dinner went better. That if you guessed what would upset before it upset, you could swerve in time. That being easy, being light, being the one who is no trouble, bought peace. It really did buy it. It worked. You became so attuned to others that your own tuning, the station where what you wanted came through, got lost in the noise. You did not switch it off on purpose. It simply stopped having anyone to listen to it, beginning with you.

You grew up and took the gift out of the house. To the friendships, to work, to love. You are the one everyone turns to because you know how to listen, you are the one who stays late seeing to what is missing, you are the one who moulds herself. You are rewarded for it. You receive gratitude, you receive compliments, you receive the place of the one who is indispensable. But there is a bill no one shows you, and the bill is this: each time you mould yourself to someone, you spend a little of a reserve that cannot be seen. It does not hurt in the moment. It hurts afterward, all at once. Because to adapt once is lightness. To adapt always, in every room, with every person, without there ever being a room where you can simply be as you are, that is a hunger that grows beneath the smile. The hunger, when it gathers enough, does not ask. It flees.

Let me stay a little longer on this side, the side of adaptation, because it is the side you defend without noticing, the side you are

proud of. There is a cruel thing in over-adapting that makes it so hard to let go of, and it is that it works. You are not doing relationships badly when you mould yourself. You are doing them well, too well. People like you, they seek you out, they feel good beside you, and all of that is true, none of it is a lie. The price does not appear in them, it appears in you, and it appears in a place you learned not to look. I want you to notice where it hurts. It does not hurt during.

During, it is even good, there is a real pleasure in being the one who smooths things over, in being the one no one has to manage, in gliding through a room without friction. The bill always arrives afterward, and it arrives on its own, and so you never link it to the cause. It arrives as a tiredness for no reason on a Tuesday morning. It arrives as a sudden irritation with someone who did nothing. It arrives as that urge to disappear that frightens you because it seems to come from nowhere. It does not come from nowhere. It comes from a reserve you emptied while smiling, drop by drop, without anyone ever having warned you that it had a bottom.

There is a finer detail still, which perhaps you have never put into words. When you adapt so much, so fast, to so many people, there comes a point where you no longer even know what you like. Someone asks you where you want to go to dinner and you feel a blank, not out of indecision, but because the part of you that knew what you wanted was trained for years to have no wanting of its



own, to wait for the wanting of others and mould itself to it. They ask what your favourite film is and you remember the favourite film of every person you watched films with, but your own taste is covered in dust. This is not frivolity. It is the most visible trace of something deep: you spent so long tuning yourself to the signal of others that you lost your own frequency. A person who has lost her own frequency cannot truly belong to any room, because to belong you have to bring someone there, and you, by dint of being everyone, stopped bringing anyone.

That is where the pendulum turns. There is no conscious decision, there is a limit that is crossed. One day you receive one more request, one more message, one more person needing your mouldable version, and instead of moulding yourself you feel a tiredness that is not physical, it is older than the body. You feel that if you give one more millimetre you will cease to exist. The system, which learned to survive, does the only thing it knows how to do when adaptation no longer works: it withdraws you. It draws the curtains. It puts you in the mode where no one comes in. The strange thing, what confuses you so much, is that this feels good. Isolation, at first, is the most honest place you know. Because it is the only one where you do not have to be anything to anyone. Where you can not answer and there is no weather to manage. Where finally, after days of being everyone's, you are once again only your own.

Here I have to tell you something with all the tenderness I am capable of, because it is easy to hear it wrongly. Isolation, at the start, is not an illness. It is intelligence. It is your nervous system doing a correct sum with the data it had. If being with people means, in your experience, ceasing to be you, then being alone becomes the safe place. There is nothing wrong with that conclusion. Given the premises, it is correct. A creature that learned that the presence of others costs it its own centre will, sooner or later, choose solitude as shelter. Not out of a lack of love. Out of survival economy. The retreat always begins as legitimate protection, as the wise gesture of one who moves away from the fire so as not to be burned more.

The danger is not in the beginning of the isolation. It is in what it becomes if it stays too long. Because a protection repeated many times stops, slowly, being a gesture and becomes a skin. You begin by saying I cannot today, I am tired, and you are right, you are. But if the I cannot today repeats week after week, month after month, there comes a point when you no longer say I cannot. You say I am not. I am not one for crowds. I am not one for dinners. I am not one for giving myself.

In that moment something happened that you need to know in order to undo it: the defence turned into identity. What was a temporary shelter gained furniture, curtains, a name on the door. You built, without noticing, the figure of the defensive hermit, the woman who is enough for herself, who does not need, who is fine on

her own, thank you. That figure, at a certain point, stops protecting you and starts protecting itself, from you, from your own desire for company. Because to admit that you miss people would be to admit that the house you built against the world is also a cell.

Notice that there is no villain anywhere in this story. There was no trauma with a headline name, there was no cruel person you can point to and say it was because of that. The houses that teach us the pendulum are almost always good houses. Parents who loved and who had their own weather to manage. Tables where there was food and there was affection and there was, at the same time and without malice, an air that changed and a child learning to anticipate it. No one did this to you on purpose. No one is to blame for your swinging.

It is precisely for that reason that it costs so much, because there is nowhere to send the fury, no one to call to account. There is only the serene and difficult realisation that you learned to survive in a way that served in that house and that no longer serves in your life as a grown woman. The old form was faithful to its time. It saved what there was to save. It is only that you grew and it did not, and now it protects you from things that no longer exist and prevents you from things you need.

I am going to tell you a scene, because the universals only land when they gain a body. A woman, let us call her that, spent a whole Saturday at a family lunch. She was impeccable. She saw to the dishes before anyone asked, she kept company with the aunt no one

can stand, she told the stories that make her father laugh, she remembered what each one likes and does not like in their coffee. She came away with everyone saying she is a darling, that she is the pillar, that without her it would not be the same. She got home, closed the door, and could not turn on the light. She stayed in the dark of the hallway with her coat still on, and what she felt was not sadness. It was an emptiness with an exact shape, the emptiness of one who was many things to many people and came home with no one to be.

She spent the next three days not answering the phone. Her sister sent a message, she saw it, she did not reply. A friend invited her for coffee, she invented work. She felt awful, of course, because on top of the emptiness there was now guilt, the old guilt of one who moves away from those she loves and cannot explain why. But the truth, the one she only saw much later, is that those three days of silence were not a lack of love for the family. They were the necessary flight of one who had given herself to the end and needed to find herself again before she could appear once more. The pendulum doing what the pendulum does. Total adaptation on Saturday, total isolation through the week, and in the middle, nowhere, her.

Let me tell you what happens when those three days go on repeating over years, because that is where the story becomes harder to see, and more important. The same woman, some years later, no longer spends only three days shut away. She now

organises her whole life to reduce the number of rooms where she has to be everything to everyone. She declines invitations before she feels them, with an ease that surprises even herself. She has ready answers, light, pleasant, that keep people at an exact distance, near enough not to be accused of being cold, far enough not to empty herself. She tells herself a pretty story about this. She says she has matured, that she has learned to put herself first, that she no longer lets herself be used as before. There is truth in that story, there really is, she has learned things. But beneath the pretty story there is something she tells no one and almost does not tell herself, which is that the Friday nights began to have a different silence.

A silence that is no longer only rest. It is a silence that weighs. When an old friend, one of those she really cared about, stops insisting, stops inviting her because she tired of hearing no, she feels a tightening she cannot explain, and she covers it quickly with the thought that it is fine like this, that she prefers her peace. The defence turned into identity so slowly that she never saw the border. She is no longer a woman who sometimes withdraws. She is a woman who presents herself to the world as someone who does not need. She needs. She needs very much. It is only that to admit it would be to open the door of a house she spent years shutting against the only thing that could really hurt her, which was to give herself again and empty herself. The isolation that began as a cure became the most elegant illness there is, the one that disguises itself as a cure forever.

. . .

I want you to see the two women of the two scenes as one, because they are, they are the same person in different phases of the same movement. The one at the lunch, still on the adaptation side, gives herself to the end and flees for three days. The one of the Fridays, already on the side of installed isolation, stopped giving herself and built a whole life around not having to give herself. Between one and the other there was no decision, there was a pendulum that, from swinging so much, kept stopping further and further from the

middle, on the side of flight, because the side of fusion cost too much. This is what no one warns you of when you are in the lunch phase, when you are still the one who moulds herself and only flees now and then.

They warn you of the dangers of giving yourself too much, they tell you to set limits, and all right. But no one warns you that the remedy you are going to invent for the fusion, which is withdrawal, has a slow and silent side effect, and that this side effect is a solitude with the name of wisdom. I do not tell you this to frighten you. I tell it to you so that, if you are already in the phase of the silent Fridays, you may know that that woman is not broken either. She is only very far from the middle, and the middle exists, and one can come back to it, slowly.

Now I want to dismantle with you the false diagnosis, because it is where most of your suffering lives, more even than in the pendulum itself. The false diagnosis is the story you tell yourself about what this means. The story tends always to be some version of I am unstable. I have no balance. I am too much, and then too little. There are people who say this out loud, with an ashamed smile, like someone confessing a defect they have already accepted. That is how I am, I am one of extremes, all or nothing. There are people who do not even say it, who only live it, who only carry it as a dull shame that explains why their relationships never go the way they wanted. In both cases, the diagnosis is the same and it is wrong. You are not

unstable. You are caught between two points when your life asked for a third.

Think well about what the word unstable hides. Unstable presumes that there is a stable way to do what you are doing badly. It presumes that there exists a right way to swing between dissolving and fleeing, and that you, through an incapacity of yours, did not find it. But there is no right way to swing between two extremes that both cost you. There is no possible balance in a pendulum. A pendulum, by definition, has no rest in the middle, it has rest only when it stops swinging, and it will not stop while the only energy that moves it is fear. You are not failing at stability. You are faithfully living the rules of a two-sided game, and losing, because that game cannot be won. Whoever swings between adapting and disappearing is not broken. She is playing too well a game she should not be playing.

There is another ugly name you tend to give yourself, and I want to dismantle it too, because it is the one that most keeps you from people. The name is too much. Too intense when you give yourself, too cold when you withdraw. You live with the shame of being too much and too little, sometimes in the same week, sometimes for the same people. Do you know what the too much really is? It is the way an intensity that has no middle appears, because without the third ground your presence knows only two volumes: the maximum, when you mould yourself with everything you have, and the silence,



when you take yourself away. A person who has learned conscious belonging has intermediate volumes.

She can be present at half gas, she can be in a room without giving herself whole or fleeing whole, she can say I am here but today on a low murmur. You never had those middle volumes. You had the everything and the nothing. The everything, seen from outside, looks like too much intensity, and the nothing, seen from outside, looks like coldness, and you, who feel both on the inside as the same taut cord, take home the shame of being a person of extremes. You are not a person of extremes. You are a person who was only taught two volumes, and who is now, with this chapter, discovering that there is a button in the middle that no one showed her.

There is a particular cruelty in how the world reads your pendulum, which you need to know so as not to internalise it any further. When you give yourself too much, the world takes advantage and calls you generous. When you withdraw, the world resents it and calls you selfish, or distant, or difficult. Notice the trap: the side where you empty yourself is rewarded, the side where you protect yourself is punished. You grew up receiving this teaching every day, and so your system learned a poisonous lesson, which is that being loved costs emptying yourself and that sparing yourself costs the love.

With that lesson in the body, of course you swing. You go to fetch the love on the side of fusion until you cannot bear it, you have had enough, you close, you lose the love, you feel guilty, and you open

again to win it back, and you empty yourself once more, and you close again. The pendulum is not your instability. It is the exact form a whole life takes trying to solve an impossible equation, in which the love was on one side and you were on the other, and you never knew there was a third column where the two could be together.

It is here that I ask you to slow down, because the part that changes everything is coming. There is a third ground. There is a place that is neither fusion nor flight, neither becoming all of them nor shutting yourself all of you. That place has a simple name and you never inhabited it, not because you did not deserve it, but because no one showed you it existed. It is called conscious belonging. The difference between conscious belonging and the pendulum is the difference between being in a room as you and being in a room as what the room wants. In over-adapting, you are with the people but you are not with yourself. In isolation, you are with yourself but you are not with the people. Conscious belonging is the place, rare and learnable, where you are with the people and with yourself at the same time. Where you do not have to choose between the bond and your centre because the two fit in the same breath.

I know that this sounds, the way I say it, like a promised land you have already given up looking for. So I am not going to promise you that you reach it, not today and not with this chapter. What I want is to take an idea out of your head, and the idea is this: that your swinging proves you are not capable of belonging. It proves none of

that. Your swinging proves exactly the opposite. It proves that you have not yet given up. A person who had given up on belonging would stay only on the side of isolation, would install herself there, would make of the hermit the definitive house and die at peace in her cell.

You cannot do that. You come back. However hurt you come away from the world, however much the silence tastes of relief, there is always a week when you open the door again, say yes again, mould yourself again. It is easy to read that return as weakness, as not being able to keep your limits. I read it another way. I read it as the living proof that the part of you that wants to be with people did not die. It is only lost between two extremes, waiting to learn that there is a middle.

I want to tell you something about what is beneath all this, deeper than your individual story, because you will recognise yourself better if you see it. You did not invent the pendulum. You inherited it. The ways of being with others pass from generation to generation the way the colour of the eyes passes, without anyone choosing, without anyone teaching on purpose. If you look back, calmly, you may well find, in your line, women who made exactly the same movement.

A grandmother who gave herself whole to the house and the family and who, now and then, without anyone understanding why, locked herself in her room for an afternoon with the excuse of a migraine. A mother who was the soul of the parties and who came back from

them silent, emptied, unbearable for two days. They were not unstable either. They were links in a chain that learned, somewhere, far back, that being with people cost one's own centre, and that passed that bill on without ever putting it into words. You received the inheritance in the body before you could think it. The pendulum you swing today began to swing long before you were born.

I tell you this not to give you one more weight, not so that you may add to your own the guilt of all the grandmothers. I tell it to you for the opposite reason. When you see that the swinging is not your personal failing but a pattern handed to you, something loosens. The shame loses force. Because you stop being a broken and individual woman and become a woman in a place of a longer story, a woman to whom fell, perhaps, the task of being the first to notice the pattern. To notice is not to resolve, and I am not asking you to resolve anyone's inheritance. But there is an enormous difference between carrying a pendulum blindly and carrying it with your eyes open, knowing what it is, where it comes from, and that it is not you, it is an old way of loving that reached you looking for someone who would look at it. You can be the one who looks at it. That already changes the way you carry it.

Let us come back to the ground, to the concrete, because that is where the turn lives and the turn is small. I am not going to ask you to resolve the pendulum. Whoever promises you that they will take the pendulum away is selling you fusion or flight under another

name, and you already have enough of those two. What I am going to ask you is a tiny thing, and it happens inside the swing itself. Notice where the pendulum always catches you unarmed: in the middle. In the transition.

At the exact moment when you feel you gave too much and you are about to flee. That instant, the instant between being everything and disappearing, is the only place where you have power, because it is the only place where there is still choice. When you are already in full over-adaptation, you do not choose, you are dragged. When you are already in full isolation, you do not choose, you are locked away. But in the middle, at the moment when you feel the cord tightening, there is a crack. It is in that crack that the gesture is made.

The gesture is this, and I want you to hear it exactly as it is, without making it larger than it is. In the middle of the pendulum, when you feel you gave too much and the body is already asking to flee, instead of running to isolation, you make a tiny pause and you say something true. Small. One only. In a room where you used to be everything to everyone, you say out loud the small thing that is yours. Not the great truth that changes relationships, not the confrontation you put off your whole life. A small thing.

This tired me, I am just going to sit for a bit. Or, I have no opinion on that, today I just wanted to listen. Or, it was lovely to see you and I am at the end of my strength, I am going home earlier. A sentence in which you appear, the real you, in the middle of the room, without

disappearing from it. Do you see what this does? It is not fusion, because you did not mould yourself. It is not flight, because you did not leave. It is a third thing. It is presence. It is the first stone of the third ground.

Let me give you the gesture in slow motion, with a body around it, so that it does not stay abstract. Imagine yourself at that Sunday lunch, at that point of the afternoon when you have already seen to everything, already listened to everyone, already been the pillar for four hours, and you feel the cord in your chest tightening, that old warning that if you stay any longer you will have to flee the whole week to recover. It is exactly there, in that warning, that the gesture lives. Not fleeing already, with the excuse of work. Not staying two more hours emptying yourself to the end. In the middle. You get up, and instead of going to see to the next thing, you sit beside someone you are fond of and say a simple sentence.

I am a bit at my end, I am just going to sit here for a while doing nothing. You stay. Your body is going to shout, during those first minutes, that this is dangerous, that you are failing your role, that they will notice you stopped serving. Let it shout. Stay sitting. Almost certainly, what will happen is that the person tells you, all right, rest, and life goes on, and the ceiling does not fall. You have just done, live, the thing the pendulum told you was impossible: you were in a room, you stopped moulding yourself, you did not flee, and you went on belonging. It was small. It was everything.

. . .

I want to give you another, from the other side of the pendulum, in case you are more in the phase of the silent Fridays. There the gesture is not to stop giving yourself, it is the opposite, it is to take one step at a time out of the cell without emptying yourself. That friend who stopped insisting, the one you really cared about. The gesture, within this sign, is not to organise a great reunion, not to force yourself into a whole night that will exhaust you and confirm the old bill. It is less. It is to send her a small and true message. I thought of you today, I have had little rope for people but I miss you.

Notice what that sentence does that none of your usual exits did. It does not mould you, because you promise nothing you cannot keep. It does not hide you, because you appear, you say the truth of your

little. It is an appearing with the measure you have, and not with the measure she wanted, and that is why it is sustainable, that is why it will not throw you into three more days of flight. Isolation told you either I appear whole or I do not appear. The gesture teaches you to appear a little, with truth, and to discover that a little with truth is enough, and that no one demands of you the whole of old, it was you who demanded it of yourself.

Do you see the pattern of the two gestures? They are opposite in movement, one brakes the fusion, the other pierces the isolation, but they have the same root. Both ask you to appear with the true measure of what you have at that moment, instead of appearing with the measure the room wants or not appearing at all. Conscious belonging is not a state you reach. It is this tiny, repeated competence of being present at your own scale. There are days when your scale is large and you can give yourself a great deal, without danger, because you are full. There are days when your scale is small and the faithful thing to do is to appear little and to say so. The pendulum knew only the little that hides and the much that empties. The third ground is to have a scale, to know it, and to honour it out loud in the midst of people. That is learned. Not with force. With loving repetition of small gestures.

It looks like nothing. I know it looks like nothing. You are expecting an instruction equal to a pendulum that shakes your whole life and I give you a sentence of eight words said in the middle of a dinner. But



this is how conscious belonging is learned, not in a leap, one atom at a time. Because what you never had, in truth, was the repeated experience of being with people as yourself and nothing bad happening to you. All your old learning says that being you near others costs the centre, costs the peace, costs the place.

No idea undoes that learning. Only the new experience undoes it, given in doses small enough that the system does not fire. Each time you say a small and true thing in the middle of a room and the room does not collapse, your body records a new piece of data that contradicts the old bill. I was present, I was me, and I went on belonging. It was possible. I did not die. No one left. It is of many of those small data, and only of them, that the ground you have not yet inhabited is slowly built.

There is a banal sentence that can serve you as a compass, and it comes disguised as a compliment, as the verdicts that mark us most always do. Sooner or later someone tells you, with the best of intentions, you are so easy to be with. The compliment feels good, of course, because it was to deserve it that you trained your whole life. But I want you, the next time you hear it, to notice what it reveals. You are easy to be with because you moulded yourself to me. Because you were no trouble, because you guessed what I wanted, because my tuning was all turned to your station and none to mine.

Being easy to be with was the coin with which you paid for your presence for years. Conscious belonging, the real one, costs you your

place as the easy one. Because a person who appears, who has a temperature of her own, who is sometimes tired and says so, who has an opinion and holds it, that person is not so easy. She is more real. There are those who stay and those who think you changed. The ones who stay are your new table. The ones who think you changed go on at the old table, and the old table is still good, it goes on being a good table for whoever needs you easy. It only stopped being yours.

Because this is what no one warns you of when they speak to you of limits and of being yourself, as though it were only a matter of courage, as though it were enough to decide. What is at stake, beneath the pendulum, is a mourning. The mourning of the place you had when you were everything to everyone. That place was good. It was not a prison, not at the start, it was a place where you were loved and needed and indispensable, and there is an enormous comfort in being indispensable, there is a whole identity built on it.

What I ask of you, when I ask you to appear in the middle of the pendulum, is that you begin to give up that good place. Not in the heat of the moment, not with a slammed gate. Slowly, one small sentence at a time. But it is a farewell all the same, and it would be dishonest of me to call it anything else. You are saying goodbye to the woman who managed to be everything to everyone. You will miss her. She was capable, she was loved, she knew her place in any room. It is hard to leave her, even when she was killing you slowly.

Notice, very carefully, what you are not leaving. You are not leaving the people. This is the confusion the pendulum imposes on you and that I want to undo for good. The pendulum tells you that either you stay with them, and in that case you dissolve, or you save yourself, and in that case you lose them. To adapt or to disappear, as though to love and to be were enemies. But what you learned badly was not to love people, it was to be with them in a single way, the way of moulding yourself.

To let go of that way is not to let go of the people. It is to let go of the old way of being with them, to find a way where you too fit. You go on loving exactly the same people. The sister, the friend, the family table, the father who laughs at your stories. None of those loves ends. What ends is the way you give yourself, that yes, the way that emptied you. You stop being the mouldable version and start being a whole version, and that robs no one. It only gives you back to yourself.

The hermit you built in there, the woman who is enough for herself and does not need, does not have to die either. I want you to see this, because sometimes, when we finally begin to come out of the isolation, we are tempted to hate the part of us that locked itself away, as though it were a traitor. It is not. The hermit saved you. It was she who held your centre when the world was spending all of it. Do not cast her out. Thank her. What she did wrong was not to

protect you, it was to protect you too much, to have stayed on guard long after the war ended.

You do not need to dismiss her, you need to tell her that now you can be you too when there are people in the room, that she no longer has to be the only place where you withdraw. As conscious belonging grows, as you accumulate the small proofs that being with people as yourself is possible, the hermit loosens on her own. She no longer has to work so hard. She stops being a cell and goes back to being what she should always have been, a room where you withdraw sometimes, with a door that opens and closes, and not a whole house locked against the world.

There are those who hear all this and say, but then what about when I really need to be alone, is that flight? No, hear me well, it is not. To learn conscious belonging is not the prohibition of solitude. Chosen solitude, the one that comes from someone who is full and wants to rest, is one of the healthiest things there is, and you will always need it. The difference between healthy withdrawal and the flight of the pendulum is not in the act, it is in the origin. You withdraw out of flight when you do it because you gave too much and can no longer bear your own dissolution, and in that case the silence is a cure for a wound you did not have to open.

You withdraw in health when you do it from a centre you did not lose, when you go to your room not to flee people but to come back to yourself, and tomorrow you reappear without the hangover of

guilt. The same gesture, two opposite origins. As you appear more in the middle of the pendulum, you will notice that you need the flight less and less, because you no longer empty yourself to the end, and that the solitude that remains takes on another taste, the taste of rest and not of the wounded retreat.

I come back down to the ground before we close, because I do not want you to leave here with a pretty theory and no gesture in your hand. Think of a concrete room in your life, one where the pendulum always catches you. It can be the family table on Sunday, it can be the Friday group of friends, it can be a meeting where you are always the one who calms tempers. Choose one. And for the next time you are there, prepare in advance, calmly, your small and true thing. Not the great one, the small one.

The sentence that says this is me, without making a drama, without asking permission, without dissolving into what the room wants. Rehearse it, if you must, because at first you will feel the body shout that this is dangerous, that you will lose your place, that they will find you difficult. That shout is the old bill defending itself. Say the sentence all the same. Small. True. Then stay in the room and watch what happens. Almost certainly, what will happen is nothing bad. It is of that nothing bad, repeated slowly, that the thing the pendulum never let you have is born.

I do not promise you that from tomorrow you stop swinging. It would be a lie, and you have had too many promises. The pendulum

you inherited took generations to assemble and is not dismantled in one chapter. What I tell you is smaller and truer. That from the moment you appear in the middle of the swing, even once, even trembling, you stop being only at the mercy of the two extremes. You dig, with one sentence, a first handsbreadth of third ground. And the third ground is not conquered, it is inhabited, a little more each time, as the body learns, proof after proof, that to belong does not require you to disappear and that to be does not require you to flee.

It is not fitting back into the room where you dissolved. It is staying in that same room, with the same people you always loved, and being there for the first time as you. Go on swinging, if you must, a while longer. But the next times, in the middle, in the instant of the crack, stay. Say your small thing. And notice that the room did not collapse, that no one left, and that you, for the first time, were present without having ceased to be home inside yourself.

S I G N 5



Your nervous system  
begins to reject certain  
environments

*I cannot anymore.*



There are rooms where you breathe deeply without knowing you are breathing deeply. There are rooms where the air becomes something you have to push. The chest closes a millimetre, the shoulders rise another, and there is a part of you already calculating the hour at which you can leave without offending anyone. You decided none of this. You did not think. Your body went in before you, read the whole house in a fraction of a second and took a position that your head will spend the night trying to deny.

You arrive at a place where you were welcome. Where you are still welcome, notice, that has not changed. You ring the bell of a house where you have been happy. The moment the door opens, before the embrace, before the smell of the food, before any word, your body tightens. A small tightening, at stomach level, like someone bracing for something that has not yet come. You go in smiling. The smile is real, you are not feigning affection. Beneath the smile there is a clock that has started to count.

You know this tightening. Everyone knows it, though few people say it out loud, because to say it seems an accusation, and you do not want to accuse anyone. There is no one to accuse. The people in that room are good people. They receive you well. They laugh with you. Even so, the moment you go in, a part of you wants to get back in the car, close the door and breathe the silence again.

Perhaps it happens to you at the Christmas table. Perhaps at a dinner of old colleagues you insist on keeping out of a loyalty you no



longer know to what. Perhaps in the kitchen of the house where you grew up, with the same chairs, the same yellow light above the table, the same people saying the same things they always said. Nothing changed there. It is precisely because nothing changed that your body no longer fits.

I want you to notice something before we go on, because it is the whole thing. Your body understood first. Your head is still negotiating, explaining, finding reasons for it to be nothing. Your body has already decided. Between what the body decides and what the head accepts, years can pass.

There is an old wisdom in the body that the head does not have, and it is a wisdom that does not ask permission. When you go into a room, your body reads everything at once, without words: the temperature of the people, what can be said and what cannot, the form of you that this place will accept and the form it will tell you to keep. It does this whole reading before you hang up your coat. It takes a position. The head, that one, always arrives late, with explanations in hand, trying to rewrite a decision that was already made on a floor where it does not rule. That is why you so often feel divided in certain rooms: you are not divided, you are hearing two voices that do not speak at the same time. One has already decided. The other is still arguing whether it has the right to decide.

Think of how many times, years later, you understood something about a place or a person and your reaction was not surprise, it was

recognition. I always knew, you said. I always knew. Well you always knew, only the one who knew was the body, and you would not let it speak because the head had better and better-dressed arguments. The body does not argue. It tightens. We were trained to think that a well-made argument is worth more than a tightening without words, when often it is exactly the other way round.

The conscious mind is a negotiator. It sits at the table of your discomfort and proposes deals. It says you are tired, that it was the week, that you ate too much, that perhaps you are turning unpleasant with age. It says that maybe it is you, that everyone manages to be there without this tightening, that the problem must be yours. The conscious mind has an enormous talent for convincing you that the sign is not a sign, it is a defect. While it negotiates, your body, which does not know how to lie, goes on doing that small thing at the door of certain houses: closing.

I am going to ask you not to treat this as weakness. Treat it as information. Because that is what it is.

There is a difference no one taught you to make, and that changes everything from the moment you make it. It is the difference between leaving a place tired and leaving a place diminished.

To leave tired is an honest and simple thing. You were with many people, you talked a lot, you did sums, you smiled for hours, you managed children or hard conversations or too much noise. Your

body spent itself. It is a tiredness of muscle, of attention, of presence. You go home, you sleep, and the next day the account is settled. You wake whole. The place where you were goes on being a good place, and you would go back, only with more energy. Overload asks one thing only: rest. You give it rest and it passes.

To leave diminished is something else entirely. You did not come away smaller because you talked a lot. You came away smaller because, to fit in that room, you had to shrink a part of yourself. You had to keep an opinion, smother a reaction, laugh at something that did not make you laugh, let pass a sentence that hurt you so as not to spoil the atmosphere. You made yourself smaller, millimetre by millimetre, all night, and you did not even notice while you were there, because you have done it for so long that the shrinking became natural posture. You only notice afterward. In the car. In the silence. When the body decompresses and you feel, suddenly, the exact amount of you that was left outside so that you could be inside.

Perhaps you find it hard to believe they are two such different things, because they both dress in the same clothes. They both dress as tiredness. You get home and say I am exhausted, and you use the same word for the night when you laughed a lot with people you love and for the night when you shrank hour after hour in a room where you did not fit. The word is the same. The thing beneath the word is as different as the warmth of a hearth is from the warmth of a fever. Both warm. One heals, the other sickens.

Here is the test, the only one you need to know. Overload is resolved with sleep. Incoherence is not.

Sleep a whole night after a room that diminished you. Sleep ten hours. Wake up. Look. The tiredness of that room is still there. Not in the body, which rested. It is still in another place, a place for which we have no simple word, somewhere between the chest and the throat, a kind of dull weight the sleep did not touch. Because sleep does not heal incoherence. Sleep heals muscular effort. Incoherence is healed only one way, and that way is not rest, it is truth. That is why so many people sleep and sleep and sleep and go on exhausted from a life that looks, from outside, perfectly comfortable. They do not need more rest. They need less shrinking. They are things that live on different planets, though they both dress as tiredness.

I am going to give you the signs by name, because recognising them one by one is half the work.

The tightening at the door. That instant, before going in, when the body braces. It is not fear. You fear nothing concrete. It is the anticipation of effort, your system assembling the armour it will need to spend the next hours being a version of you more tidied, more fittable, more pleasant than what you are when no one is asking you to be convenient.

The urge to leave the moment you arrive. You sat down five minutes ago and you are already thinking when you can get up. Not because

the place is bad. Because the place asks of you an expense you no longer want to pay, and the body, which does sums faster than the head, has already seen the price and already wants to refuse the purchase.

The tiredness that does not pass with sleep. We have spoken of it. It is the signature. It is the fingerprint of incoherence. When sleep does not resolve it, it is not the body that is ill. It is the life that is misaligned, and the tiredness is the name we give to the misalignment because we have no other to hand.

The way the body closes in certain rooms. The shoulders that rise. The chin that drops. The arms that cross without an order. The breath that goes short, at the tip of the lungs, never down at the bottom. The voice that changes tone, thinner, more careful, more on the outside. You do not order these things done. They do themselves. They are the physical translation of a sentence your head still does not let you say: here, I cannot be whole.

There are more signs, and each woman has them in her own way, but all belong to the same family. The sleep that does not come after certain conversations, even when tired. The way your voice changes from house to house, more open in some, more tidied in others, without your ordering it. The hurry to press the lift button before anyone else gets in, after a room that cost you. The physical relief, almost animal, when a certain person says they cannot come after all, and the immediate shame of that relief. The tiredness that

knocks at your door the day before, before you even leave the house, just at the thought that tomorrow is the lunch. You have noticed that you fall ill with a strange ease around certain commitments. You have noticed that your body finds ways not to go. It is not weakness, it is not cunning. It is the body using the only language it has to tell you something your mouth still has not the courage to say.

Notice that none of this is dramatic. You do not faint. You do not cry. There is no scene. It is all minute, so small that for years it passes under the radar, and it is precisely because it is so small that it is so reliable. The great emotions lie, exaggerate, stage. These tiny signs do not. They have no imagination to lie. They say only what is.

Now let me speak to you of what you do with this, because it is here that most of us get lost.

You do not tell the truth about the sign. You tell a lie about yourself.

The truth of the sign would be: this environment asks of me something I can no longer give without betraying myself. The lie about yourself is cheaper and more to hand, and it is this: I am becoming a difficult person.

. . .

Listen to yourself. Listen to the things you say about yourself after leaving one of those rooms. I am turning unpleasant. I no longer have patience for anyone. Before I bore this well, now I bear nothing, it must be me. I am becoming antisocial. There must be something wrong with me. I am harder and harder to put up with. It used to be easier to be with me.

You know this monologue. It is a monologue of self-accusation that you recite with a frightening fluency, because you have rehearsed it many times. It has one characteristic you should notice: it is always about you being worse. Never about the environment no longer serving. The blame stays entirely with you, and the place stays intact, generous, above any suspicion. You carry the whole weight of something that is not yours alone.

There is a reason you prefer this lie to the truth, a deep and almost tender reason. Thinking yourself difficult keeps the table safe. If the problem is you, then the table goes on being the good place it always was, and you can go on belonging to it, even as the defective version of you. But to tell the truth, to say this environment no longer serves who I am, that threatens the belonging, and belonging is the oldest thing you have, older than your own memory. So your system

chooses to sacrifice you rather than risk the table. It prefers that you be the failure than that the place be questioned.

It is a child's choice, in the most literal sense: it was the child you were who learned that it was safer to be the problem than to lose the table, because a child does not survive without the table, and you learned that when you had no way yet of learning anything else. You grew up, but the choice stayed. You go on preferring to be the defective one than to put the table in question, and you call this humility when it is, in truth, the last gesture of a child who did not believe she could belong without accusing herself.

I am going to tell you a sentence and I want you to read it slowly. Your body is not failing. Your body is informing.

What you call turning unpleasant is your nervous system refusing to go on paying a price it paid for years without complaining. What you call turning antisocial is your capacity, finally tuned, to tell apart the environments that fill you from the environments that empty you, a capacity you should always have had and that upbringing, good upbringing, taught you to switch off. What you call being difficult is, most of the time, being finally clear about where you fit whole and where you fit only shrunken.

The body is not the problem. The body is the compass. You spent years treating your compass as a factory defect, apologising for it pointing, trying to re-educate it to point where everyone says we



should want to go. A compass is not re-educated. It points. It is the only honest thing you have inside you that has not yet learned to lie out of convenience.

There is a cruel detail in the way you learned to distrust it. The better brought up you were, the more they taught you to be easy to put up with, to be no trouble, to put the comfort of others before your own, the more you learned to silence the compass. Because a girl who said I cannot be here, this place tightens me, was a difficult girl, and no one wants to be a difficult girl. So you learned to say everything is fine with your mouth while the body said it is not with the shoulders, and you did it so well, for so long, that you stopped hearing the body at all. You silenced the compass so deep that you came to think you had none. Now, when it points again, instead of greeting it like an old friend returning, you are frightened of it, like someone hearing a voice in a house they thought empty. The voice was always there. It was you who learned to pretend the house was empty.

Why has it only started to point now, you ask. You spent years in those rooms with no tightening. What changed?

Nothing changed in the room. You changed. It is here that we need to go deeper, because the truth of this sign is not only in your body. It is in something larger, in a fabric that ties you to these rooms far longer than your memory reaches.

You did not arrive at these tables by chance. Some of them are your family. Others are friendships of so many years that they became almost family. Others are workplaces where you spend more waking hours than with those you love. All of them have one thing in common: you learned to be in them. You learned early, in many cases before you had words, what form of you that place accepted. Which parts could appear and which parts were better kept. What you could laugh at and what you could not. When you should speak and when your silence made the room more comfortable.

It was no one's cruelty. It was the way groups keep themselves whole. Every group, every family, every table, has a format, its own way of being together, and each person who belongs there learns to fit that format the way a piece learns to fit the hole it was given. The piece does not complain about the hole. It adapts. It files itself down where needed. For a long time the filing is not even felt, because the piece is still growing and grows already with that shape.

The problem, if one can call a problem something so natural, is that you went on growing after the shape was fixed. The table stopped asking you for new versions. It asks you for the same version as always, the version you learned to be there at ten, at twenty, at thirty. That version, for years, fit. It fit because you still resembled it. Now it has stopped fitting, not because the table tightened, but because you grew out of it, and each time you come back you have

to fold yourself again into the old shape, and your body, which grew with you and not with the table, refuses to fold without protest.

This is the tightening at the door. It is your body seeing, before you, the old shape waiting. The shape you will have to wear. Refusing, with that small closing, to wear a garment that already tightens you everywhere.

Think of who you are in those rooms. Not who you are in general, who you are there. There is a version of you that exists only at your family table, a way of speaking, a place where you sit, jokes you repeat, silences you keep. There is a version of you that exists only in that group of friends of twenty years, and that perhaps no longer resembles at all the woman you are on the other days of the week. These versions are not false. They were true. They were the exact form you learned in order to belong to those places, and for a long time they served, because you fit them as in a tailored mould. What happened was nothing bad. It happened only that you went on living outside those rooms. You grew in directions those rooms never saw. Now, when you come back, you have to leave all those directions at the door, the way one leaves a coat, and put on the old version again, and it tightens everywhere because it was sewn for a body you no longer have.

No one there maliciously asks you to be small again. They ask you with love to be who you were again, because it is who you were that they miss, it is that person they know how to love. You, to give them

what they ask, fold all the directions inward and become the old version for a few hours. It is an act of love, notice. It is out of love that you fold. But the body, that one, cannot tell the fold made out of love from the fold made out of fear. To it, a fold is a fold, and it tightens all the same, because the part of you that grew does not disappear just because you sent it inside for a few hours. It stays there, pressed in, aching, waiting for the night to end.

I want you to see that this does not make the table a bad place. It makes the table a place that was designed for a version of you that no longer exists whole. The table is fine. It fulfils the function it was made for. It goes on receiving, with the same shape, the people who still fit it, and those people are happy there, and they do well. The table did not fail you. It is you who grew, and growing has this strange price of leaving you too large for places where you were exactly the right size.

There is a word for what you feel in these rooms, and it is a word you will resist using because it seems too large for something as small as a dinner. The word is mourning.

You are in mourning for a place that was good.

It is not the mourning of death. No one died. The people are all alive, all at the table, all calling you with affection. It is a mourning harder to grieve than that of death, precisely because no one died and the place is still there, intact, in front of you, working perfectly for

everyone except you. You grieve a place that did not disappear. You grieve a belonging that is still offered to you and that you can no longer accept on the terms on which it is offered. You are losing something no one took from you.

There is no villain in this loss. I want this to be very clear, because your head is going to look for someone to blame, because it is easier to lose something when there is someone to blame for the loss. There is no one. The people at that table did not do you harm. They did not exclude you. They did not change with you, and that, in truth, is what hurts most: they did not change. They go on loving the version of you they knew, with all the sincerity in the world, and offering you her place at the table. The place is still warm, with your name on it. It is you who no longer fit it, and that is no one's fault. It is only what happens when a person grows and the place where she learned to be stays the size of who she was.

I want to insist on this because the temptation to invent a villain is enormous, and it is a temptation that looks like mercy but is poison. It would be so much simpler if there were a bad person at that table, one who diminished you on purpose, one you could point to and say it was because of her. You would have a clean story, with a right side and a wrong side, and you could move away with the clear conscience of someone who fled an evil. But the truth is harder to carry than any villain. The truth is that the table is good. The people are good.

They treat you well, they wish you well, and even so you come away smaller, and there is no one you can blame for it except the very fact that you grew. There is no injustice to denounce. There is only a quiet unsuitability between who you became and the place where you learned to be, and quiet unsuitabilities do not make pretty stories, they grant no one the right, they do not let you walk out slamming the door. They leave you only there, at the table, loving good people and not fitting, with no one to be angry at, which is the most solitary mourning there is.

This is the part almost no one tells you, because it is an uncomfortable truth: you can love exactly the same people and stop being the same person beside them. The two things fit at the same time. The affection diminished nothing. What diminished was your capacity to pretend, at their table, that you are still who you were when that table was tailored to you. You go on loving them. It is only that loving them no longer obliges you to shrink to fit where they kept your place. To discover this is one of the most silent solitudes there is, because you have no one to share it with: the people who would understand your loss are exactly the people it loses.

. . .

I remember a woman who told me, with a simplicity that stayed with me, a banal sentence that fell like a verdict. She was speaking

of her mother's house, of the Sunday lunch she went to every week for forty years, and she said: I like going there, only I always come back smaller. She said nothing more. She did not need to. It is all there, in that tiny sentence. The real liking. The loyalty of forty Sundays. The price: coming back smaller. No complaint against the mother, notice. No accusation. The mother does not diminish her on purpose. The mother loves her, loves her with all the love she has, and offers her at the table the place of the daughter she was, because that is the place the mother knows how to set. The daughter, who grew out of that place, sits in it every Sunday out of love, and folds herself into it out of love, and goes home, out of love, smaller.

This has no easy solution, and I am not going to lie to you by promising you one. But it has a turn, and the turn is smaller than you are expecting, and it fits whole inside the sign itself.

The turn is not to change anything on the outside. It is not to stop going to the table. It is not a letter of rupture, a hard conversation, a cut. You do not have to do any of that, and most of you, which loves those people, does not want to do any of that, and it does well. The turn is more inward, more silent, and it begins with one thing only: learning to read the body instead of silencing it.

For years you treated your body like a badly behaved pupil you had to put in order. It tightened, you ordered it to relax. It wanted to leave, you forced it to stay two more hours. It closed, you forced it to open. You treated your own body as the enemy of your good

upbringing. The turn is to stop treating it as an enemy and to start treating it as an informant. You do not obey it blindly, note. You do not get up and leave every dinner where you feel a tightening, that would be to trade one tyranny for another. You listen to it. You ask it what it knows. You learn to ask the one question that separates overload from incoherence.

To listen to the body is not a mystical or complicated thing. It is almost boring for being so concrete. It is to notice, at the door of a house, that your shoulders rose, and instead of ordering them down, to ask quietly, what do you know that I do not yet want to know. It is to notice, halfway through a dinner, that you are breathing up high, at the tip of the lungs, and instead of forcing yourself to breathe deeply to disguise it, to let that short breath tell you what it has to say.

The body speaks in a language of small gestures, and you spent your life translating those gestures into the language of self-accusation. The shoulders rise and you translate I am tense, what a bother I am. The breath shortens and you translate I am anxious, I should relax. You are translating badly. The right translation of the shoulders that rise is here I brace to defend myself. The right translation of the short breath is here I do not let myself be taken up whole. The body is not failing the translation. It is you who made it into the wrong language.



The question is this, and it is the whole turn: after you leave an environment, in the car, in the silence, before the head begins to negotiate, you ask yourself, did I come away tired or did I come away diminished?

It is a small question and almost no one asks it, because no one taught us that there were two different things there. We think tiredness is tiredness. It is not. Ask. And learn to feel the difference, because the difference is felt, not thought. The tiredness of overload is clean, almost sweet, it is the tiredness of one who spent herself living. You lay your head down and it dissolves. The tiredness of incoherence is dull, it stays lodged in you, and you already recognise it, because it is the same one that is still there the next day after you sleep. When you notice it, you already know. It was not the amount of people. It was the amount of you that was left outside.

Ask this question once. Then again. Go on gathering the answers, without haste, without deciding anything with them, only gathering them. You will notice something: certain environments always leave you tired and never diminished, and those are yours, keep them, they are home, you can go there and empty yourself freely because you fill back up. Other environments leave you almost always diminished, however well they treat you, and those, they are not bad, notice, I am not telling you to cut them off, they are only environments that ask of you a version you no longer are, and to

know that, only to know that, without yet doing anything with it, already changes you on the inside.

Because the violence, the real violence you have been doing to yourself, was not going to those tables. It was going to those tables and calling yourself unpleasant for feeling what you felt there. It was coming away diminished and blaming yourself for the diminishing, as though it were you failing and not the environment asking of you an impossible thing. The turn does not take you from the tables. It takes from you the self-accusation. You stop leaving a hard room thinking you have a defect and start leaving it thinking, with a new serenity, that environment asks of me a form I no longer have, and it does not matter, and it is no one's fault, and I can go back there knowing now what it costs me.

This is called honouring the sign. To honour a sign is not to obey it. It is to stop denying it. It is to stop telling your body that it is wrong when it tightens at the door of certain houses. It is to grant it its point, in silence, without having to explain to anyone, without having to make any scene. You know what you feel. The body informed. For the first time in many years, instead of arguing with it, you tell it: I heard you. You are right. Thank you.

There is an enormous difference, and I want you to keep it, between honouring a sign and obeying an impulse. To obey the impulse would be to get up in the middle of every dinner where you feel a tightening and leave, to stop answering whoever tires you, to cut off

everything that costs you. That is not freedom, it is a new prison, only with other bars. Whoever obeys every impulse of the body becomes a slave to it just as before she was a slave to good upbringing. To honour is different. To honour is to hear the information and then choose, in conscience, what you do with it.

Sometimes you hear the tightening and you stay all the same, out of love, and you stay whole in your choice because it was a choice. Other times you hear the tightening and you see that that room is no longer worth what it costs you, and you move away slowly, without drama, without a slammed door. What changes is not what you do on the outside. What changes is that you stopped betraying yourself on the inside. You stopped pretending you did not hear. And whoever stops pretending she does not hear recovers something she had lost without noticing: the sense of being a whole person, even when she chooses to fold. Because a chosen fold does not break. A forced and denied fold, that one breaks, little by little, every day.

Notice what this does. It does not change the table. The table stays the same, with the same shape, with the same good people, with the place warm and waiting for you. What changes is you sitting there. You no longer fold with shame at folding. If you fold, you know you are folding, you know why, and you do it, if you decide to, as a choice of love and not as a blind obligation. There is an enormous dignity in folding out of love knowing you are folding, and there is none in

folding out of habit and calling yourself difficult for it. It is the same physical posture. On the inside, they are different lives.

There are those who think honouring the body is a luxury, a thing for whoever has time to listen to herself. It is the opposite. It is one of the most practical things there is. Your body is saving you years. It is telling you, with that small tightening, a truth your head would take a decade to admit, if it admitted it at all. Each tightening at the door is free information about where you fit and where you do not, and you have been throwing it away, calling it a symptom, calling it a defect, asking a doctor for a pill to silence it when all it wanted was to be heard once.

I am not telling you that everything the body tightens about is incoherence, mind. Sometimes it is only overload, and overload is resolved with rest, and there is nothing deeper in it. That is why the question matters so much. The question separates. I came away tired, rest, go back. I came away diminished, there a truth is waiting, and rest does not touch it, and pretending it does is like taking syrup for a hunger. You will feel better for a few minutes and the hunger is still there, because the hunger was not for syrup.

Let me tell you one last scene, small, because it has all of this inside.

A person I know spent a whole Christmas thinking herself awful. She sat at the family table, the table of always, and halfway through the dinner she caught herself counting the minutes until she could

leave. She felt the tightening from the door. She felt the body close when she sat down. Instead of listening to the body, she did what we all do: she turned against herself. What a horrible person I am, she thought, who cannot bear a Christmas with my family, who wants to leave a table where everyone loves me, there must be something very wrong with me. She went home hating herself. She slept badly, chewing over her own coldness. She woke the next day with the tiredness of that Christmas still whole in her chest, and it was that tiredness that did not pass, that stubborn tiredness sleep did not carry off, that finally made her stop and ask, maybe it is not me being horrible, maybe my body is telling me something I do not want to hear.

The thing the body was telling was not hatred. It was mourning. That table, which she loved, had been tailored to a girl she no longer was. The table had not changed. The people had not changed. They went on loving the girl, keeping her the girl's place, talking to her as though she were still the girl. She, who had grown out of that place, sat in it every Christmas and shrank to fit, and always came away smaller, and called that smallness a defect of character when it was only the exact mark of a garment that already tightened her.

The next Christmas she came back. She came back, notice, she did not cut anyone off, she made no speech, she broke nothing. She came back to the same table, with the same people, and she felt the same tightening at the door. Only this time she did not call herself

horrible. This time, before going in, she said inwardly: you tighten because you know that here I am going to fold a little, and that is all right, today I choose to fold for these people, because I love them, and tomorrow, in the car, I am not going to call myself unpleasant for it. I am only going to recognise that these are my own, and that I no longer fit whole into their shape, and that the two things are true at the same time.

She came away tired from that Christmas. Tired, not diminished, and the difference was not in the table, which was the same. It was in her, who stopped lying to herself about what that table cost her, and in stopping the lie, she stopped wounding herself on top of the cost. The cost stayed. The wound she used to put on top of the cost, that one went.

This is what you have to do, and it is only this, for now. You do not have to change tables. You do not have to cut anyone off. You do not have to have the hard conversation you keep putting off, not yet, perhaps never. You have one thing only, small and yours, that no one sees and that changes everything: to listen to your body at the door of houses. To ask it the question in the car, in the silence. Did I come away tired or did I come away diminished. And to believe its answer, for the first time, more than you believe your head's negotiation.

Because your body does not wish you ill. It never did. It was always on your side, tightening at the door of the rooms that shrink you,

wanting to leave the tables that ask of you old versions, closing in the places that diminish you, and you called it a defect your whole life. It is not a defect. It is the part of you that refused to lie, even when all your good upbringing ordered it to lie. It is the only compass you have that has not yet learned to point where it is convenient. To begin to follow it, slowly, without cutting anything, without promising to arrive anywhere, only to listen to it where before you silenced it, is the most loyal thing you can do for yourself.

You remain at the table, if you want to remain. You come back, if you want to come back. But you begin to know, finally, what it costs you to be where you are. And to know what it costs, without blaming yourself for the cost, without making the person you love the villain of your smallness, is the first true gesture of a woman who stopped treating her own body as a traitor and began to treat it as what it always was: the first to know, and the last she had not yet learned to listen to.

I cannot anymore, says the body. And for the first time you do not answer yes you can, come on. You answer: I know. I heard you. From today we are going to do this together.

SIGN 6



You begin to confuse  
peace with the absence of  
people

*Maybe it is better alone.*





There is a Friday night you know well. You turned down the invitation. Not with sharpness, nor with a lie, you turned it down with that grace you have already learned to have, real tiredness serving as a real excuse, and so no one could argue with you. You did not switch off the phone, no, that would be too dramatic, you left it face down on the table, which comes to almost the same thing. You sat down. There was, in the first half hour, something so good rising up through your chest that it almost frightened you with its cleanness. Silence. A warm house. Your breathing returning to a rhythm that did not have to keep up with anyone else's. You thought, without saying it aloud because there was no aloud in which to say it, that maybe this was it. That maybe it had always been this. That you had been looking in people for something that was here all along, on this sofa, in this low light, in this not having to.

It is that not having to we need to speak about with great care, because it is the place where this sign hides, and it is the place where we most easily deceive ourselves with the best of intentions.

First, though, let me tell you that I understand where this comes from. You did not arrive at this Friday on a whim. You arrived after many tables. There was a time when you went to everything, when being with people was the most natural thing in the world, when you walked into a room and the room cost you nothing, it was just a room with good people inside it. Those people are still good. This has

to be said straight away, and said to your face, because everything that follows depends on us not forgetting it: the people you withdraw from did you no harm. There is no villain here.

There is no betrayal, no rupture, no bitterness that justifies the distance and proves you right. The same people who once filled you are still the same people. The dinners are the same dinners. The conversations have the same warmth they always had, and you know they do, because you see others warming themselves at them exactly as before. The house that used to gather you still gathers. The tablecloth is the same. The chairs are the same. Nothing there has changed. You changed. That is the part that hurts in a way that has no one to be angry with, because it is no one's fault, not even yours. No one failed. What still serves so well everyone who stayed around the table simply stopped serving you.

There was, in fact, a sentence. There is almost always a sentence, one of those said without weight that go on weighing a lifetime. Someone said to you, in the middle of a dinner, with the good faith of someone who only wants you to be well, you are very quiet today. It was not an accusation. It was care. It was precisely the care that went through you, because it forced you to notice what you already knew and were managing to ignore as long as no one said it aloud: that you were there, and at the same time you were not there, that your body was sitting at that table out of respect for everything it

had once been, and your soul had left the room without anyone seeing it go.

You smiled, you said it was only tiredness, and it really was tiredness, and it was not only tiredness. You left early. On the way home, instead of sadness, you felt that clean relief again. It was there, perhaps, that you began to confuse the two things. It was there that the relief of leaving a table that was no longer your home began to look like the discovery that maybe you were better off with no table at all.

It is that not having to we need to speak about with great care.

Notice what you felt. It was not joy, exactly. It was relief. Relief is a magnificent and treacherous thing at once, because it tastes of peace and is not always peace. Relief is what you feel when you stop carrying a weight. In that there is a truth I will not take from you: you really were carrying a weight. You did not invent the tiredness to prove yourself right. When you refused that Friday, you refused something real, you refused having to arrive and smile before you felt like smiling, you refused having to find a subject, you refused having to be a version of yourself that fit inside the conversation, you refused having to explain where you have been and how you have been and why you have been so absent, yes, absent, that was the word someone used and that stuck in you like a thin bone. You refused all of that. In exchange you received a warm house and silence. You traded well. Who would not trade.

Except there is a question here you have not yet asked, and it is the whole question of this chapter. It is not whether you traded well tonight. You did. It is whether, night after night, this trade is returning you to the world or pushing it away for good. It is whether the silence that tasted so good to you today is the silence that fills, or the silence that empties slowly and convinces you that you were full. They are two silences, and they taste exactly the same in the mouth. That is the fine cruelty of this sign. The other signs in this book had outlines. You felt the not belonging at the table, you felt it in the body, you felt the discomfort pushing you. Not this one. This sign does not hurt. This sign caresses. This sign arrives disguised as a cure, and that is why it is the hardest of them all.

Let me first tell you what I am not going to tell you, so that we can breathe. I am not going to tell you that you need more people. I am not going to tell you that solitude is a problem to be solved, that you have to force yourself out, that the healthy thing is to be in company and the sick thing is to be alone. It would be a lie and you would know it was a lie, and I would lose the right to speak with you about the rest. Solitude is legitimate. Chosen solitude is, very often, the most intelligent and most loving thing a person can do for herself. There are withdrawals that save lives. There are silences without which we would never hear anything again, not ourselves, not the world, not the music. You, who keep withdrawing, may be doing the most right thing of your life. It may well be so. It is precisely because

it may well be so that I have to be so careful in helping you know whether it is.

Because there are two things that resemble each other too closely.

There is a peace that is born of meeting yourself. There is a peace that is only the relief of not having to meet anyone. They wear the same clothes. Both arrive in a warm house and low light. Both arrive when you switch off the phone. Both tell you everything is fine now, you can rest. The difference is not in the moment. It is in what comes after. That is why this chapter is not going to ask you to do anything different on your Fridays, at least not yet. It is going to ask you only to learn to listen to the after.

I know the first peace. You know it too, even if you may have lost sight of it. It is that kind of time alone you come out of larger. You read for a whole afternoon and at the end you want to call someone to tell them what you read, not out of need, out of overflow, because there was so much good that it did not fit in you alone. You walk alone and halfway through the walk the world becomes sharper, the people you see in the street stop being obstacles and become people again, and you feel a simple, warm desire to be part of that once more.

You spend a weekend shut away tending to yourself and on Monday you do not fear Monday, you return to it with a kind of good hunger. That peace expands. You recognise it by the fact that it widens your

radius. After it, the world becomes larger, not smaller. You come back more capable of people, not less. Healthy withdrawal has this unmistakable signature: it increases your capacity to return. It is an inhale. Every inhale exists so that, afterwards, there can be an exhale.

I know the second peace. You know that one too, and it is with that one I have to be exact, because it is the one that deceives. That one does not return you to the world. That one shuts the door a little harder each time. After that one, you do not have more desire to call anyone, you have less. You do not wait for Monday with hunger, you wait for it with a tightening, and Sunday night begins to have that colour you know. That peace does not expand, it shrinks. The worst of it is that it sells itself as the first. It tells you that you have finally discovered who you are. It tells you that you have matured. It tells you that you have learned, with age, not to need others, and it dresses that sentence as wisdom, as if not needing were a trophy and not, sometimes, a wound that stopped bleeding on the outside and goes on bleeding within. That peace does not fill you. It empties you so slowly, with such delicacy, that you swear you are filling up.

I will give it a simple name, without theories. There is a withdrawal that is meeting, and there is an isolation that is flight. The difference between the two is not seen in the act. It is seen in the direction.

Let me show you the mechanics, because they are precise and almost invisible, and until you see them you will go on confusing the

two.

Imagine that every time you are with people there is a cost. I am not talking about bad people, nor toxic relationships, nor anything that deserves to be cut off. I am talking about the normal cost, the cost all relationships have, the cost of being with others: you have to translate yourself. There is always a translation. When you are alone, your inner experience and your expression are the same thing, there is no gap. You feel and you are that, without mediation. But the moment another person enters, a gap opens between what you feel and what you show, and that gap has to be filled with work.

You have to choose words. You have to calculate what the other person can bear to hear today. You have to manage your face. You have to sustain an expectation they have of you, even if that expectation is only that you are reasonably well. You have to perform, even minimally, a continuity, the continuity of being the person they know. All of this is the cost of company. It is a real cost. You are not being weak for feeling it. You are being human.

There is a cost within the cost, the finest of all, which is that of keeping yourself recognisable. When you return to an old table, to a family, to a group you share years with, there is a version of you those people know and are fond of, and that version has rights. It has the right to go on existing, because it was with her that everything binding you together was built. Except you, meanwhile, have changed inside, without warning and without fault, in the

silent way people change. So, every time you sit at the table, you do work no one sees and that you yourself barely notice: you hold the old version upright, so that others can go on recognising you. You do not lie. It is tenderer and more tiring than lying.

It is loving people enough not to spoil the memory they have of you, and so presenting yourself still as someone you no longer quite are, only so that the table can go on being a table. That is the most hidden cost of company for someone who is changing. It is also the most innocent reason to flee it. Because alone, and only alone, you do not have to hold any version. Alone you can be exactly what you are becoming, owing no one the continuity of being what you were. The relief of not having to hold yourself is so great, and so deserved, that you confuse it with coming home. Maybe it is coming home. Or maybe it is only the door closing slowly over a room where no one asks anything of you any more because no one is there any more.

. . .

Now, isolation is, first of all, a very intelligent flight from this cost. Here is the part I ask you not to skip: the flight works. That is what makes it so dangerous. When you shut yourself away, the cost vanishes at once. You no longer translate, no longer calculate, no longer sustain, no longer perform. The relief of that liberation is genuine, it is physical, you feel your shoulders drop. The problem is



not that the flight does not work. The problem is what it charges in the long run, in silence, without warning you.

Because there is a law no one explained to you that governs all of this. The capacity to be with people is a muscle. Every muscle that stops being used does not stay the same, waiting for you. It atrophies. What cost you ten yesterday will, tomorrow, if you withdraw, cost you twelve. Not because people have got worse. Because you, without training, lost your stamina. At twelve you withdraw even more, and because you withdraw more, tomorrow it costs fifteen. You see the spiral. The more you isolate yourself to flee the cost of company, the higher that cost becomes, and the higher it becomes, the more you isolate yourself. Defensive isolation does not lower your need to be hidden. It raises it. Each night refused does not make you need fewer people. It makes you need more solitude to bear people. That increase in the need to hide yourself, you call, without meaning to deceive yourself, the discovery of who you are.

There is a cruel detail in this atrophy, which is that it feels like gain. When the muscle loses strength, you do not feel the loss as loss. You feel the world as louder. People do not seem more difficult to you because you are weaker; they seem to you, from the inside, genuinely more difficult, more demanding, more tiring than they were. Because the experience is honest, you believe it. You conclude that people have got worse, or that you finally see them clearly, when the truth is only that you lost the callus.

It is like someone who stops walking for months and then thinks the streets have got steeper. The streets are the same. The legs changed. No one looks at their own legs asking whether it was them; it is much easier to look at the street. That is why this sign lies with such confidence. It does not tell you you are becoming more fragile for the world. It tells you the world does not deserve you, and it says so in the first person of your own experience, in the most convincing voice there is, which is yours.

Notice how it is exactly the opposite in the withdrawal that is meeting. That one does not atrophy the muscle. That one repairs it. You take a day for yourself not to flee the cost of company, but to have somewhere again to pay that cost from without going into debt. You come back with reserves. Because you come back with reserves, the cost of the next company, instead of rising, falls, because you arrive at it whole and not borrowing from yourself. You have the same signature again, in reverse: the withdrawal that is meeting lowers the cost of the world, the isolation that is flight raises it. One trains the muscle to rest. The other lets it forget that it exists.

How do you tell, in the moment, which of the two you are living, if both give you the same relief in the first half hour? You do not tell in the moment. That is the difficult and freeing news at once. There is no way of knowing, while you are inside the silence, whether this silence is the one that fills or the one that empties. They taste the

same in the mouth. There is only one way to know, and it is the only thing this chapter is going to ask you to learn. To look at the after.

There is a night I remember, and it is not mine, it belongs to many people I know, and maybe it is yours too. A woman had refused, for months, everything. Every dinner, every birthday, every coffee, every anything. She had done it with a narrative she was proud of, the narrative of someone who has finally learned to respect her own energy, not to spend herself on those who do not deserve it, to choose her peace. They are beautiful sentences. They are true sentences in many mouths.

At one point, someone she loved very much said to her, without malice, almost in jest, that she was becoming a person hard to reach. She replied, with the serenity of someone who is right: I would rather be well alone than badly accompanied. She was proud of the answer. The other person, who knew her, did not argue. She only said one thing, and said it with such tenderness that it hurt more. I know. I will only ask you one thing. When you come home from these nights you did not go out, do you have more desire to live, or less?

She could not answer at once. Not because the question was hard to understand. Because it was hard to bear.

Because the truth is she knew the answer. She knew it in the body, before knowing it in the head. The nights she withdrew no longer returned her to anything. She woke the next day not larger, smaller.

Not with the world sharper, with the world more distant, behind a glass that was getting, month by month, thicker. The phone face down on the table was no longer a rest from one night, it was the phone's natural position. What she had called peace, throughout all those months, and which was a word she liked because it left her at peace with herself, began, that night, before that question, to show her its other face. It was not peace. It was absence. She had begun to confuse peace with the absence of people. The disguise was perfect, because the absence of people did bring, in fact, a kind of peace, the peace of having no cost. Except it was the peace of a muscle that has forgotten it hurts, because it stopped moving.

It is here, at this exact point, that I need to protect you from a false diagnosis, because the false diagnosis of this sign is the most seductive of all. The false diagnosis dresses itself as wisdom. It goes like this: I discovered that I am happier alone. It goes like this: people tire me, they always did, only now do I have the courage to admit it. It goes like this: I learned not to need anyone, and that is maturity.

Listen carefully, because I am not going to tell you that these sentences are a lie. Some of them may be absolutely true. There are people for whom solitude really is their element, there are temperaments that flourish in silence and wither in the crowd, and of those, for years, life in society asked that they pretend to be something else. If you are one of those, I am the last to want to push you back into the noise. The question is not whether the sentence is

true. The question is whether the sentence is describing a discovery or covering up a surrender.

Because I discovered that I am happier alone has two origins, and they are opposite, and they are said in the same words. One origin is the meeting: I discovered who I am when I stop translating myself, and that discovery gives me so much that I return to the world with more to offer. The other origin is the wound: I hurt myself so many times trying to belong, I was so many times the person who did not fit, I translated myself so many times in order not to be too much or too little, that my system, to protect me, learned to switch off the hunger for the world.

When the hunger switches off, it really does feel like freedom. But it is not freedom. It is anaesthesia. It is the body doing what the body does with what hurts too much: it stops feeling it, so that it will not cost. By no longer feeling the hunger for people, the person swears she has cured it. She has not cured it. She has put it to sleep. She calls it wisdom because the word surrender is unbearable, and no one wants to look surrender in the face, above all when it disguises itself so well as choice.

There is a third sentence, the most discreet, which may be the one you use most. I am better this way. It says nothing grandiose. It claims neither happiness nor wisdom, only a better, comparative, prudent, almost humble. It is by being so modest that it escapes any suspicion. But ask yourself better than what. Because there is a

better that belongs to someone who got out of tight clothes and finally breathes, and that better is true and it grows.

There is a better that belongs to someone who lowered the expectations of her own life so far that any flat day already seems a good day, and that better is the better of someone who settled, the better said with a half smile and the eyes a little lowered. Both say I am better this way. But one says that life opened, and the other says that life shrank until it fit inside what you can still bear, and that shrinking, because it no longer hurts as much as it did, you call improvement. See which of them you are speaking of. Not by the sentence. By the size of the life around the sentence.

People tire me. Maybe so. But ask yourself which tiredness. There is the tiredness of someone who spends herself performing a version of herself that is not hers, and that tiredness is just, and the answer to that tiredness is not to flee people, it is to stop performing yourself before them. There is the tiredness of someone who switched off the capacity to be with others and so any presence, even the lightest, weighs on her, because the muscle atrophied and can no longer bear even the light. These two tirednesses say the same sentence. People tire me. But one is the tiredness of carrying a mask, and the other is the tiredness of someone who lost the strength even for what demands no mask at all. Only you, in the honesty of your after, can know which of them is yours.

Here comes the layer that usually stays invisible, because you always tell it to yourself as if it were only about you, only about your temperament, only about your having discovered that you like being alone after all. But you were not born withdrawing. You learned it, little by little. It is worth asking where you learned it, because the answer is usually far behind any Friday.

In almost every story, there is a moment when being with others stopped being safe and started being costly. There was a time, once, or many times, when you showed what you felt and the response was small, or absent, or wrong. When you were fully present and came home with the sense that it had cost you and had not given to you. When you belonged to a table, to a house, to a group, to a family, and did everything right, and even so there was a fine tightening, the tightening of someone who loves people and stopped being the same person beside them. Your system, which is wise in its defensive way, drew a very reasonable conclusion: if being with others is costly and gives little, the most economical thing is to be with fewer others. With time, the most economical of all: to be with none.

Notice that this is not a flaw of yours. It is a learning, and it was an intelligent learning in the context in which it happened. There was a time when withdrawing really was the right thing, when the table asked of you a version of yourself you could no longer give, and pulling away was an act of faithfulness to yourself, not a weakness.

The problem, and this is the heart of the hidden layer, is that the strategy that saved you in one context went on running after the context had passed. The muscle you were taught to spare stays spared even where there is no longer any danger to spare it from. You go on withdrawing from tables that no longer ask of you what that table asked. You go on fleeing a cost those people no longer charge you. The defence outlived the threat. Because no one warned you that the defence had to be switched off when the threat was over, it stays on, and you confuse that staying on with your way of being.

. . .

There is one more thing you inherit and that has almost no name. In many houses, withdrawing was the honourable way of suffering. There was someone, before you, who learned that one does not trouble anyone with what one feels, that one tends to one's own pain alone, that the dignified thing is not to weigh. That person, whom you may have loved very much, taught you, without a single lesson, that solitude is the proper place of the soul when it suffers. You did not choose that. You received it the way one receives the colour of one's eyes.

When today you withdraw and feel a strange nobility in it, an almost peace of someone doing the right and dignified thing,



perhaps it is not only you feeling. Perhaps you are carrying out an old instruction, from someone who isolated themselves in order not to weigh, and who passed that isolation to you as an inheritance, dressed as virtue. Recognising this obliges you to nothing. It only takes the isolation out of your hands as though it were your personal discovery, your hard won wisdom, and returns it to what it in part is: a way of being in the world that was taught to you before you were old enough to refuse it.

There was a conversation, once, that may tell you this better than I can. A woman was telling a friend, with no drama at all, almost as one comments on the weather, that she had stopped going to the Sunday lunches at the house where she grew up. The friend, who knew her, did not ask what had happened, because she knew nothing had happened. She only asked, and asked low: and do you like it there? The woman was silent a while, and then said something that stayed floating in the kitchen. I like them. I no longer know if I like myself there. There was no grievance in the voice. There was mourning. The exact mourning of someone who loves people and stopped being the same person beside them, and discovers, with a tender surprise, that those two things, which seemed one, can after all be separated.

You can love completely those who sit at that table and, at the same time, no longer find yourself sitting there. It is not a contradiction. It is only the way life changes us faster than it changes the places

where we were happy. What the woman was doing, by no longer going, was not a mistake nor a correction. It was mourning. She was saying goodbye to a version of herself without having to say goodbye to a single person. She was doing for the old house what one does for everything that was good and stopped being ours, without having changed: letting it go on being good, there, for those who still fit inside it.

Pay attention to the danger hidden in that mourning, because it is what this chapter is about. The mourning of a good place is legitimate and necessary, and you have every right to withdraw from it in order to grieve it. But there is a point, fine as a thread, where the withdrawal that was mourning begins to become habit, and the habit begins to become your only house. You grieve the Sunday lunch, and you do well. But if, from refused lunch to refused lunch, you go on ceasing to want any new table, any encounter, any other kitchen where you might still fit, then the mourning stopped being mourning. It became surrender. Healthy mourning closes a door and, with time, opens your attention to others. Surrender closes a door and tells you all doors are the same and not worth it. Again the same signature: one expands, the other shrinks. Only the question of the after, again, will tell you which of them you are in.

I underline it again, because it is easy to read this and fall into fear: none of this makes your solitude a mistake. The inheritance may be there and your need for silence be, at the same time, true and yours.

Both things fit. I am not trying to disqualify your withdrawal. I am trying to give you the eyes to see it from inside, because only from inside can you tell the silence that fills from the silence that empties, and you deserve to know which of them you have been living in.

Let me stop a moment on what this is not, because without this paragraph the rest may be misread, and I do not want to leave you badly accompanied by me. This is not an invitation to force yourself. I am not telling you to accept every invitation, to fill yourself with people, to fight your withdrawal with a full diary. That would be trading one vice for another, the flight from the world for the flight from yourself.

There are those who isolate themselves out of defence and there are those who drown themselves in people for exactly the same reason, in order not to be with themselves, and that too is a flight, only noisier. Health is not in either extreme. It is not in being always with people, nor in being always without them. It is in being able to do both. It is in being able to withdraw without that shutting you, and being able to go into the world without that scattering you. Freedom is not always choosing solitude. It is having both doors open, and being able to cross either of them without the other closing forever behind you.

That is why the gesture I am going to ask of you is so small. Because it does not take the silence from you. It does not push you out of the house. It does not force you into a single Friday you do not want. It

happens entirely inside your own withdrawal, without your having to interrupt it. It is only a question, and it is the question this whole chapter is made of.

After this silence, did I have more desire to live, or less?

That is all. You do not have to change your Friday. You have to learn to listen to your Sunday morning. Withdraw. Withdraw as much as you need. But, the next day, before anything else, ask the question of the after. After this night alone, did the world become larger or smaller. Did people, at a distance, seem people to me again, or seem to me even more of an effort. Do I feel like, even from afar, even without doing it today, returning to something, or do I feel only like not having to. Do I have more hunger, or less. Did I inhale, and now feel like exhaling, or did I inhale and want only to go on inhaling until there is no air left.

There is a way of asking this question without it becoming one more way of policing yourself, because the last thing you need is one more tribunal in the house. Do not ask it interrogating yourself. Ask it listening to yourself. The difference is everything. To interrogate is to demand a right answer from yourself, and the fear of being wrong ends up always giving you the answer that reassures you, and the answer that reassures does not serve, because what you want is not to reassure yourself, it is to know. To listen is something else. To listen is to ask no answer at all of yourself in the morning, it is only to notice, without words, what your first inclination of the day is.

On waking, before you think, your body leans toward the world or moves away from it. The phone that might ring gives you a good shiver or a bad one. The idea of crossing someone in the street warms you a little or weighs on you. It is not an answer that is spoken. It is an inclination that is felt. The body, in these things, lies far less than the head, because the head has an interest in being right and the body has no interest at all, it only knows whether it is hungry or no longer is.

Notice the verb of this gesture. I do not ask you to leave. I ask you to notice. To notice is cousin to remaining. It does not take you from the place where you are. It asks you only to be attentive from inside it. You stay in your silence, and at the same time you begin to listen to it. That listening costs no company at all. You can do it entirely alone, in your warm house, with the phone face down. You only come to have, alongside the silence, a small witness, which is you, asking with tenderness: this silence, is it filling you or emptying you. The answer you do not have to force. It comes, with time, if you leave the question awake.

Because what tells the two peaces apart was never what you feel while you are inside them. It is the trail they leave when you come out. The peace that is meeting leaves a trail of good hunger, of a sharper world, of a warm desire to return. The peace that is absence leaves a trail of thicker glass, of phone calls you do not make, of Sundays with that colour. You, who know how to feel, can learn to

feel the trail too. I ask you nothing more. I do not ask you to fight your solitude. I ask you not to confuse the silence that returns you with the silence that carries you away, only because both give you, in the first half hour, the same rest.

Do not be in a hurry with the answer, nor be frightened if it does not come at once, nor be frightened even more if it comes and is hard. There are those who ask this question once and flee it for years, because they sensed it and did not want to hear it, and that too is human, and I do not judge you for it either. The question does not oblige you to act on the answer. It only obliges you to stop pretending you do not have it. That is already a lot, in a place as slippery as this, to stop pretending.

Because as long as you do not ask the question, the silence that empties you and the silence that fills you are indistinguishable, and you live without knowing which of them you inhabit, and that is not the peace you deserve, it is only the peace of someone who did not look. Real peace can bear being looked at. Real peace is not afraid of the question of the after. The other, the one that disguises itself, flees the question like someone fleeing a mirror, and it is by that, very often, that you recognise it before anything else: by the way it bothers you that I am even suggesting you ask it.

Ask the question once, and then ask it again. Keep noticing, over the weeks, not one isolated night, but the direction. Because one night lies. One night of withdrawal can empty you and you wake content,

and it can fill you and you wake sad, and from one single night you will not be able to tell anything apart. It is the direction that does not lie. It is the drawing your afters make over a month. If you notice, and are honest, and the direction is of hunger growing, of the world drawing near, of desire returning, then your silence is one of those that fill, and you can withdraw in peace, in real peace, in the peace that expands. If the direction is of hunger fading, of the world retreating, of desire dwindling, then do not judge yourself, but do not lie to yourself: this silence is emptying you with a velvet hand, and what you called the discovery of who you are may be, underneath, a hunger you put to sleep so as not to feel it hurt.

Even there, even if you discover you are in the silence that empties, I am not going to order you to do anything big. This page promises you no arrival. It does not tell you to fill the house with people tomorrow, to recover the muscle all at once, to force a Friday of a thousand people. That would be another violence, the violence of someone taking your refuge from you without asking whether you still need it. The refuge is legitimate as long as it is refuge. It only stops being so when it becomes flight, and the only way for you to know which it is is not to stop withdrawing. It is to notice the after. The gesture stays entirely inside the sign. I do not ask you to fit anywhere. I do not even ask you to belong yet. I ask you only for the question, repeated, patient, the question that forces you to nothing and that, only by being awake, begins slowly to strip the disguise from the silence that shrinks you.

Because solitude is yours, and it is legitimate, and it will go on being so. But your appetite for the world is also yours, and that one, unlike solitude, makes no noise when it begins to die. It goes out in silence, with the same delicacy with which the house grows warm and the light grows low, and so you can lose it without noticing, and call that loss peace. The question of the after is the candle you leave burning beside that hunger, so that you can watch it breathe. As long as the candle is lit, you do not lose it without knowing. That is all, for now. Not leaving the house tonight, if you do not feel like it. But tomorrow morning, before anything, in your whole silence, without having to smile at anyone, asking yourself with the greatest tenderness whether this silence is returning you to the world, or slowly saying goodbye to it.

To stay with the question. Not with the hurried answer. With the question. Awake, beside you, in the warm house, in the low light, faithful.



SIGN 7

You realise the problem  
was never belonging, but  
the price of belonging

*Maybe I was just paying too dearly for  
belonging.*



There is a bill no one ever showed you. It does not come on paper, it has no number, there is no moment when someone sits down across from you and says, here it is, this is what you owe. And yet it is paid. It has been paid for so long that you stopped feeling it as a bill. It became the air. It became the way you breathe when you walk into a room where there are people you love and where, for some reason you never knew how to name, you become a little smaller at the door. Not much. Enough to fit through. Enough that your presence disturbs nothing.

I am going to ask something difficult of you now, at the start. Set down, for a moment, the idea that this is a book about boundaries. It is not. Set down too the idea that you came here to learn to say no, to defend your space, to assert your needs. Those books exist and some are good. But if you reached this seventh sign, it is because you have already understood, somewhere in the body, that your problem was never not knowing how to set boundaries. Your problem was another, older and tenderer, and harder to see precisely because it came disguised as virtue. Your problem was that you learned to pay for belonging with pieces of yourself, and you did it so well, for so long, that no one noticed. Not even you.

Notice now. Slowly.

You remember the tables. Across these six signs, you crossed them all. The family table where you laughed at the same jokes half a second late, because the laughter no longer came out of you on its

own and you had to go and fetch it. The table of old friends where you told the version of yourself they knew, the one that fit inside the story they had about who you were, and you kept the other, the new one, the one that did not yet have a place at the table, for later, for the drive home alone, for the silence of the car. The work table where you nodded your head while inside something told you, it is not like that, it is not quite like that, but the head went on nodding because nodding was cheaper than what not nodding would cost.

At all of them you did the same thing, without ever giving it a name. You shrank a little. You lowered the volume of something in you that, if it came out whole, would take up too much space. You smiled over a sentence that hurt you slightly, so as not to spoil the afternoon. You swallowed the small truth to protect the large peace. You left each of those tables with a feeling you confused so many times with tiredness, and that was not tiredness. It was the bill. It was the low sound of the bill being charged.

I want you to understand, before anything else, that there is nothing wrong with you for having paid. You paid because you wanted to be there. You really did. The desire to belong is not a weakness of yours that needs curing. It is the most human thing there is. Belonging is how we survived while we were small and defenceless and how we go on having meaning after we are grown. No one becomes whole alone on an island. No one. Belonging is healthy. It is beautiful. It is the place where life takes on colour. The problem was never your

wanting the table. The problem was the price you learned to accept as normal for a place at that table. The cruellest thing about that price is that it was never charged to you all at once. It was charged in instalments, over years, in amounts so small each time that they seemed the natural cost of loving someone.

A little here. A little there. The opinion you did not voice. The dream you spoke of laughing, as if you did not take it seriously, so that no one would take it seriously first and spare you the shame. The part of you that stayed home because it did not go with that group. The version of you that you knew would disappoint, and that you therefore kept, and that with time you kept so well you almost lost sight of it.

This is what you have been paying. Today, in this sign, I do not come to tell you that you paid to those who did not deserve it, nor that you were robbed, nor that you were deceived. I do not come to give you a villain. There is no villain. The people at those tables took nothing from you. Most of them do not even know you paid. Some would have been horrified if they had known. It was you who, out of love and out of fear, and the two usually come hand in hand, decided that was the value of a place among those you loved. You paid it with your dearest currency, which was not your time, nor your energy, nor your work. It was you. It was you whole, pretending to be a little less in order to fit.

There is a sentence you may already have said to someone, or heard someone say to you, and that seems like good sense and is, in truth, the exact name of the wound. It is this: you have to give a little, that is how it works. It is true. Every relationship has giving. Every belonging asks you to give something up, to make room, to be not only yourself and your will. This is just and it is good. But there was a moment, somewhere, when you stopped giving things up and began to give up yourself. No one warned you the border had been crossed, because the border has no sign. You gave up the dinner hour and that is fine. You gave up the film you wanted to watch and that is fine. Then, without warning, you gave up your opinion, your strangeness, your way of feeling things, and that was no longer fine, but by then you had given up so much that you also gave up the capacity to notice you were giving up what should not be given up.

That is what hurts. It is not the giving. It is the giving without ground, the giving that does not know where to stop because it lost sight of what it was protecting.

Let me land this in a scene, because signs do not live in beautiful sentences, they live in concrete afternoons.

Imagine a Sunday lunch. The house is the one it always was. The smell is the one it always was, that smell that returns you to eight years old in a second. The right people are there, the ones you love, the ones you cried out for when you were small and afraid of the dark. There is a conversation, the kind that runs in every family,

about someone, about someone's choice, and you have an opinion. You have a whole and clear opinion of your own, formed by everything you have lived and read and learned, and it contradicts the opinion that fills the table.

You feel the opinion rise, you feel it reach your throat. You stop. Not out of cowardice. Do not call yourself a coward, that is unjust. You stop because, in a calculation you make faster than you could explain, you realise that telling your truth there would cost the afternoon, would cost the lightness, would cost the warm comfort of that table that was your home, and that this cost is greater, in that instant, than the cost of staying silent. So you stay silent. You smile. You change the subject with grace, because you got good at it, you became expert at changing the subject before the subject costs you too much.

The lunch goes on, sweet, and you take part in it, and you laugh, and you clear the table, and you say goodbye with real kisses, because the love is real, this is the most important thing of all, the love is completely real. Then you get into the car. There, in the car, alone, with the engine still off and your hands on the wheel without gripping it, you feel something that has no good word. It is not anger, because there is no one to be angry at. It is not sadness, because it was a good day. It is more like the feeling of having left a shop and, already on the street, realising you paid too much for

something, and that it is too late to go back, and that anyway you would not know what to say at the counter.

You paid too much. Again. It was not even expensive, you would say, it was only an opinion you did not voice, a sentence of nothing. But it was not the sentence. It was what the sentence meant. It was one more instalment on the long loan you took out, so long ago, against your own right to be whole beside those you love.

If you stay still there in the car a moment longer, without starting the engine, perhaps you will remember the first time. Not today's lunch. The very first of all, the one that taught the body to do this. For many women it is from childhood, and it is so small it seems nothing. Once you came home overflowing with something, a joy, an idea, one of those enormous truths children bring whole before they learn to break them into presentable pieces, and you showed it to someone you loved, and that person was tired, or busy, or sad, and answered sideways, or did not answer, or answered with a weight in the voice that you could not read but that your body read to perfection. You learned, in that second, without words, a lesson you would carry to every table of your life.

You learned that your full version could weigh on those you loved. That there was a size of you that cost others. You decided, with the fierce and loving intelligence of a child who wants to go on being loved, that from then on you would bring a lighter version, a smaller one, easier to receive. It was not a conscious decision. It was a

decision of the body, the kind that is made once and kept for thirty years. The person who answered you sideways that day probably does not even remember, and loved you immensely, and never knew that in that banal instant they taught you the price. There is no villain even on that first day. There is only a child learning to pay, and love passing badly translated, and a body that decided to protect the bond at the cost of size.

You paid too much. Again. As on that day. As on every day between that one and this.

There are those who will tell you, and perhaps have already told you, that what you need is to assert yourself more. To be firmer. Not to let yourself be erased. There is truth in that, but it is a truth that heals by halves, and the missing half is precisely the one that matters. Because if you take that advice as it usually comes, you will turn your house into a battlefield. You will go to each table determined to tell your truth whatever it costs, to mark your position, not to give in. You will manage it, for a while, and you will feel powerful, and you will feel free, and then you will feel alone. Because firmness without tenderness does not give you back belonging. It gives you back your territory, yes, but empty. You did not want an empty territory. You wanted the table full and yourself whole at it. Both things. You always wanted both things. It was precisely because they made you believe you could not have both that you spent your life choosing one and grieving the other in secret.



Here is the deception, the false diagnosis in which so many women like you get lost, and lose years. The deception tells you there is a choice to be made. It tells you, either you or them. Either you stay faithful to yourself and lose the table, or you stay at the table and lose yourself. This choice haunted all the previous signs. It lay beneath each of them, like a cold current beneath warm water. In the first sign, when you realised you were present without being home, the choice whispered to you, either accept that you do not belong, or pretend that you do. In the sign where you felt your voice coming out smaller than it was inside you, the choice whispered, either speak loud and lose them, or speak low and lose yourself. In all of them, always, the same double-edged blade, always the same sentence, choose, you have to choose, you cannot have both.

It is a lie. It is one of the oldest and best disguised lies there is, because it comes dressed as realism, it comes with the air of adult wisdom, it comes saying, life is made of choices, grow up, accept that you cannot have everything. You, who are serious and honest and do not like to deceive yourself, accepted it, because it seemed mature. But it was not mature. It was only the form your pain found to protect you from a hope that seemed too dangerous to hold. The hope that maybe, maybe, it was possible to be with them and be with yourself at the same time. Maybe the "either" was never true. Maybe it was always an "and" disguised as an "either".

Look closely at the choice they sold you, because it has a hole in the middle, and once you see the hole you will not be able to go back to not seeing it.

. . .

The choice says, either you or them. But notice, that is only a true choice if it is true that your whole presence does not fit there. Often it is not true. Often your whole presence did fit, always fit, and it was you who, in anticipation, decided it did not fit, and shrank before even testing. You shrank pre-emptively. You paid the bill before they charged it, afraid of being charged. You never came to know whether they would have charged it. Maybe most of the people you love would have stayed, would stay, with your truth told in love. Maybe some would even have been relieved, because they too were paying in their own way, and your truth would give them licence for theirs. You never knew. Because the choice they sold you did not let you find out. It closed the case before opening it.

I want to be careful here, because it is easy, at this point, to slip into a promise that is not true. The easy promise would be to tell you, see, after all you can have everything, you just have to tell your truth and everyone will love you the same. No. That would be lying to you, and I promise not to lie to you in this book. The truth is more sober

and more beautiful than that. The truth is that some people, yes, will need you to stay small in order to stay comfortable.

Some tables only really worked with your reduced version, and your whole version will change the temperature of the room, and some of those tables will grow more distant. This is real and you will have to feel it. But, and this is the whole point of this sign, that is not the majority. That is not the rule. You generalised from the few tables that really did demand you small and applied the rule to all, and spent your life paying at tables that had never charged you anything, out of fear of a bill that only a few would really bring.

You paid in advance, almost everywhere, a bill that was only real in a few places.

This is the fine mechanics of the thing. This is the part that takes time to see because it is silent and because it looks like love. What you called, for years, being a good person, being easy, being calm, being good company, was in large part this. It was an automatic payment system you switched on so early in life that you do not even remember switching it on. You walk into a room, and before anything happens, before anyone asks you for whatever it may be, the system has already run, has already calculated what in you might bother, has already turned it down, has already handed you at the door a version of yourself tuned not to clash. You do this in seconds. You do this without deciding. It is so much yours it seems like personality, and it is not personality, it is an old survival strategy

you learned in a time when belonging really was a matter of life or death, because you were small and depended entirely on those who fed you and kept you warm.

Here we come to the layer beneath all the others, the deepest, the one that explains why this is so hard to let go.

You did not invent the price. You inherited it.

There was, before you, someone who also paid. Probably your mother. Probably hers. There was a woman, in your line, who learned that her place at the table of the world depended on not taking up too much space, on not wanting too much, on not being too much. She learned it in a time when that was literally true, when a woman who was too whole could really lose her bread, her roof, her protection. She paid. She shrank to fit and taught, without ever saying a word about it, her daughters to shrink too, because the love of a mother who paid dearly is to want to spare her daughter the pain, and she knew no other way to spare her daughter than to teach her to pay in time, before life charged her worse. She passed you the currency in the conviction that she was giving you a tool. It was, then, a tool. What she could not know is that the world, for you, would change enough that her tool would become, in you, a prison.

So when today you sit at a table and shrink without meaning to, it is not only you shrinking. It is a long line of women shrinking through you, each one paying for the next, each one believing she was

protecting the one who came after. There is no villain in this line. There is only love passing from hand to hand in the form of fear, because fear knew no other way to dress itself as love. You are not broken. You are faithful. You are being faithful to a pact no one signed and everyone kept. One of the tenderest and most freeing things you can do today is to look at that pact and understand that it was necessary, and that it was love, and that it is no longer yours to keep.

Think of a woman from that line, just one, to see her clearly. Maybe your grandmother, maybe one you never even knew and of whom only a hard photograph and a name remain. There was a time in her life when she really did have to pay. Not out of imagined fear, out of real danger. Her place at the table of the world depended literally on not saying too much, on not wanting too much, on not being too much, because a woman who was too much, in her time, could lose things you today cannot even imagine losing, could lose her bread, her name, her children, the protection that kept her alive. She learned to shrink because shrinking was surviving.

She was good at it, she was so good at it that she survived, and because she survived you are here. Give her back, for a moment, the dignity of what she did. She was not weak. She had a courage you can barely measure, the courage of someone who diminishes herself every day to keep her own alive. Her shrinking was heroism. When she passed the currency to her daughter, and the daughter to your

mother, and your mother to you, each one passed it in the exact conviction that she was giving an instrument of survival, the best tool she knew, the only one that had saved her. How does one judge that? One does not judge it. One bows the head.

What none of them could have guessed is that the world, before you, would change enough that the tool would stop saving and start imprisoning. You will no longer lose your bread for having an opinion at the Sunday table. You will no longer lose your children for disagreeing. The real danger that made the currency make sense dissolved somewhere between your grandmother and you, without noise, without warning, without anyone coming to say, you can stop paying now, the bill was forgiven. That is why you go on paying. Not because you are foolish. Because no one told you. Because the order to pay was shouted for generations and the order to stop was never given, and you, faithful, go on carrying out the last instruction you received, which was to protect yourself by shrinking, without knowing that what it protected you from no longer exists. You are paying off a debt whose creditor died long ago and that no one told you was settled.

There is an almost unbearable tenderness in this, when one sees it. You are defending yourself against a danger that has passed, with a weapon from another war, out of loyalty to women who loved you so much they gave you the only defence they had. The only thing you need to do with that loyalty is not betray it. It is to honour it in a

new way. It is to look back, at the whole line, and tell them in silence, thank you, I know what this cost you, and because of what you paid I can now pay less, and paying less is your gift taking shape in me, not your betrayal. The inheritance they left you was not the shrinking. The shrinking was only the packaging. The inheritance was survival. The highest way to honour those who survived so that you could exist is, now that you can, to dare to live whole.

You see what this changes. You were not failing when you paid. You were honouring. You were honouring an inheritance of women who survived by paying, and your loyalty to them took the form of going on paying a bill that, in your time, was already forgiven and you did not know.

Go back now, with this in your hands, to all the tables. Go back with new eyes.

That family table where you stayed silent on Sunday. You did not stay silent because you were weak. You stayed silent because a very old woman inside you said in your ear, do not disturb, stay good, stay easy, that is how one stays. You obeyed her out of loyalty, without knowing you were obeying her. That table of friends where you kept your new version. You did not keep it out of shame, deep down. You kept it because you learned that the new part of a woman is the most expensive part to show, the one that most risks the place, and you protected it the way one protects what is precious, by hiding it. You

paid to protect what was most your own, without realising that paying that way was exactly losing it.

It was all love, you see. It was all love badly informed about its time. There is no failing of yours here to forgive, because there was no failing. There was faithfulness. There was a good woman paying too dearly for something she deserved to have for free, and calling that being good.

It is exactly at this point, when this is seen whole like this, that the small thing happens that changes everything. It is not a lightning bolt. It is not a revolution. It is more discreet than that, and therefore truer. It is something that softens. You feel, perhaps as you read this, perhaps only later when it settles, a kind of loosening in a place in the chest that had been clenched for so long that you had stopped feeling it clenched. Like a shoulder that had been raised for years and that, suddenly, without your commanding it, drops. That softening is not the relief of someone who has arrived. It is the softening of someone who has understood something and has not yet lived it, but already knows she will be able to live it. It is the difference between standing at a closed door and standing at an open one. You have not crossed yet. But the door is no longer locked, and you know it is no longer locked, and that, by itself, changes the whole body.

What softens is the war. The silent war you waged inside yourself, between the one who wanted to be with them and the one who



wanted to be with herself, that war that left you exhausted without anyone understanding of what. When you see that you never had to choose between the two, the war loses its reason to be. Both lower their weapons. They look at each other and realise they were always on the same side, that they always wanted the same thing, that only a spoiled language had set them fighting. There is a good silence after that war. A silence that is not empty. It is rest.

It is in that silence that the question changes.

For six signs, and probably for far longer than six signs, for almost your whole life, you asked a question. You asked it in a thousand ways, but it was always the same question, and the question was, where can I belong. Where do I fit. Where is there room for me. You looked for that place at the tables where you grew up and at the tables you chose, in the groups, in the loves, in the jobs, in every room you walked into asking in silence, is there room for me here, can I stay. That question, however sweet it seems, carries a poison within it, and the poison is this, it presumes the place belongs to others and that you have to ask for it. It always puts you in the position of someone arriving at the door of another's house to ask to come in, and whoever asks to come in pays the entrance, always, with whatever currency they have. That is why you paid. Because the question you asked already carried the bill inside it.

Now, at this threshold where the war has softened, you hear a different question forming. You did not look for it. It came on its

own, from the same place the softening came from. The new question is this, and I want you to read it slowly, because it will stay with you long after you close this book.

. . .

Where can I remain whole while I belong.

Feel the difference. It is not where do I fit. It is where do I remain whole. It is not whether there is room for me. It is whether there is room for me without my having to leave parts of myself at the door. The old question looked for a place. The new question looks for a condition. That condition is the only thing that makes belonging worth the name. Because a belonging that costs you pieces of yourself is not belonging, it is lodging. You are housed, you do not belong. To belong, really to belong, is to be able to remain whole while you are there. It is presence with no piece missing.

Notice what this new question does not ask of you. What it does not ask is as important as what it asks. It does not ask that everyone agree with you. To belong whole is not to be at a table where everyone thinks as you do, that does not exist and would be tedious if it did. You will go on sitting at tables where they say things you deeply disagree with, and you will be able to disagree, aloud and with love, and go on belonging, because agreement was never the real

currency of belonging, it was only the false currency you learned to use.

It does not ask performance of you. It does not ask that you be the fun one, the easy one, the one who never weighs, the one who brightens the room. You can arrive tired, you can arrive sad, you can arrive silent, and remain whole in your silent sadness, and belong like that. It does not ask reduction of you. This is the greatest of all, because reduction was your payment all along, the main currency, and the new question is the first thing in your whole life that looks at that currency and tells you, this was never needed, you can keep it.

Let me give you a scene for this new question, because it too needs a concrete afternoon to land in, and not to stay only shining in the abstract.

Go back to that Sunday table. The same one. The same smell, the same people, the same conversation running about someone's choice. Your opinion rises again, reaches your throat again. Except this time you are not asking the old question, you are not asking in silence is there room for me here if I say this. You are asking the other one. You are asking can I remain whole at this table while I say what I feel. The answer, you realise with a warm astonishment, is not a single one. It depends on the table, depends on the day, depends on who is there. But what changed is not the answer. It is that now there is a question to ask, where before there was only an order to obey.

Before, the currency came out on its own, without question, automatic, and you stayed silent before you knew you had a choice. Now there is an interval, very thin, between the impulse to pay and the payment, and in that interval there fits a freedom that was never there. Maybe you still stay silent, this Sunday. That is fine. It is not the staying silent that changed. It is that this time you stay silent seeing, and not sleeping. Whoever stays silent seeing is no longer paying with eyes closed. She is looking at the currency in her hand and deciding, still afraid, but deciding, and one day, not today, maybe keeping it in her pocket and telling her truth with so much love that the table holds, and discovering, with her heart pounding, that the table had held all along.

What the new question asks is only one thing, and it is a thing you always had to give and were hiding because they told you it cost too much to show. It asks presence. Only that. It asks that you be there, whole, real, with your opinion and your strangeness and your crooked and beautiful way of feeling things, and that this presence, only this, be enough. Conscious belonging, the one that opens now before you, is not bought with your disappearance. It is bought with your appearance. It is the exact opposite of what you learned. It is not shrinking to fit. It is appearing to belong. The dizzying part, the one that makes the ground move a little beneath your feet, is to realise that maybe it was always like this, and that the price you paid your whole life was the price of a shop that after all charged

nothing, and you always arrived at the door already holding out the currency.

Do not hurry now to do anything with this. It is not time to act. It is time to know. There is a temptation, at this point, and it is the old temptation disguised as courage, the temptation to take this understanding and run to the next table to put it to the test, to assert yourself whole, to finally be you with no discount. Do not run. The new question is not a marching order. It is a door that opened. A door that opens does not need to be crossed in the same instant. It can stay open while you, on the inside, get used to the light coming through it. There is a work of looking that comes before the work of walking, and you are in the work of looking.

Let me tell you what changes, even now, even before you do anything at all, just by knowing this.

The reading of the past changes. That feeling in the car, after the lunch, the bill being charged quietly, will return. You will sit at tables and you will notice the old system running, your version tuning itself at the door, the currency coming out on its own. That does not end today. What ends today is the innocence. You will come to see the currency coming out. To see, only to see, is already the beginning of everything, because you cannot let go of what you do not see, and you, all your life, paid without seeing. Now you will see. There is an immense compassion born of seeing, because you will realise, at each table, I am not failing, I am paying an old bill, and I can,

perhaps, not today, but perhaps one day, stop paying it. That sentence in the car, that one, stops being nameless sadness and becomes information. It becomes your ally. The bill, when you feel it being charged, stops being your condemnation and becomes your sign, the seventh, telling you, notice, you are paying too much again, and this time you know.

It also changes the way you look at others at the table. While you believed the false choice, either you or them, the others were, without your wanting it, a kind of gentle adversaries, people you loved and from whom at the same time you had to defend yourself by shrinking. There was a fine tension, always, even in love. Now that the war has softened inside you, it softens too in the way you see them. They stop being those who charge you and go back to being only those you love. Most of them never wanted you small. Most of them never even noticed you paid.

Some will be surprised, and happy, when you begin, slowly, to appear more whole, because they missed you without knowing of what, they felt something was missing from the table and did not know that the thing missing was you whole. This is perhaps the greatest tenderness of all, to realise that your reduced version, which you thought you were offering as a gift, as care, as a way of not weighing, was in truth an absence they felt without naming. That by paying with your disappearance, you gave them less, not more. That

your whole presence, the one you were so afraid to show, was precisely what was missing from the table you love.

It changes, finally, what you think this whole path was. There were moments, across these seven signs, when you may have thought the problem was you, that there was in you a flaw at the root, an inability to fit, a strangeness that condemned you to always be half outside. I want, before I leave you at this threshold, to undo that with all the tender firmness I am capable of. There was no flaw. The not belonging you felt, table after table, sign after sign, was never proof that you were broken. It was the way your body, which is wiser than your head, warned you that you were paying too much. The not belonging was the bill hurting.

It was the symptom of an expensive bill, not of a wrong person. Each sign was, you see now, a way of paying too dearly. The first, present without being home, was the bill of your soul already outside the room while the body paid for the place. The one of your kept desires was the bill of hiding what was most your own so as not to risk the table. The one of your voice coming out smaller was the bill of bought agreement. All of them. Seven different ways of the same woman paying too dearly for a place that, at many of the tables, was hers for free and she did not know.

The opposite of your not belonging was never to fit better. It is not to become more flexible, more adaptable, more skilled at fitting. That would only be learning to pay the bill more elegantly, and you are

already too elegant at paying it, it was part of the problem. The opposite of your not belonging is to belong without diminishing yourself. It is the table full and you whole at it. It is to love the same people and stop being the same person beside them, and to discover that this does not take you from the table, that love holds your transformation, that one can love whole whom one loved shrunken, and that perhaps one loves even better.

Because this is what no one told you, and what I want to leave with you at the door, before you cross it, when you cross it, in your own time. You can stay. You can stay at almost all the tables you love. You will not have to choose between them and yourself, in most cases, because the choice was always false. What will change is not your presence or your absence at the table. What will change is the price. You will learn, slowly, to be there without paying. To sit down and not hold out the currency at the door. To let your opinion rise and come out with love and the afternoon not end, and to realise, with an astonishment that will make you want to laugh, that after all the afternoon held, that the table held, that it held far more than you asked of it, that you had spent years sparing a table that had never asked you to spare it.

At the few tables where the bill was real, where your whole version really does not fit, where they wanted you small to keep themselves comfortable, you will have to feel the mourning, and that mourning is real and deserves your respect, but even that mourning will be



cleaner, because you will know what you are grieving. You are not grieving for having failed. You are grieving a table that was good and stopped being yours without anyone at it having changed, without anyone having taken anything from you, only because you stopped being able to pay what it charged, and ceasing to be able to pay that is not a loss on your part, it is a liberation that hurts. But those tables are few. You generalised from them your whole life. The work that comes, on the other side of this door, is to undo that generalisation, table by table, discovering, with surprise each time, how few really did charge, and how many always wanted you whole and waited, in silence, for you to arrive.

You are at the door. I do not ask you to enter yet. You noticed something today, and noticing is the work of this sign, not crossing. You noticed that the problem was never belonging. The desire to belong, that one, was healthy, was human, was beautiful, and goes on being so, and will never stop being so, because you are a being that belongs, that becomes whole beside others, and there is no cure nor liberation that will change that, nor will there be, because that is not an illness, it is your humanity. The problem was always the price.

It was always the currency you learned to hold out at the door before anyone asked you for it. The thing that softened in you, a few pages ago, when you saw this whole, was the old tightening of someone who thought she had to choose between her people and herself. That tightening loosened. Not because you solved anything,

you have not solved anything yet, the work is all still to do. It loosened because you saw. Because the question you entered this sign with, where can I belong, gave way, on its own, without effort, to a question you will carry with you for the rest of the path.

Where can I remain whole while I belong.

Stay with it. Do not try to answer it today. Let it live in you like a light coming through an open door that you, on the inside, your eyes still getting used to it, watch without moving. There is time. There is no bill at this door. For the first time in a long time, you are at the entrance of a place where no one will charge you anything to stay. What remains for you to do, for now, is only this, and it is so much, it is to stand at the threshold, with the new question in your hand, and let what softened go on, without hurry, softening.



EPILOGUE

# The veil of the horizon



There is something they may not have told you when you began this book, and that I put off telling you until now, because you needed to walk the path first in order to receive it without its hurting you. It is this: there was no destination.

You came looking for a place. I know you did, because I came too, because everyone who opens a book with the word not belonging on the cover carries under their arm the same secret hope, that of there being, at the end, a door, and on the other side of the door a room where one finally fits. You imagined, perhaps without confessing it to yourself, that if you read attentively enough, if you recognised each of the signs, if you did all the work and skipped no difficult page, you would reach a place where you could set down your bag. A place where you stopped being the woman who is always slightly outside, slightly too much, slightly too little. You walked the whole book heading toward that place.

I let you walk, because the path was true even if the arrival did not exist. But now the hour has come to tell you what you see when you arrive. You arrive, and the place is not there. It receded. As the line of the horizon always recedes.

Have you ever noticed what the horizon does? You walk toward it all afternoon. You see the exact line where the earth meets the sky, sharp, there, you can point at it with your finger, it is at that distance and not another. You walk. You walk more. The sun moves, your legs tire, the landscape around you changes, and after hours you reach

the point where the line seemed to be. The line is not there. It is ahead again, at the same distance, equally sharp, equally impossible. You could walk your whole life and never touch it, and it is not because you are slow, not because you lack path, not because you do not yet deserve it. It is because the line of the horizon was never ahead of you. The line of the horizon is not a place in the world. It is the place where your gaze stops reaching, and your gaze walks with you. The line you were chasing was your own way of seeing, carried to its limit. It walked with you the whole time. It was yours.

I want you to breathe this in slowly, because everything this book promised you is decided here. Horizons are not places one arrives at. They are places from which one learns to walk. They serve to give you direction, not destination. They serve to tell you which way is forward, not to receive you at the end. Whoever confuses the horizon with a home spends their life feeling in default, because they are always arriving and have never arrived. Whoever understands that the horizon is a direction walks in peace, because the peace was not at the end of the road, it was in the way of walking it.

Apply this now to what you came here for. There is no home at the end of this book. There is no room where you finally fit and rest forever and close the matter. I know this may sound, on a first reading, as if I were taking something from you. As if I had brought you all this way to tell you, in the last chapter, that after all there

was no prize. But stay with me a little longer, because it is exactly the opposite.

Do you remember the thesis of this book, that sentence I asked you to carry like someone carrying a warm stone in their pocket, through every chapter? The opposite of not belonging is not to fit. It is to belong without needing to diminish yourself. Look closely at what that sentence does. It does not promise you a state. It does not tell you that you will end up fitted. It says something else, finer and freer, it says that you can belong without bending yourself. To belong without bending yourself is not a place one arrives at. It is a way of being. It is a verb. Verbs do not conclude, verbs are made, continually, in the present, as long as there is life to make them.

That is why the last veil of this book is the veil of the horizon. Because it is the veil that falls when you stop searching for the arrival. While you believed there was a destination called fitting, you lived with the front of your body turned toward a place that did not exist, and everything that was now seemed provisional to you, a waiting room, not yet. The veil of haste fell over each of your days. You lived like someone passing through their own life, waiting to reach the good part. The horizon called you and you ran, and the more you ran the more it receded, and what you read in that receding was your own failure. You thought, I have not arrived yet because I am not yet enough. When the truth was simpler and gentler: you have not arrived yet because there is nothing there to

arrive at. The horizon recedes from everyone, from the woman who thinks herself a hopeless case and from the woman everyone envies. It recedes the same. It is not your punishment. It is the nature of the line.

Now let me tell you what it is to remain, because this is the word I want to leave with you, and I want to leave it whole.

To remain is a verb in the present continuous. It has no form of arrival. There is no point at which one has remained once and for all and after which one no longer needs to remain again. It is not like climbing a staircase and staying on the upper floor. It is more like breathing. You breathe now, and that does not excuse you from breathing a moment from now. No one breathed enough. No one finished breathing and was done. You remain today, at today's table, and that is whole and it is enough, and tomorrow there will be another table, and you will remain again, anew, from the start, and that is not failure, that is being alive.

I know part of you wanted the other thing. You wanted the cure. You wanted to be able to say, on a day marked in the calendar, there, I am healed, I no longer fail to fit, I closed the cycle, the method is over, here is the diploma. The whole industry of human repair promised you that date. I cannot promise it to you, and I refuse to, because it would be lying to you with the pretty smile of someone selling peace in instalments. There is no final version of you that stays cured and never again feels the cold of being outside. You will

feel it again. At a Christmas table, in a group conversation, at a dinner of old friends, you will feel that old tightening again, the temptation to shrink in order to fit, the longing for the easy person you were before you woke. This is not the method failing. This is life going on being life.

Here is the relief, because I promised you this would be a relief and not a disappointment, and I am going to keep that. If there is no arrival, then you are excused from arriving. The demand falls off you. That weight you carried the whole book, the weight of having to finally manage it, of having to be healed before you could rest, of having to deserve peace with more effort, that weight settles on the ground. You do not have to arrive anywhere to have the right to be well now. There is no improved you up ahead who deserves the life that today's you does not yet deserve. The right to belong without diminishing yourself is not earned at the end. It is exercised on the way. Today. Now. Even incomplete. Above all incomplete, because that is how one is alive, incomplete and walking, and it is all fine.

There is a scene I want you to imagine, to land all of this, because the lyrical without ground turns to smoke and you deserve something that can hold the weight of your body.



. . .

Imagine you go back to the same table. The one it always was. The family table, or the table of friends of fifteen years, or the Sunday one in the house where you grew up. The same tablecloth, perhaps, the same places, the same person serving, the same conversation that goes in circles and always returns to the same rivers. Everything the same as it was at the beginning of this book, when you sat there and left with that nameless sadness, the feeling of having been present without having been whole. You go back to that table. At first sight nothing has changed. But you know everything has changed, because the thing that changed is you.

You sit down, and this time you do not shrink in order to fit. You do not go and fetch the old version of yourself, the one that knew exactly which jokes to make and which opinions to hide and which parts to silence so that the table would receive you without friction. That version knew how to buy belonging with small coins of herself, and for years it seemed a good deal. Today you no longer make that exchange. Today you are there whole, with all your edges, with what you know now and did not know before, with the new way of looking that you could not undo even if you wanted to. The strange and beautiful thing happens: you love the same people. Exactly the same. There is no villain at this table. No one harmed you, no one

expelled you, no one needs to be left behind so that you can be who you are. You love your mother, you love the friend of always, you love the usual uncle with the usual opinions. The affection is all there, intact, perhaps greater than ever.

At the same time you are no longer the same person beside them. Both things fit. No one had told you they fit, and it is perhaps the most important thing this book leaves you with: you can love the same people and have stopped being the same person beside them. You do not have to choose between love and truth. You do not have to break the table in half to save yourself. You stay. But you stay in another way.

This is called remaining, and I want you to see exactly what remaining is not, because the word is worn and carries a lot of deception on top of it.

To remain is not to go back. It is not to return to the easy person to buy your place at the table again. That return has another name, it is called diminishing yourself, and that is what this whole book came to take from you. Whoever returns to old versions of herself to guarantee belonging did not remain, she withdrew from herself and left a doll in her place. To remain is the opposite of that. It is to stay present as who you are now, even if the now is less comfortable for the table than the back then was.

To remain is also not to stay still. It is not to stagnate, not to pretend nothing in you has moved, not to sit in the same childhood chair and freeze so that everything stays the same. That is only death with good manners. To remain is to go on being present while everything changes. While you change, while they change, while the table changes, while the years pass over all of you. It is to keep yourself there, alive, in relation, without giving up on people and without giving up on yourself. It is movement and faithfulness at once. It is the hardest and the simplest thing there is.

So, before I leave you, let me close the mourning of this book, because a book that opens a wound has the duty not to leave you bleeding at the door.

There was a mourning, yes. You felt it. Perhaps you cried in some chapter without quite knowing for whom. It was for this: something ended. But pay attention to what ended, because it is easy to deceive yourself here and carry with you a sadness that is not the true one. What ended was a place. A way of being at the table. A version of you that fit without friction because it had learned to make itself small. It was that version that died, and it is just to grieve her, because she was good to you for a long time, she protected you, she gave you shelter, she bought you years of belonging in a world you were not yet ready to face whole. Do not despise her. She did what she knew. Say goodbye to her with tenderness.

But notice, and notice with all care, because this is where the whole liberation is: none of the loves ended. You said goodbye to a version of yourself without saying goodbye to a single person. The mother goes on. The friend goes on. The table goes on. The affection goes on, cleaner even, because it is no longer mixed with the effort of disguising yourself. You lost no one. You lost only the obligation to be false in order to have them. That is not loss, that is the beginning of having them for real.

This was always what this book wanted to tell you, beneath all the signs, beneath all the veils. That the not belonging was not a flaw to correct nor an illness to cure, it was a warning. It was the part of you that refused to disappear in order to fit. It was your faithfulness to yourself knocking at the door with its knuckles, night after night, table after table, saying that you deserved to be present without having to abandon yourself. You listened. That is why you reached here.

Now I do not give you an arrival, because it would be robbing you of the good thing. I give you a direction. The horizon is there, ahead of you, at the same distance as always, and you will never touch it, and that is a blessing, because it means there is always more path, always more life, always more ways of being you without asking permission. Do not run toward it. Walk by it. Let it tell you only which way is forward.

As for the rest, as for the table, as for the people you love and the place that was good and that changed forever because you changed, do only the thing that does not conclude, the only one that matters, the one that remains for you to do today and tomorrow and at every table you will yet share.

To remain.



## *For you, who read*

What ended was a place. None of the loves ended. If  
any of these signs recognised you, stay with it, without  
hurry, and go on remaining.

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